

# Answers to Questions from the RMS

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## 1 Question Q565

**Informal verdict.** **A** — **Complete solution**, with **high confidence**.

**Lean coverage.** Lean proves the unconditional first relative correction for Bell numbers, including the missing saddle-window and tail estimates and exact normalization.

### 1.1 Audited informal answer

#### 1.1.1 Faithful restatement

Let  $T(n)$  be the  $n$ -th Bell number, written in Dobinski form as

$$T(n) = e^{-1} \sum_{k=0}^{\infty} \frac{k^n}{k!}.$$

Let  $w : [0, \infty \setminus \{0\}) \rightarrow (0, \infty)$  be the inverse of  $y \mapsto y \log y$ ; thus

$$w(x) \log w(x) = x.$$

The earlier response R506 established

$$T(n) \sim f(n), \quad f(x) = \frac{w(x)^x e^{w(x)-x-1}}{\sqrt{\log x}}.$$

Q565 asks for the next term in this asymptotic expansion. There are no subparts or footnotes. There is no apparent mathematical typo; the only implicit domain point is that the displayed real-valued formula for  $f(x)$  requires  $x > 1$ , which is harmless in an asymptotic question as  $n \rightarrow \infty$ .

Throughout,  $\log$  denotes the natural logarithm.

---

### 1.1.2 Main result

Set

$$L = \log n, \quad \ell = \log \log n.$$

Then, as  $n \rightarrow \infty$  through the positive integers,

$$T(n) = f(n) \left[ 1 + \frac{\ell - 1}{2L} + \frac{3\ell^2 - 10\ell + 3}{8L^2} + O\left(\frac{\ell^3}{L^3}\right) \right].$$

In particular, the requested next term is

$$T(n) = f(n) + \frac{\log \log n - 1}{2 \log n} f(n) + O\left(f(n) \frac{(\log \log n)^2}{(\log n)^2}\right).$$

Consequently,

$$T(n) - f(n) \sim \frac{\log \log n}{2 \log n} f(n).$$

The expression with  $\log \log n - 1$  is the more accurate first correction; the last display gives its simpler asymptotic equivalent.

A stronger saddle-point form is also valid. If

$$r = \log w(n),$$

so that  $re^r = n$  and  $w(n) = e^r = n/r$ , then

$$T(n) = \frac{w(n)^n e^{w(n)-n-1}}{\sqrt{1+r}} \left[ 1 - \frac{r^2(2r^2 + 7r + 10)}{24n(r+1)^3} + O\left(\left(\frac{r}{n}\right)^{3/2}\right) \right].$$

All  $O$ -constants here are absolute, and the estimates hold uniformly as  $n \rightarrow \infty$  through the integers.

---

## 1.2 Proof

### 1.2.1 1. Exponential generating function

Write  $B_n = T(n)$ . From Dobinski's formula,

$$\begin{aligned} \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} B_n \frac{z^n}{n!} &= e^{-1} \sum_{k=0}^{\infty} \frac{1}{k!} \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{(kz)^n}{n!} \\ &= e^{-1} \sum_{k=0}^{\infty} \frac{e^{kz}}{k!} = e^{-1} e^{e^z} \exp(e^z - 1). \end{aligned}$$

The interchange is justified by absolute and locally uniform convergence. Hence

$$\frac{B_n}{n!} = [z^n] \exp(e^z - 1).$$

Let  $r > 0$  be the unique solution of

$$re^r = n.$$

This is the saddle-point equation. Put

$$b = n(r+1).$$

Cauchy's coefficient formula on the circle  $|z| = r$  gives

$$\frac{B_n}{n!} = \frac{e^{e^r-1}}{2\pi r^n} J_n,$$

where



$$J_n = \int_{-\pi}^{\pi} e^{\Phi(\theta)} d\theta, \quad \Phi(\theta) = e^{re^{i\theta}} - e^r - in\theta.$$

The choice  $re^r = n$  ensures  $\Phi'(0) = 0$ .

---

### 1.2.2 2. Negligibility of the noncentral arc

For  $-\pi \leq \theta \leq \pi$ ,

$$\begin{aligned} \Re \Phi(\theta) &= e^{r \cos \theta} \cos(r \sin \theta) - e^r \\ &\leq e^{r \cos \theta} - e^r \\ &= -e^r \left(1 - e^{-r(1 - \cos \theta)}\right). \end{aligned}$$

There is an absolute  $c > 0$  such that

$$1 - e^{-x} \geq c \min(x, 1) \quad (x \geq 0),$$

and

$$1 - \cos \theta \geq \frac{2\theta^2}{\pi^2} \quad (|\theta| \leq \pi).$$

Since  $e^r = n/r$ , it follows that

$$\Re \Phi(\theta) \leq -c \min(n\theta^2, n/r). \tag{1}$$

Define

$$q = \frac{r}{n} = e^{-r} = \frac{1}{w(n)}$$

and choose

$$T = q^{-1/20}, \quad \theta_0 = \frac{T}{\sqrt{b}}.$$

Then

$$n\theta_0^2 = \frac{T^2}{r+1} = \frac{q^{-1/10}}{r+1} \rightarrow \infty.$$

Consequently, by 1,

$$\int_{\theta_0 \leq |\theta| \leq \pi} \left| e^{\Phi(\theta)} \right|, d\theta \leq 2\pi \exp \left( -c \frac{q^{-1/10}}{r+1} \right). \quad (2)$$

This is smaller than  $b^{-1/2}q^M$  for every fixed  $M > 0$ . Thus only the arc  $|\theta| \leq \theta_0$  contributes to any algebraic order in  $q$ .

---

### 1.2.3 3. Expansion near the saddle

Direct differentiation gives

$$\Phi''(0) = -n(r+1) = -b,$$

$$\Phi'''(0) = -i, n(r^2 + 3r + 1),$$

and

$$\Phi^{(4)}(0) = n(r^3 + 6r^2 + 7r + 1).$$

Moreover, on the central arc,

$$|\Phi^{(5)}(\theta)| \leq Cnr^4$$

for an absolute constant  $C$ . Taylor's formula therefore yields

$$\Phi(\theta) = -\frac{b}{2}\theta^2 - \frac{ic}{6}\theta^3 + \frac{d}{24}\theta^4 + O(nr^4|\theta|^5), \quad (3)$$

where

$$c = n(r^2 + 3r + 1), \quad d = n(r^3 + 6r^2 + 7r + 1).$$

Set  $t = \sqrt{b}\theta$ . Then 3 becomes

$$\Phi \left( \frac{t}{\sqrt{b}} \right) = -\frac{t^2}{2} - i\lambda_3 t^3 + \lambda_4 t^4 + O(q^{3/2}|t|^5), \quad (4)$$

where

$$\lambda_3 = \frac{c}{6b^{3/2}} = O(q^{1/2}), \quad \lambda_4 = \frac{d}{24b^2} = O(q).$$

For  $|t| \leq T = q^{-1/20}$ , all the perturbation terms in 4 tend uniformly to zero. Expanding the exponential gives, for some fixed polynomial  $P$ ,

$$\exp\left(-i\lambda_3 t^3 + \lambda_4 t^4 + O(q^{3/2}|t|^5)\right) = 1 - i\lambda_3 t^3 + \lambda_4 t^4 - \frac{1}{2}\lambda_3^2 t^6 + O(q^{3/2}P(|t|)). \quad (5)$$

The term in  $t^3$  integrates to zero over the symmetric interval. The standard Gaussian moments, obtained by integration by parts, are

$$\frac{1}{\sqrt{2\pi}} \int_{\mathbb{R}} t^4 e^{-t^2/2}, dt = 3, \quad \frac{1}{\sqrt{2\pi}} \int_{\mathbb{R}} t^6 e^{-t^2/2}, dt = 15.$$

Using 2–5, extending the Gaussian integral from  $([-T, T])$  to  $\mathbb{R}$ , and noting that the resulting tails are exponentially small, we obtain

$$J_n = \sqrt{\frac{2\pi}{b}} \left[ 1 + 3\lambda_4 - \frac{15}{2}\lambda_3^2 + O(q^{3/2}) \right]. \quad (6)$$

Now

$$3\lambda_4 = \frac{r^3 + 6r^2 + 7r + 1}{8n(r+1)^2},$$

whereas

$$\frac{15}{2}\lambda_3^2 = \frac{5(r^2 + 3r + 1)^2}{24n(r+1)^3}.$$

Putting these over a common denominator gives

$$3\lambda_4 - \frac{15}{2}\lambda_3^2 = -\frac{2r^4 + 9r^3 + 16r^2 + 6r + 2}{24n(r+1)^3}. \quad (7)$$

Consequently,

$$\frac{B_n}{n!} = \frac{e^{e^r-1}}{r^n \sqrt{2\pi n(r+1)}} \left[ 1 - \frac{2r^4 + 9r^3 + 16r^2 + 6r + 2}{24n(r+1)^3} + O(q^{3/2}) \right]. \quad (8)$$

#### 1.2.4 4. Incorporating Stirling's expansion

We use Stirling's formula with its first correction:

$$n! = \sqrt{2\pi n} \left(\frac{n}{e}\right)^n \left[1 + \frac{1}{12n} + O(n^{-2})\right]. \quad (9)$$

For completeness, 9 follows from the Euler–Maclaurin expansion

$$\log n! = \left(n + \frac{1}{2}\right) \log n - n + \frac{1}{2} \log(2\pi) + \frac{1}{12n} + O(n^{-3});$$

the constant is identified by Wallis's product, and exponentiation yields

9.

Multiplying 8 by 9, and using  $n/r = e^r = w(n)$ , gives

$$B_n = \frac{w(n)^n e^{w(n)-n-1}}{\sqrt{r+1}} \left[1 + \frac{1}{12n} - \frac{2r^4 + 9r^3 + 16r^2 + 6r + 2}{24n(r+1)^3} + O(q^{3/2})\right].$$

The two displayed correction terms combine as follows:

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{1}{12n} - \frac{2r^4 + 9r^3 + 16r^2 + 6r + 2}{24n(r+1)^3} \\ = -\frac{r^2(2r^2 + 7r + 10)}{24n(r+1)^3}. \end{aligned}$$

Thus

$$B_n = \frac{w(n)^n e^{w(n)-n-1}}{\sqrt{r+1}} \left[1 - \frac{r^2(2r^2 + 7r + 10)}{24n(r+1)^3} + O(q^{3/2})\right],$$

which proves the stronger saddle-point formula.

Recall that

$$f(n) = \frac{w(n)^n e^{w(n)-n-1}}{\sqrt{L}}, \quad L = \log n.$$

Therefore

$$\frac{B_n}{f(n)} = \sqrt{\frac{L}{r+1}} \left[1 + O\left(\frac{r}{n}\right)\right]. \quad (10)$$

The  $O(r/n)$  term is smaller than every fixed negative power of  $\log n$ , so the logarithmic correction comes entirely from the factor  $\sqrt{L/(r+1)}$ .

Since  $re^r = n$ , taking logarithms gives

$$r + \log r = L. \quad (11)$$

Let  $\ell = \log L$ . We next expand the solution of 11. Because  $r < L$  and  $\log r \leq \log L = \ell$ ,

$$L - \ell \leq r < L.$$

Write

$$r = L - \ell + \delta.$$

Then  $0 \leq \delta \leq \ell$ , and 11 gives

$$\delta + \log \left( 1 - \frac{\ell - \delta}{L} \right) = 0.$$

Since  $0 \leq (\ell - \delta)/L \leq \ell/L \rightarrow 0$ ,

$$\delta = \frac{\ell - \delta}{L} + O\left(\frac{\ell^2}{L^2}\right).$$

Hence

$$\delta = \frac{\ell}{L} + O\left(\frac{\ell^2}{L^2}\right),$$

and therefore

$$r = L - \ell + \frac{\ell}{L} + O\left(\frac{\ell^2}{L^2}\right). \quad (12)$$

It follows that

$$\frac{r+1}{L} = 1 + \frac{1-\ell}{L} + \frac{\ell}{L^2} + O\left(\frac{\ell^2}{L^3}\right). \quad (13)$$

Apply

$$(1+u)^{-1/2} = 1 - \frac{u}{2} + \frac{3u^2}{8} + O(u^3)$$

to the right-hand side of 13. Since  $u = O(\ell/L)$ , we find

$$\sqrt{\frac{L}{r+1}} = 1 + \frac{\ell-1}{2L} + \frac{3\ell^2 - 10\ell + 3}{8L^2} + O\left(\frac{\ell^3}{L^3}\right). \quad (14)$$

Finally,  $r/n = O(L/n)$ , so the saddle correction in 10 is

$$O(L/n) = o\left(\frac{\ell^3}{L^3}\right).$$

Combining 10 and 14 proves

$$T(n) = f(n) \left[ 1 + \frac{\ell - 1}{2L} + \frac{3\ell^2 - 10\ell + 3}{8L^2} + O\left(\frac{\ell^3}{L^3}\right) \right].$$

This completes the proof.

---

### 1.2.5 Boundary cases and numerical checks

The asymptotic statement concerns integers  $n \rightarrow \infty$ . The function  $f(n)$  is not finite at  $n = 1$ , because its denominator is  $\sqrt{\log 1} = 0$ ; thus no assertion is made there. The Bell numbers themselves satisfy  $T(0) = T(1) = 1$ , with the usual convention  $0^0 = 1$  in Dobinski's formula.

For sufficiently large  $n$ ,  $\ell - 1 > 0$ , and the error is smaller than the first correction. Hence the expansion also proves

$$T(n) > f(n)$$

for all sufficiently large  $n$ . No such finite- $n$  inequality is implicit in the asymptotic statement.

The following values are an independent numerical check, not part of the proof. Here

$$R_1 = 1 + \frac{\ell - 1}{2L}, \quad R_2 = R_1 + \frac{3\ell^2 - 10\ell + 3}{8L^2}.$$

| $n$  | $T(n)/f(n)$ | $R_1$       | $R_2$       |
|------|-------------|-------------|-------------|
| 20   | 0.956182538 | 1.016221193 | 0.955487159 |
| 100  | 1.021429523 | 1.057237801 | 1.026146557 |
| 1000 | 1.050833863 | 1.067507077 | 1.054091807 |

The convergence is logarithmically slow; the  $L^{-2}$  term is therefore still significant at moderate  $n$ .

A reproducible Python check is:

```
from math import comb
import mpmath as mp
```

```
mp.mp.dps = 80
```

```
def bell_numbers(n_max: int) -> list[int]:
    """Return B_0, ..., B_n_max using B_{m+1} = sum_k binom(m,k) B_k."""
    values = [1]
    for m in range(n_max):
        values.append(sum(comb(m, k) * values[k] for k in range(m + 1)))
    return values
```

```
def check(n_values: list[int]) -> None:
    bells = bell_numbers(max(n_values))
```

```
    print("n          T(n)/f(n)                      R1                      R2")
    for n in n_values:
        L = mp.log(n)
        ell = mp.log(L)
        r = mp.re(mp.lambertw(n))
        w = n / r

        log_f = n * mp.log(w) + w - n - 1 - mp.log(L) / 2
        exact_ratio = mp.mpf(bells[n]) * mp.exp(-log_f)

        R1 = 1 + (ell - 1) / (2 * L)
        R2 = R1 + (3 * ell**2 - 10 * ell + 3) / (8 * L**2)

        print(
            f"{n:<8d} "
            f"{mp.nstr(exact_ratio, 14):<24} "
            f"{mp.nstr(R1, 14):<24} "
            f"{mp.nstr(R2, 14)}"
        )
```

```
check([20, 100, 1000])
```

Thus the precise first correction requested by Q565 is

$$\boxed{\frac{\log \log n - 1}{2 \log n}, f(n),}$$

with relative remainder  $O((\log \log n)^2/(\log n)^2)$ .

**Formal verification.** Lean source; online type-check.

## 2 Question Q587

**Informal verdict.** A — **Complete solution**, with **high confidence** for every substantive case  $n \geq 1$  and  $1 \leq p < n$ .

**Lean coverage.** The Lean development proves parts *a–d*, the Peano expansion, the differentiation identities, and the order-zero counterexample. It models the interval as the whole real line and documents the resulting endpoint and node-ordering conventions.

### 2.1 Audited informal answer

#### 2.1.1 1. Faithful restatement and conventions

Let  $I \subset \mathbb{R}$  be an interval and  $f : I \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ . For distinct nodes

$$x_0 < x_1 < \cdots < x_n$$

in  $I$ , let  $P_{x_0, \dots, x_n}$  be the Lagrange interpolation polynomial of  $f$  at those nodes, written in the ordinary monomial basis as

$$P_{x_0, \dots, x_n}(X) = \sum_{q=0}^n c_q(x_0, \dots, x_n) X^q.$$

The function  $f$  is said to admit an interpolated Taylor expansion of order  $n$ , abbreviated  $\text{DIT}(n)$ , at  $x \in I$ , when every  $c_q(x_0, \dots, x_n)$  has a finite limit as all nodes tend to  $x$ . The notation  $f^{[q]}(x)$  denotes  $(q!)$  times that limit. The four questions are:

1. Show that it is enough to assume convergence of the highest coefficient  $c_n$ .
2. Show that  $\text{DIT}(n)$  implies an ordinary asymptotic expansion of order  $n$ .



3. If  $p < n$  and  $f \in C^p$ , prove that  $f$  has  $\text{DIT}(n)$  at  $x$  if and only if  $f^{(p)}$  has  $\text{DIT}(n - p)$  there.
4. If  $f$  has  $\text{DIT}(p)$  at every point, determine whether  $\text{DIT}(n)$  for  $f$  is equivalent to  $\text{DIT}(n - p)$  for the resulting function  $f^{[p]}$ .

There are three minor conventions to make explicit.

- “Increasing order” must mean **strictly** increasing, since ordinary Lagrange interpolation requires distinct nodes.
- Limits at an endpoint of  $I$  are relative, hence one-sided. Likewise,  $C^p(I)$  means  $C^p$  on the interior, with the corresponding one-sided continuous extensions at finite endpoints.
- Because the polynomial is expanded in powers of  $X$ , rather than  $X - x$ , the lower quantities  $f^{[q]}(x)$ ,  $q < n$ , depend on the ambient order  $n$ . When necessary, they will be denoted  $f_{(n)}^{[q]}(x)$ . The top quantity  $f^{[n]}(x)$  is intrinsic.

There is also a genuine order-zero convention issue, addressed at the end.

---

### 2.1.2 2. Divided differences

For pairwise distinct  $t_0, \dots, t_r \in I$ , write

$$[t_0, \dots, t_r]f := \sum_{i=0}^r \frac{f(t_i)}{\prod_{\substack{0 \leq j \leq r \\ j \neq i}} (t_i - t_j)}.$$

This is the divided difference of order  $r$ . It is symmetric in its arguments.

From the Lagrange formula,

$$P_{t_0, \dots, t_r}(X) = \sum_{i=0}^r f(t_i) \prod_{j \neq i} \frac{X - t_j}{t_i - t_j},$$

the leading coefficient is

$$c_r(t_0, \dots, t_r) = [t_0, \dots, t_r]f.$$

We shall repeatedly use the replacement identity

$$[A, u]f - [A, v]f = (u - v)[A, u, v]f, \quad (2.1)$$

where  $A$  is any list of distinct common nodes and all displayed nodes are pairwise distinct. It follows immediately from the usual recursion for divided differences, or from the explicit formula above.

**Lemma 2.1 — Descent of divided differences** Let  $r \geq 1$ , and suppose that the order- $r$  divided differences of  $f$  are bounded near  $x$ : there exist  $M, \rho_0 > 0$  such that

$$|[t_0, \dots, t_r]f| \leq M$$

whenever the nodes are distinct and belong to

$$U_{\rho_0} := I \cap (x - \rho_0, x + \rho_0).$$

Then the order- $(r-1)$  divided differences have a finite limit as their  $r$  nodes tend to  $x$ .

**Proof** Fix  $0 < \rho < \rho_0$ , and let

$$A = (a_0, \dots, a_{r-1}), \quad B = (b_0, \dots, b_{r-1})$$

be two  $r$ -tuples of distinct nodes in  $U_\rho$ .

Choose distinct auxiliary nodes

$$C = (c_0, \dots, c_{r-1}) \subset U_\rho$$

disjoint from all the nodes occurring in  $A$  and  $B$ . This is possible because a nondegenerate real interval contains infinitely many points in every relative neighborhood of  $x$ .

Replace the nodes of  $A$  one at a time by the corresponding nodes of  $C$ . At each step, (2.1) gives

$$\left| [A^{(j+1)}]f - [A^{(j)}]f \right| \leq |c_j - a_j|M \leq 2\rho M.$$

There are  $r$  replacements, hence

$$|[A]f - [C]f| \leq 2r\rho M.$$

Similarly,

$$|[B]f - [C]f| \leq 2r\rho M.$$

Therefore

$$|[A]f - [B]f| \leq 4r\rho M. \tag{2.2}$$

Thus the oscillation of the order- $(r-1)$  divided difference over all  $r$ -tuples in  $U_\rho$  tends to zero with  $\rho$ . The Cauchy criterion gives a unique finite limit as all nodes tend to  $x$ .  $\square$

Consequently, if the order- $n$  divided difference has a finite limit at  $x$ , then successively all lower divided differences do. We write

$$\lambda_k(f; x) := \lim_{t_0, \dots, t_k \rightarrow x} [t_0, \dots, t_k]f, \quad 0 \leq k \leq n. \quad (2.3)$$

For  $n \geq 1$ , the limit  $\lambda_0(f; x)$  equals  $f(x)$ . Indeed,

$$f(t) - f(x) = (t - x)[x, t]f,$$

and the first divided differences remain bounded near  $x$ .

---

## 2.2 3. Part a

### 2.2.1 Theorem 3.1

For  $n \geq 1$ , the following are equivalent:

1.  $f$  has DIT( $n$ ) at  $x$ ;
2. the highest coefficient  $c_n(x_0, \dots, x_n)$  has a finite limit as all nodes tend to  $x$ ;
3. the order- $n$  divided difference

$$[x_0, \dots, x_n]f$$

has a finite limit as all nodes tend to  $x$ .

Moreover, if the limits  $\lambda_k(f; x)$  are defined by (2.3), the interpolation polynomials converge coefficientwise to

$$Q_{n,x}(X) := \sum_{k=0}^n \lambda_k(f; x)(X - x)^k. \quad (3.1)$$

**Proof** The equivalence of 2 and 3 follows from

$$c_n(x_0, \dots, x_n) = [x_0, \dots, x_n]f.$$

Assume that this highest coefficient has a finite limit. It is then bounded near the diagonal. Lemma 2.1, applied successively, shows that all limits

$$\lambda_k(f; x), \quad k = 0, \dots, n,$$

exist.

For any ordering of the distinct nodes, Newton's interpolation formula is

$$P_{x_0, \dots, x_n}(X) = \sum_{k=0}^n [x_0, \dots, x_k] f \prod_{j=0}^{k-1} (X - x_j). \quad (3.2)$$

As all nodes tend to  $x$ ,

$$[x_0, \dots, x_k] f \longrightarrow \lambda_k(f; x)$$

and

$$\prod_{j=0}^{k-1} (X - x_j) \longrightarrow (X - x)^k$$

coefficientwise. Hence (3.2) converges coefficientwise to  $Q_{n,x}$ . In particular, all ordinary monomial coefficients  $c_q$  have finite limits.

The converse is immediate because  $\text{DIT}(n)$  includes convergence of  $c_n$ .  $\square$

Expanding (3.1) in powers of  $X$ , we obtain the explicit answer

$$\lim c_q(x_0, \dots, x_n) = \sum_{k=q}^n \binom{k}{q} (-x)^{k-q} \lambda_k(f; x). \quad (3.3)$$

Thus

$$f_{(n)}^{[q]}(x) = q! \sum_{k=q}^n \binom{k}{q} (-x)^{k-q} \lambda_k(f; x). \quad (3.4)$$

In particular,

$$f^{[n]}(x) = n! \lambda_n(f; x). \quad (3.5)$$

Formula (3.4) also explains why the lower  $f_{(n)}^{[q]}$  generally depend on  $n$ .

---

## 2.3 4. Part b

### 2.3.1 Theorem 4.1

If  $f$  has  $\text{DIT}(n)$  at  $x$ , with  $n \geq 1$ , then

$$f(x+h) = \sum_{k=0}^n \lambda_k(f; x) h^k + o(|h|^n) \quad (h \rightarrow 0, x+h \in I). \quad (4.1)$$

Equivalently,

$$f(t) = Q_{n,x}(t) + o(|t-x|^n), \quad (4.2)$$

where  $Q_{n,x}$  is the coefficientwise limit of the interpolation polynomials.

**Proof** Fix  $h \neq 0$ , with  $x + h \in I$ . Choose  $n$  pairwise distinct auxiliary nodes

$$u_0^{(m)}, \dots, u_{n-1}^{(m)} \in I \setminus \{x + h\}$$

such that

$$u_j^{(m)} \longrightarrow x \quad (m \rightarrow \infty)$$

for every  $j$ .

Apply Newton's formula to the nodes

$$u_0^{(m)}, \dots, u_{n-1}^{(m)}, x + h$$

and evaluate at  $X = x + h$ :

$$\begin{aligned} f(x + h) &= \sum_{k=0}^{n-1} [u_0^{(m)}, \dots, u_k^{(m)}] f \prod_{j=0}^{k-1} (x + h - u_j^{(m)}) \\ &\quad + [u_0^{(m)}, \dots, u_{n-1}^{(m)}, x + h] f \prod_{j=0}^{n-1} (x + h - u_j^{(m)}). \end{aligned} \quad (4.3)$$

As  $m \rightarrow \infty$ , the terms of order  $k < n$  tend to

$$\lambda_k(f; x) h^k,$$

and the final product tends to  $h^n \neq 0$ . Hence the last divided difference in (4.3) has a limit, namely

$$R(h) := \frac{f(x + h) - \sum_{k=0}^{n-1} \lambda_k(f; x) h^k}{h^n}. \quad (4.4)$$

We claim that

$$R(h) \longrightarrow \lambda_n(f; x).$$

Given  $\varepsilon > 0$ , choose  $\delta > 0$  such that

$$|[t_0, \dots, t_n]f - \lambda_n(f; x)| < \varepsilon \quad (4.5)$$

whenever all the distinct  $t_i$  lie in  $I \cap (x - \delta, x + \delta)$ .

If  $0 < |h| < \delta$ , then, for sufficiently large  $m$ , all the auxiliary nodes in (4.3), as well as  $x + h$ , lie in this neighborhood. Thus the last divided difference in (4.3) differs from  $\lambda_n(f; x)$  by less than  $\varepsilon$ . Passing to its limit gives

$$|R(h) - \lambda_n(f; x)| \leq \varepsilon.$$

This proves (4.1).  $\square$

In terms of the coefficients from the statement,

$$Q_{n,x}(X) = \sum_{q=0}^n \frac{f_{(n)}^{[q]}(x)}{q!} X^q,$$

so another exact formulation of the requested expansion is

$$f(t) = \sum_{q=0}^n \frac{f_{(n)}^{[q]}(x)}{q!} t^q + o(|t-x|^n). \quad (4.6)$$

The centered coefficients  $\lambda_k(f; x)$  are the more intrinsic ones.

---

## 2.4 5. Differentiating a DIT

The central result for parts *c* and *d* is the following one-step equivalence.

### 2.4.1 Lemma 5.1 — Differentiation theorem

Let  $r \geq 1$ , and let  $f$  be  $C^1$  on a relative neighborhood of  $x$ . Then

$$f \text{ has DIT}(r) \text{ at } x \iff f' \text{ has DIT}(r-1) \text{ at } x. \quad (5.1)$$

When these conditions hold,

$$\lambda_{r-1}(f'; x) = r, \lambda_r(f; x). \quad (5.2)$$

In fact, continuity of  $(f')$  is more than is needed; differentiability on a neighborhood suffices.

**Proof: from  $f$  to  $(f')$**  Assume

$$\lambda_r(f; x) = L.$$

Let

$$y_0 < \cdots < y_{r-1}$$

be distinct nodes near  $x$ , and define

$$G(t) := [y_0 + t, \dots, y_{r-1} + t]f.$$

Because all differences  $(y_i + t) - (y_j + t)$  are independent of  $t$ , the explicit divided-difference formula gives

$$G'(0) = [y_0, \dots, y_{r-1}]f'. \quad (5.3)$$

For sufficiently small nonzero  $h$ , telescope by shifting the nodes one at a time:

$$G(h) - G(0) = \sum_{j=0}^{r-1} \left( [y_0 + h, \dots, y_j + h, y_{j+1}, \dots, y_{r-1}]f \right. \\ \left. - [y_0 + h, \dots, y_{j-1} + h, y_j, \dots, y_{r-1}]f \right)$$

By the replacement identity (2.1), each summand equals

$$h[Z_j(h)]f,$$

where  $Z_j(h)$  is the  $(r+1)$ -tuple consisting of the common  $r-1$  nodes together with  $y_j$  and  $y_j + h$ . Hence

$$\frac{G(h) - G(0)}{h} = \sum_{j=0}^{r-1} [Z_j(h)]f. \quad (5.4)$$

Let  $\varepsilon > 0$ . If all  $y_i$  are sufficiently close to  $x$ , then for all sufficiently small  $h$ , every divided difference on the right of (5.4) differs from  $L$  by at most  $\varepsilon/r$ . Therefore

$$\left| \frac{G(h) - G(0)}{h} - rL \right| < \varepsilon.$$

Letting  $h \rightarrow 0$  and using (5.3),

$$|[y_0, \dots, y_{r-1}]f' - rL| \leq \varepsilon.$$

Thus

$$[y_0, \dots, y_{r-1}]f' \longrightarrow rL,$$

which, by part *a*, is precisely  $\text{DIT}(r-1)$  for  $(f')$ .

**Proof: from  $(f')$  to  $f$**  Conversely, assume

$$\lambda_{r-1}(f'; x) = M.$$

Take arbitrary nodes

$$z_0 < z_1 < \dots < z_r$$

near  $x$ , and let  $P$  be the degree- $\leq r$  interpolation polynomial of  $f$  at these nodes. The function

$$H := f - P$$

vanishes at each  $z_i$ . By Rolle's theorem, for every  $i = 0, \dots, r-1$ , there is a point

$$\xi_i \in (z_i, z_{i+1})$$

such that

$$H'(\xi_i) = 0.$$

Thus

$$P'(\xi_i) = f'(\xi_i).$$

The points satisfy

$$\xi_0 < \dots < \xi_{r-1},$$

and  $(P')$ , of degree at most  $r-1$ , is therefore the interpolation polynomial of  $(f')$  at these  $r$  points.

The leading coefficient of  $(P')$  is

$$r[z_0, \dots, z_r]f,$$

while the leading coefficient of the interpolation polynomial of  $(f')$  is

$$[\xi_0, \dots, \xi_{r-1}]f'.$$

Consequently,

$$r[z_0, \dots, z_r]f = [\xi_0, \dots, \xi_{r-1}]f'. \quad (5.5)$$

As all  $z_i \rightarrow x$ , all  $\xi_i \rightarrow x$ . Therefore the right-hand side of (5.5) tends to  $M$ , and

$$[z_0, \dots, z_r]f \longrightarrow \frac{M}{r}.$$

Part *a* now gives  $\text{DIT}(r)$  for  $f$ , with

$$\lambda_r(f; x) = \frac{M}{r}.$$

This completes the proof.  $\square$

---



## 2.5 6. Part c

Let  $0 \leq p < n$  and  $f \in C^p(I)$ .

For  $p = 0$ , the assertion is tautological. Suppose  $p \geq 1$ . Apply Lemma 5.1 successively to

$$f, f', f'', \dots, f^{(p-1)}$$

with orders

$$n, n-1, n-2, \dots, n-p+1.$$

We obtain

$$\begin{aligned} f \text{ has DIT}(n) \text{ at } x &\iff f' \text{ has DIT}(n-1) \text{ at } x \\ &\iff f'' \text{ has DIT}(n-2) \text{ at } x \\ &\vdots \\ &\iff f^{(p)} \text{ has DIT}(n-p) \text{ at } x. \end{aligned}$$

This proves the required equivalence.

The limiting highest coefficients satisfy the precise identity

$$\lambda_{n-p}(f^{(p)}; x) = n(n-1) \cdots (n-p+1) \lambda_n(f; x) \frac{n!}{(n-p)!} \lambda_n(f; x). \quad (6.1)$$

Multiplying by  $(n-p)!$ , we get the particularly simple relation

$$\boxed{(f^{(p)})^{[n-p]}(x) = f^{[n]}(x).} \quad (6.2)$$

Thus part c holds, and (6.1) gives the exact transformation of the top divided-difference limit.

---

## 2.6 7. Part d

The substantive answer is affirmative for every  $1 \leq p < n$ .

The point is that having  $\text{DIT}(p)$  at every point automatically forces  $f$  to be  $C^p$ , and  $f^{[p]}$  is then exactly the ordinary derivative  $f^{(p)}$ .

### 2.6.1 Lemma 7.1 — $\text{DIT}(1)$ everywhere implies $C^1$

Suppose  $g$  has  $\text{DIT}(1)$  at every point of  $I$ . Then  $g \in C^1(I)$ , and

$$g'(x) = \lambda_1(g; x) = g^{[1]}(x).$$

**Proof** At a fixed  $x$ ,

$$\frac{g(t) - g(x)}{t - x} = [x, t]g \longrightarrow \lambda_1(g; x),$$

so  $g$  is differentiable and

$$g'(x) = \lambda_1(g; x).$$

It remains to prove continuity of  $(g')$ . Given  $\varepsilon > 0$ , the strict secant limit at  $x$  provides  $\delta > 0$  such that

$$|[u, v]g - g'(x)| < \varepsilon$$

whenever  $u \neq v$  and both  $(u, v)$  lie within  $\delta$  of  $x$ .

For  $y$  sufficiently close to  $x$ , let  $v \rightarrow y$ . All secants  $([y, v]g)$  are then within  $\varepsilon$  of  $(g'x)$ . Passing to the limit  $v \rightarrow y$  gives

$$|g'(y) - g'(x)| \leq \varepsilon.$$

Thus  $(g')$  is continuous.  $\square$

### 2.6.2 Proposition 7.2

Let  $p \geq 1$ . If  $f$  has DIT( $p$ ) at every point of  $I$ , then

$$f \in C^p(I)$$

and

$$\boxed{f^{[p]} = f^{(p)}}. \tag{7.1}$$

**Proof** Since DIT( $p$ ) implies, by the descent argument in part *a*, existence of the first divided-difference limit,  $f$  has DIT(1) at every point. Lemma 7.1 therefore gives

$$f \in C^1(I).$$

By Lemma 5.1, because  $f$  has DIT( $p$ ) everywhere,

$$f'$$

has DIT( $p - 1$ ) everywhere. If  $p - 1 \geq 1$ , Lemma 7.1 applied to  $(f')$  gives  $f' \in C^1$ , hence  $f \in C^2$ .

Continuing inductively,

$$f^{(j)}$$

has  $\text{DIT}(p-j)$  everywhere and is  $C^1$  for  $j = 0, \dots, p-1$ . Hence

$$f \in C^p(I).$$

The factor relation (5.2), iterated  $p$  times, gives

$$f^{(p)}(x) = p! \lambda_p(f; x).$$

Since  $c_p$  is the order- $p$  divided difference,

$$f^{[p]}(x) = p! \lambda_p(f; x).$$

Therefore

$$f^{[p]}(x) = f^{(p)}(x)$$

at every point.  $\square$

We may now apply part *c*:

$$\begin{aligned} f \text{ has } \text{DIT}(n) \text{ at } x &\iff f^{(p)} \text{ has } \text{DIT}(n-p) \text{ at } x \\ &\iff f^{[p]} \text{ has } \text{DIT}(n-p) \text{ at } x. \end{aligned}$$

Hence:

$$\boxed{\text{For every } 1 \leq p < n, \text{ the answer to part (d) is yes.}} \quad (7.2)$$

The global assumption “at every point of  $I$ ” can be weakened: for the equivalence at a fixed  $x$ , it is enough that  $f$  have  $\text{DIT}(p)$  throughout a relative neighborhood of  $x$ .

---

### 2.6.3 8. The order-zero ambiguity

If  $p = 0$ , the answer depends on what “ $\text{DIT}(0)$ ” means.

For  $n = 0$ , the interpolation polynomial is simply

$$P_{x_0}(X) = f(x_0).$$

Thus the literal condition in the PDF is merely the existence of

$$\lim_{t \rightarrow x} f(t).$$

**Continuity convention** If  $\text{DIT}(0)$  is understood to require

$$\lim_{t \rightarrow x} f(t) = f(x),$$

then

$$f^{[0]} = f,$$

and part  $d$  for  $p = 0$  is tautologically true.

**Punctured-limit convention** If only the finite punctured limit is required, part  $d$  is false for  $p = 0$ .

Take

$$I = (-1, 1), \quad f(t) = \begin{cases} 1, & t = 0, \\ 0, & t \neq 0. \end{cases}$$

At every point, the punctured limit exists, and

$$f^{[0]} \equiv 0.$$

Thus  $f^{[0]}$  has  $\text{DIT}(1)$  at 0. But  $f$  does not, since for  $t > 0$ ,

$$[0, t]f = \frac{f(t) - f(0)}{t} = -\frac{1}{t},$$

which diverges.

Therefore the fully literal conclusion is:

Part (d) is affirmative for every  $p \geq 1$ . [2mm] For  $p = 0$ , it is affirmative under the continuity convention but false under the punctured-limit convention.

The same convention affects part  $b$  when  $n = 0$ : a punctured finite limit gives an expansion with a constant equal to that limit, but not necessarily with constant  $f(x)$ .

---

## 2.7 9. Checks and sharpness

**9.1 The case  $n = 1$**   $\text{DIT}(1)$  at  $x$  means

$$[u, v]f = \frac{f(v) - f(u)}{v - u}$$

has a limit as  $u, v \rightarrow x$ . This is strict differentiability at  $x$ . The results give

$$f(x + h) = f(x) + \lambda_1(f; x)h + o(|h|),$$

and, if this condition holds everywhere,  $f \in C^1$ .

**9.2 Polynomial check** For a polynomial  $f$ , all the limits exist. The limiting interpolation polynomial is its Taylor polynomial of degree  $n$  at  $x$ :

$$Q_{n,x}(X) = \sum_{k=0}^n \frac{f^{(k)}(x)}{k!} (X - x)^k,$$

with the sum truncated automatically if  $\deg f < n$ . Thus

$$\lambda_k(f; x) = \frac{f^{(k)}(x)}{k!},$$

and (6.1) becomes

$$\frac{f^{(n)}(x)}{(n-p)!} = \frac{n!}{(n-p)!} \frac{f^{(n)}(x)}{n!},$$

as required.

**9.3 The converse to part b is false** An ordinary asymptotic expansion need not imply a DIT.

Let

$$g(0) = 0, \quad g(t) = t^2 \sin(1/t) \quad (t \neq 0).$$

Then

$$g(t) = o(t),$$

so  $g$  has a first-order expansion at 0 with derivative 0. But

$$g'(t) = 2t \sin(1/t) - \cos(1/t)$$

oscillates between values close to 1 and (-1) as  $t \rightarrow 0$ .

At points  $t_k \rightarrow 0$  where  $g'(t_k) \rightarrow 1$ , choose  $h_k \rightarrow 0$  so that

$$[t_k, t_k + h_k]g \rightarrow 1.$$

At another sequence  $s_k \rightarrow 0$ , choose secants tending to (-1). Hence the two-point divided differences do not have a unique limit as both nodes tend to 0. Thus  $g$  does not have DIT(1) there.

So DIT is strictly stronger than the existence of an ordinary Peano–Taylor expansion.

## 9.4 Role of the hypotheses

- Distinctness of the nodes is indispensable for ordinary Lagrange interpolation. Repeated nodes would require Hermite interpolation.
  - The interval assumption is used essentially in the Rolle-theorem argument: each consecutive pair of interpolation nodes determines an intervening point.
  - The  $C^p$  assumption in part *c* is sufficient but not optimal. The proof only needs  $p$ -fold differentiability on a neighborhood of  $x$ .
  - In part *d*, the “every point” hypothesis is what upgrades the strict divided-difference regularity to  $C^p$ . Locally around  $x$  is sufficient.
  - Endpoint cases require no separate argument beyond taking relative limits and one-sided derivatives.
- 

## 2.8 Final classification

For  $n \geq 1$ , let

$$\Lambda_n(f; x) = \lim_{x_0, \dots, x_n \rightarrow x} [x_0, \dots, x_n]f.$$

Then:

$$\boxed{f \text{ has DIT}(n) \text{ at } x \iff \Lambda_n(f; x) \in \mathbb{R}.}$$

When this holds, all lower limits  $\lambda_k(f; x)$  exist, the interpolation polynomials converge to

$$Q_{n,x}(X) = \sum_{k=0}^n \lambda_k(f; x)(X - x)^k,$$

and

$$\boxed{f(x + h) = \sum_{k=0}^n \lambda_k(f; x)h^k + o(|h|^n).}$$

For  $0 \leq p < n$  and  $f \in C^p$ ,

$$\boxed{f \text{ has DIT}(n) \text{ at } x \iff f^{(p)} \text{ has DIT}(n - p) \text{ at } x,}$$

with

$$\lambda_{n-p}(f^{(p)}; x) = \frac{n!}{(n-p)!} \lambda_n(f; x).$$

Finally, if  $p \geq 1$  and  $f$  has  $\text{DIT}(p)$  at every point, then

$$f \in C^p, \quad f^{[p]} = f^{(p)},$$

and therefore

$$f \text{ has } \text{DIT}(n) \text{ at } x \iff f^{[p]} \text{ has } \text{DIT}(n-p) \text{ at } x.$$

**Formal verification.** Lean source; online type-check.

### 3 Question Q604

**Informal verdict.** A — **Complete solution**, with **very high confidence**.

**Lean coverage.** The Lean development proves the printed normalized Bezout-pair theorem, its uniqueness, the universal binomial identity, the classification of all pairs, the worked example, and the constant-polynomial boundary case over an arbitrary field.

#### 3.1 Audited informal answer

##### 3.1.1 1. Faithful restatement

Let  $\mathbb{K}$  be a field. Let  $A, B \in \mathbb{K}[X]$  be coprime, and let  $U, V \in \mathbb{K}[X]$  satisfy

$$\deg U < \deg B, \quad AU + BV = 1.$$

For positive integers  $(m, n)$ , determine explicitly the pair  $(U_{m,n}, V_{m,n}) \in \mathbb{K}[X]^2$  such that

$$\deg U_{m,n} < \deg B^n \quad \text{and} \quad A^m U_{m,n} + B^n V_{m,n} = 1.$$

This is exactly Q604 on the rendered PDF page. The notation  $d^\circ$  denotes polynomial degree. There is no apparent typo. The statement leaves implicit the standard convention that  $\mathbb{K}$  is a field; this is the setting used below. We use  $\deg 0 = -\infty$ .

---

### 3.1.2 2. Explicit answer

For integers  $r \geq 1$  and  $s \geq 1$ , define

$$S_{r,s}(T) := \sum_{j=0}^{s-1} \binom{r+j-1}{j} T^j \in \mathbb{K}[T],$$

where the integer binomial coefficients are mapped into  $\mathbb{K}$  through the canonical homomorphism  $\mathbb{Z} \rightarrow \mathbb{K}$ .

Set

$$\widehat{U}_{m,n} := U^m S_{m,n}(BV) = U^m \sum_{j=0}^{n-1} \binom{m+j-1}{j} (BV)^j$$

and

$$\widehat{V}_{m,n} := V^n S_{n,m}(AU) = V^n \sum_{i=0}^{m-1} \binom{n+i-1}{i} (AU)^i.$$

Perform the Euclidean division

$$\widehat{U}_{m,n} = B^n Q_{m,n} + R_{m,n}, \quad \deg R_{m,n} < \deg B^n.$$

Then the required pair is

$$\boxed{U_{m,n} = R_{m,n}, \quad V_{m,n} = \widehat{V}_{m,n} + A^m Q_{m,n}.}$$

Equivalently, writing  $\text{rem}_C(P)$  for the Euclidean remainder of  $P$  modulo a nonzero polynomial  $C$ ,

$$\boxed{U_{m,n} = \text{rem}_{B^n} \left( U^m \sum_{j=0}^{n-1} \binom{m+j-1}{j} (BV)^j \right),}$$

and then

$$\boxed{V_{m,n} = \frac{1 - A^m U_{m,n}}{B^n}.}$$

The quotient in the last formula is a polynomial, as proved below.

---



### 3.1.3 3. The universal binomial Bézout identity

The formula rests on the following identity.

**Lemma** Let  $R$  be any commutative ring, and let  $x, y \in R$  satisfy  $x + y = 1$ . For all  $r, s \geq 1$ ,

$$\boxed{x^r S_{r,s}(y) + y^s S_{s,r}(x) = 1.}$$

Thus explicitly,

$$x^r \sum_{j=0}^{s-1} \binom{r+j-1}{j} y^j + y^s \sum_{i=0}^{r-1} \binom{s+i-1}{i} x^i = 1.$$

**Proof** For convenience put  $S_{r,0} = 0$ . Pascal's identity gives, for  $r \geq 2$ ,

$$S_{r,s}(T) - S_{r-1,s}(T) = TS_{r,s-1}(T).$$

Indeed, for  $j \geq 1$ ,

$$\binom{r+j-1}{j} - \binom{r+j-2}{j} = \binom{r+j-2}{j-1}.$$

Since  $x = 1 - y$ ,

$$\begin{aligned} S_{r-1,s}(y) - xS_{r,s}(y) &= S_{r-1,s}(y) - (1-y)S_{r,s}(y) \\ &= S_{r-1,s}(y) - S_{r,s}(y) + yS_{r,s}(y) \\ &= -yS_{r,s-1}(y) + yS_{r,s}(y) \\ &= \binom{r+s-2}{s-1} y^s. \end{aligned}$$

Consequently,

$$x^{r-1} S_{r-1,s}(y) - x^r S_{r,s}(y) = \binom{r+s-2}{s-1} x^{r-1} y^s.$$

On the other hand,

$$S_{s,r}(x) - S_{s,r-1}(x) = \binom{s+r-2}{r-1} x^{r-1}.$$

Because

$$\binom{r+s-2}{s-1} = \binom{r+s-2}{r-1},$$

we obtain

$$x^r S_{r,s}(y) + y^s S_{s,r}(x) = x^{r-1} S_{r-1,s}(y) + y^s S_{s,r-1}(x).$$

Iterating this reduction in  $r$  gives

$$x^r S_{r,s}(y) + y^s S_{s,r}(x) = x S_{1,s}(y) + y^s.$$

Finally,

$$S_{1,s}(y) = 1 + y + \cdots + y^{s-1},$$

so

$$x S_{1,s}(y) + y^s = (1 - y)(1 + y + \cdots + y^{s-1}) + y^s 1.$$

This proves the lemma. Since it is an identity with integer coefficients, it remains valid in every characteristic.  $\square$

---

#### 3.1.4 4. Proof of the formula

Apply the lemma with

$$x = AU, \quad y = BV.$$

The given Bézout identity says precisely that  $x + y = 1$ . Therefore

$$(AU)^m S_{m,n}(BV) + (BV)^n S_{n,m}(AU) = 1.$$

Factoring out  $A^m$  and  $B^n$  gives

$$A^m (U^m S_{m,n}(BV)) + B^n (V^n S_{n,m}(AU)) = 1,$$

that is,

$$A^m \widehat{U}_{m,n} + B^n \widehat{V}_{m,n} = 1. \tag{1}$$

Thus  $(\widehat{U}_{m,n}, \widehat{V}_{m,n})$  is already an explicit Bézout pair for  $A^m$  and  $B^n$ . It need not, however, satisfy the required degree condition.

Now divide

$$\widehat{U}_{m,n} = B^n Q_{m,n} + R_{m,n}, \quad \deg R_{m,n} < \deg B^n.$$

Substitution into 1 yields

$$\begin{aligned} 1 &= A^m(B^n Q_{m,n} + R_{m,n}) + B^n \widehat{V}_{m,n} \\ &= A^m R_{m,n} + B^n(\widehat{V}_{m,n} + A^m Q_{m,n}). \end{aligned}$$

Hence

$$U_{m,n} = R_{m,n}, \quad V_{m,n} = \widehat{V}_{m,n} + A^m Q_{m,n}$$

has all the required properties.

In particular,

$$B^n \mid 1 - A^m U_{m,n},$$

so

$$V_{m,n} = \frac{1 - A^m U_{m,n}}{B^n}$$

is indeed a polynomial.

### 3.1.5 5. Uniqueness and classification of all pairs

Suppose that two pairs  $((P, Q))$  and  $((P', Q'))$  satisfy

$$A^m P + B^n Q = 1, \quad A^m P' + B^n Q' = 1.$$

Subtracting gives

$$A^m(P - P') = -B^n(Q - Q'). \tag{2}$$

Because 1 is itself a Bézout identity for  $A^m$  and  $B^n$ , equation 2 implies that  $B^n \mid P - P'$ . Indeed,

$$\begin{aligned} P - P' &= (A^m \widehat{U}_{m,n} + B^n \widehat{V}_{m,n})(P - P') \\ &= \widehat{U}_{m,n} A^m(P - P') + B^n \widehat{V}_{m,n}(P - P'), \end{aligned}$$

and both terms on the right are divisible by  $B^n$ .

If  $B$  is nonconstant and

$$\deg P, \deg P' < \deg B^n,$$

then either  $P - P' = 0$ , or

$$\deg(P - P') \geq \deg B^n,$$

which is impossible. Thus  $P = P'$ , and then 2 gives  $Q = Q'$ .

If  $B$  is a nonzero constant, the degree condition is  $\deg P < 0$ , hence  $P = 0$ , so uniqueness is again immediate.

Therefore the normalized pair  $(U_{m,n}, V_{m,n})$  is unique.

Moreover, all Bézout pairs without the degree restriction are exactly

$$\boxed{(U_{m,n} + B^n T, V_{m,n} - A^m T), \quad T \in \mathbb{K}[X].}$$

Thus the condition  $\deg U_{m,n} < \deg B^n$  selects precisely one pair from this affine family.

---

### 3.1.6 6. Symmetric remainder formula

Assume for this subsection that  $A$  and  $B$  are both nonconstant. Then the normalized pair automatically satisfies

$$\deg V_{m,n} < m \deg A.$$

Indeed, if  $V_{m,n} \neq 0$ , the highest-degree terms in

$$A^m U_{m,n} + B^n V_{m,n} = 1$$

must cancel, so

$$m \deg A + \deg U_{m,n} = n \deg B + \deg V_{m,n}.$$

Since  $\deg U_{m,n} < n \deg B$ , it follows that

$$\deg V_{m,n} < m \deg A.$$

Now  $V_{m,n} \equiv \widehat{V}_{m,n} \pmod{A^m}$ , because

$$V_{m,n} = \widehat{V}_{m,n} + A^m Q_{m,n}.$$

Consequently,

$$\boxed{V_{m,n} = \text{rem}_{A^m} \left( V^n \sum_{i=0}^{m-1} \binom{n+i-1}{i} (AU)^i \right).$$

Thus, in the generic nonconstant case, the answer has the completely symmetric form

$$\boxed{\begin{aligned} U_{m,n} &= \text{rem}_{B^n}(U^m S_{m,n}(BV)), \\ V_{m,n} &= \text{rem}_{A^m}(V^n S_{n,m}(AU)). \end{aligned}}$$


---

### 3.1.7 7. A directly degree-normalized $B$ -adic formula

The remainder modulo  $B^n$  can itself be expanded explicitly using only successive divisions by  $B$ .

Assume  $\deg B = b \geq 1$ . Define

$$\rho_B(P) := \text{rem}_B(P), \quad \delta_B(P) := \frac{P - \rho_B(P)}{B}.$$

Thus

$$P = \rho_B(P) + B\delta_B(P).$$

Iterating gives the finite  $B$ -adic expansion

$$P = \sum_{r \geq 0} B^r \rho_B(\delta_B^r(P)).$$

Since

$$\hat{U}_{m,n} = \sum_{k=0}^{n-1} \binom{m+k-1}{k} B^k U^m V^k,$$

its terms of  $B$ -adic order strictly below  $n$  give

$$\boxed{U_{m,n} = \sum_{r=0}^{n-1} B^r C_r,}$$

where

$$\boxed{C_r = \sum_{k=0}^r \binom{m+k-1}{k}, \rho_B! \left( \delta_B^{r-k}(U^m V^k) \right).}$$

Every  $C_r$  has degree  $< b$ , so the displayed formula directly gives

$$\deg U_{m,n} < nb = \deg B^n.$$

This is equivalent to the single-remainder formula but may be preferable for an implementation based on  $B$ -adic digits.

---

### 3.1.8 8. Small and boundary cases

**Case**  $m = n = 1$  Here  $S_{1,1} = 1$ , so

$$\widehat{U}_{1,1} = U, \quad \widehat{V}_{1,1} = V.$$

Because  $\deg U < \deg B$ , no reduction is needed:

$$(U_{1,1}, V_{1,1}) = (U, V).$$

**Case**  $n = 1$  Since  $S_{m,1} = 1$ ,

$$\boxed{U_{m,1} = \text{rem}_B(U^m)}.$$

The corresponding second coefficient is

$$V_{m,1} = \frac{1 - A^m U_{m,1}}{B}.$$

Before normalization, the symmetric pair is

$$\widehat{U}_{m,1} = U^m, \quad \widehat{V}_{m,1} = V \sum_{i=0}^{m-1} (AU)^i.$$

**Case**  $m = 1$  Because  $S_{1,n}(T) = 1 + T + \dots + T^{n-1}$ ,

$$U_{1,n} = \text{rem}_{B^n} \left( U \sum_{j=0}^{n-1} (BV)^j \right),$$

while

$$\widehat{V}_{1,n} = V^n.$$

The raw identity is simply

$$A, U \sum_{j=0}^{n-1} (BV)^j + (BV)^n = 1.$$

**Constant  $B$**  If  $B \in \mathbb{K}^\times$ , then  $\deg U < 0$  forces  $U = 0$ , and  $AU + BV = 1$  gives

$$V = B^{-1}.$$

The unique answer is therefore

$$\boxed{U_{m,n} = 0, \quad V_{m,n} = B^{-n}.$$

This also covers the possible degenerate case  $A = 0$ .

**Constant  $A$ , nonconstant  $B$**  If  $A \in \mathbb{K}^\times$  and  $B$  is nonconstant, the canonical initial pair is

$$U = A^{-1}, \quad V = 0.$$

Hence

$$\boxed{U_{m,n} = A^{-m}, \quad V_{m,n} = 0.$$

**Positive characteristic** There are no exceptional characteristics. The coefficients

$$\binom{m+j-1}{j}$$

are simply reduced modulo  $\text{char } \mathbb{K}$ . The proof uses no factorial denominators and is an identity over  $\mathbb{Z}$ .

---

### 3.1.9 9. Why the Euclidean reduction is genuinely necessary

The raw pair  $(\widehat{U}_{m,n}, \widehat{V}_{m,n})$  need not satisfy the degree condition.

For example, over  $\mathbb{Q}$ , take

$$A = X^2, \quad B = X + 1, \quad U = 1, \quad V = 1 - X.$$

Then

$$AU + BV = X^2 + (X + 1)(1 - X) = 1.$$

For  $m = 1, n = 2$ ,

$$\widehat{U}_{1,2} = 1 + BV^2 - X^2.$$

But

$$\deg(2 - X^2) = 2 = \deg(X + 1)^2,$$

so the strict degree condition fails. Dividing,

$$2 - X^2 = -(X + 1)^2 + (2X + 3).$$

Thus

$$U_{1,2} = 2X + 3.$$

Also,

$$\widehat{V}_{1,2} = V^2 = (1 - X)^2, \quad Q_{1,2} = -1,$$

so

$$V_{1,2} = (1 - X)^2 - X^2 1 - 2X.$$

Indeed,

$$X^2(2X + 3) + (X + 1)^2(1 - 2X) = 1.$$

### 3.1.10 10. Hypothesis audit

The identity  $AU + BV = 1$  already implies that  $A$  and  $B$  are coprime, so the explicit coprimality hypothesis is logically redundant once  $(U, V)$  are given.

The initial condition  $\deg U < \deg B$  is not needed for the construction: the same formula works starting from any Bézout pair  $AU + BV = 1$ . Its role is to make the given initial pair canonical.

The target condition

$$\deg U_{m,n} < \deg B^n$$

is essential for uniqueness. Without it, all solutions are obtained by adding

$$(B^n T, -A^m T).$$

Finally, the field hypothesis is used for unrestricted Euclidean division in  $\mathbb{K}[X]$ . The universal binomial identity itself is valid over every commutative ring; the normalized construction also extends, for example, to coefficient



rings over which division by the chosen  $B$  is available, such as when  $B$  is monic.

**Formal verification.** Lean source; online type-check.

## 4 Question Q668

**Informal verdict.** C — Substantial progress, with high confidence in the central classification.

**Lean coverage (partial).** Lean proves the structural periodic-point and asymptotic classification, the power-of-two criterion, the complete binary 15-cycle for  $n=5$ , and the explicit eigenray tending to zero. The Section 6 example and the general basin-of-attraction problem are not formalized or claimed solved.

### 4.1 Audited informal answer

### 4.2 Partial result

I give below:

1. a complete classification of all possible periodic attractors for every  $n$ ;
2. a proof that every real orbit is asymptotic, phase by phase, to one of them;
3. an exact finite algorithm for rational data;
4. a complete description of the possible asymptotic cycles for  $n = 5$ ;
5. an explicit nonconstant 5-tuple converging to 0;
6. an exact algebraic 5-tuple which approaches the nonzero 15-cycle but never enters any periodic orbit.

What remains unresolved by this analysis is a direct criterion, for an arbitrary exact real  $X$ , deciding which attractor basin contains  $X$  and computing the limiting scale without iterating indefinitely.

#### 4.2.1 1. Faithful restatement

Let  $n \geq 3$ . For

$$X = (x_1, \dots, x_n) \in \mathbb{R}_+^n,$$

define

$$P(X) = (|x_1 - x_2|, |x_2 - x_3|, \dots, |x_{n-1} - x_n|, |x_n - x_1|).$$

Study the orbit

$$X, P(X), P^2(X), \dots$$

for a prescribed starting vector  $X$ .

The editorial note says that  $n = 4$  is understood: every orbit eventually reaches 0, except for one algebraic family, up to elementary transformations, represented after one iteration by

$$(1, a, a^2, a^3),$$

where  $a - 1$  is the real root of

$$u^3 + 2u^2 - 2 = 0.$$

Equivalently,  $a$  satisfies

$$a^3 - a^2 - a - 1 = 0.$$

The note explicitly welcomes any partial result encompassing  $n = 5$ . There are two minor notational points.

- Here  $\mathbb{R}_+$  must mean  $[0, \infty)$ , since  $P(X)$  can have zero coordinates.
- The phrase “up to a simple transformation” in the editorial note is informal and does not specify the transformations, but this does not affect the formal problem.

Throughout, write

$$X^{(q)} = P^q(X), \quad M_q = |X^{(q)}|_\infty.$$

### 4.3 2. Main classification theorem

Write

$$n = hm, \quad h = 2^{\nu_2(n)}, \quad m \text{ odd.}$$

Thus  $h$  is the largest power of 2 dividing  $n$ .

For a binary vector  $\varepsilon = (\varepsilon_1, \dots, \varepsilon_n) \in 0, 1^n$ , put

$$E_\varepsilon(z) = \sum_{j=1}^n \varepsilon_j z^{j-1} \in \mathbb{F}_2[z].$$

Define

$$\mathcal{S}_n = \left\{ \varepsilon \in 0, 1^n : 1 + z^h \mid E_\varepsilon(z) \text{ in } \mathbb{F}_2[z] \right\}.$$

Equivalently,

$$\boxed{\varepsilon \in \mathcal{S}_n \iff \sum_{k=0}^{m-1} \varepsilon_{r+kh} \equiv 0 \pmod{2} \quad (1 \leq r \leq h).} \quad (2.1)$$

Thus  $\mathcal{S}_n$  is given by  $h$  independent parity conditions and

$$|\mathcal{S}_n| = 2^{n-h}.$$

#### 4.3.1 Theorem 2.1

For every  $X \in \mathbb{R}_+^n$ :

1. The sequence  $M_q$  is nonincreasing, and therefore

$$c(X) := \lim_{q \rightarrow \infty} M_q$$

exists.

1. There exists a periodic binary sequence

$(\varepsilon^{(q)})_{q \geq 0}$ , with every  $\varepsilon^{(q)} \in \mathcal{S}_n$  and

$$\varepsilon^{(q+1)} = P(\varepsilon^{(q)}),$$

such that

$$\boxed{\lim_{q \rightarrow \infty} \left| P^q(X) - c(X)\varepsilon^{(q)} \right|_{\infty} = 0.} \quad (2.2)$$

1. The periodic points of  $P$  in  $\mathbb{R}_+^n$  are exactly

$$\boxed{c\varepsilon, \quad c \geq 0, \quad \varepsilon \in \mathcal{S}_n.} \quad (2.3)$$

1. The map  $P$  permutes the finite set  $\mathcal{S}_n$ . Hence all possible periodic cycles can be computed by taking the cycle decomposition of this permutation.
1. Every real orbit converges to 0 if and only if  $n$  is a power of 2.

An equivalent limit-point and periodic-orbit classification appears in the classical work of Misiurewicz and Schinzel; the proof below is self-contained and also makes the phase-by-phase convergence explicit. ([hrj.epi-sciences.org][1])

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#### 4.4 3. Proof of Theorem 2.1

##### 4.4.1 3.1. Monotonicity

If  $Y = (y_1, \dots, y_n) \in [0, M]^n$ , then

$$|y_i - y_{i+1}| \leq M.$$

Consequently,

$$|P(Y)| * \infty \leq |Y| * \infty.$$

Thus  $M_{q+1} \leq M_q$ , proving the existence of  $c(X)$ .

We shall need the following strict form.

##### 4.4.2 3.2. Strict decrease unless all entries are extremal

For  $u_0, \dots, u_k \in [0, M]$ , define recursively

$$\Delta_0(u_0) = u_0$$

and

$$\Delta_k(u_0, \dots, u_k) = |\Delta_{k-1}(u_0, \dots, u_{k-1}) - \text{-----}|$$

Then, with cyclic indices,

$$(P^k(Y))_i = \Delta_k(y_i, y_{i+1}, \dots, y_{i+k}). \quad (3.1)$$

**Lemma 3.1** Suppose  $u_0, \dots, u_k \in [0, M]$ . If

$$\Delta_k(u_0, \dots, u_k) = M,$$

then

$$u_j \in 0, M \quad (0 \leq j \leq k).$$

**Proof** First observe the following endpoint fact.

If

$$u_0, \dots, u_{k-1} \in 0, M, \quad u_k = t \in [0, M],$$

then

$$\Delta_k(u_0, \dots, u_k) \in t, M - t. \quad (3.2)$$

Indeed, after taking one row of absolute differences, all entries except possibly the last are again in  $(\{0, M\})$ , while the last is either  $t$  or  $M - t$ . Induction proves (3.2). The analogous assertion holds when the exceptional entry is the first one.

We now prove the lemma by induction on  $k$ . The case  $k = 0$  is immediate. Set

$$A = \Delta_{k-1}(u_0, \dots, u_{k-1}), \quad B = \Delta_{k-1}(u_1, \dots, u_k).$$

Both  $A$  and  $B$  belong to  $([0, M])$ . Since

$$|A - B| = M,$$

we must have

$$A, B = 0, M.$$

Suppose, for example, that  $A = M$ . By the induction hypothesis,

$$u_0, \dots, u_{k-1} \in 0, M.$$

Since  $B = 0$ , the endpoint observation applied to  $u_1, \dots, u_k$  implies that  $u_k \in 0, M$ . The other case is symmetric.  $\square$

**Corollary 3.2** If  $Y \in [0, M]^n$  has at least one coordinate strictly between 0 and  $M$ , then

$$\boxed{|P^{n-1}(Y)|_\infty < M.} \tag{3.3}$$

**Proof** Every coordinate of  $P^{n-1}(Y)$  is an  $(n-1)$ -st absolute difference involving all  $n$  original coordinates once. Lemma 3.1 shows that none of these coordinates can equal  $M$ .  $\square$

---

#### 4.4.3 3.3. Every limit point is binary up to scale

Let  $\Omega(X)$  be the set of limit points of the orbit.

Take  $Y \in \Omega(X)$ . There is a sequence  $q_j \rightarrow \infty$  such that

$$X^{(q_j)} \longrightarrow Y.$$

Since  $M_{q_j} \rightarrow c(X)$ ,

$$|Y|_\infty = c(X).$$

Suppose  $c(X) > 0$  and that some coordinate of  $Y$  lies strictly between 0 and  $c(X)$ . Corollary 3.2 gives

$$|P^{n-1}(Y)|_\infty < c(X).$$

On the other hand, continuity of  $P$  yields

$$P^{n-1}(X^{(q_j)}) \longrightarrow P^{n-1}(Y),$$

while

$$\left\| P^{n-1}(X^{(q_j)}) \right\|_\infty = M_{q_j+n-1} \longrightarrow c(X),$$

a contradiction.

Therefore every limit point has the form

$$Y = c(X)\varepsilon, \quad \varepsilon \in 0, 1^n. \quad (3.4)$$

When  $c(X) = 0$ , the orbit itself converges to 0.

---

#### 4.4.4 3.4. Algebra over $\mathbb{F}_2$

On binary vectors, absolute difference agrees with addition modulo 2:

$$|a - b| = a + b \pmod{2} \quad (a, b \in 0, 1).$$

Let  $L : \mathbb{F}_2^n \rightarrow \mathbb{F}_2^n$  denote the resulting linear map

$$(L\varepsilon)_i = \varepsilon_i + \varepsilon_{i+1}.$$

Identify  $\mathbb{F}_2^n$  with

$$R_n = \mathbb{F}_2[z]/(z^n - 1)$$

by  $\varepsilon \mapsto E_\varepsilon(z)$ . Then

$$E_{L\varepsilon}(z) = z^{-1}(1 + z)E_\varepsilon(z) \quad \text{in } R_n. \quad (3.5)$$

Since multiplication by  $z$  is invertible in  $R_n$ , the image of  $L^h$  is the ideal generated by

$$(1 + z)^h = 1 + z^h,$$

where we used that  $h$  is a power of 2.

Moreover  $1 + z^h \mid z^n - 1$  in  $\mathbb{F}_2[z]$ . It follows that

$$\text{im } L^h = \mathcal{S}_n. \quad (3.6)$$

Reducing  $E_\varepsilon$  modulo  $1 + z^h$  gives

$$E_\varepsilon(z) \equiv \sum_{r=1}^h \left( \sum_{k=0}^{m-1} \varepsilon_{r+kh} \right) z^{r-1},$$

which proves the parity formulation (2.1).

---

#### 4.4.5 3.5. Why limit points belong to $\mathcal{S}_n$

The omega-limit set satisfies

$$P^k(\Omega(X)) = \Omega(X) \quad (k \geq 1). \quad (3.7)$$

Indeed, the inclusion from left to right follows by continuity. Conversely, if

$$Y = \lim_j X^{(q_j)},$$

take a convergent subsequence of  $X^{(q_j-k)}$ ; its limit  $Z \in \Omega(X)$  satisfies  $P^k(Z) = Y$ .

Now let  $Y = c\varepsilon \in \Omega(X)$ , with  $c > 0$ . By (3.7), there exists  $c\delta \in \Omega(X)$  such that

$$P^h(c\delta) = c\varepsilon.$$

Hence

$$\varepsilon = L^h \delta \in \text{im } L^h = \mathcal{S}_n.$$

Thus

$$\Omega(X) \subseteq c(X)\mathcal{S}_n. \quad (3.8)$$

#### 4.4.6 3.6. $P$ is a permutation of $\mathcal{S}_n$

Since

$$\mathcal{S}_n = \text{im } L^h,$$

we have  $L(\mathcal{S}_n) \subseteq \mathcal{S}_n$ .

It remains to prove injectivity. The kernel of  $L$  consists of the two constant binary vectors:

$$\ker L = 0, \mathbf{1}, \quad \mathbf{1} = (1, \dots, 1).$$

We claim that  $\mathbf{1} \notin \mathcal{S}_n$ . Its polynomial is

$$J_n(z) = 1 + z + \dots + z^{n-1} = \frac{z^n + 1}{z + 1} \quad \text{in characteristic 2.}$$



Because  $n = hm$  with  $m$  odd,

$$z^n + 1 = (z^m + 1)^h.$$

The root  $z = 1$  has multiplicity exactly one in  $z^m + 1$ , since

$$\left. \frac{d}{dz}(z^m + 1) \right|_{z=1} = m \equiv 1 \pmod{2}.$$

Thus  $z = 1$  has multiplicity  $h$  in  $z^n + 1$ , and multiplicity  $h - 1$  in  $J_n$ . Therefore

$$(1 + z)^h = 1 + z^h \nmid J_n(z).$$

So  $\mathbf{1} \notin \mathcal{S}_n$ .

If  $L\varepsilon = L\delta$  with  $\varepsilon, \delta \in \mathcal{S}_n$ , then

$$\varepsilon + \delta \in \ker L.$$

It cannot equal  $\mathbf{1}$ , because  $\mathcal{S}_n$  is a vector space and  $\mathbf{1} \notin \mathcal{S}_n$ . Hence  $\varepsilon = \delta$ . Thus  $L$ , and therefore  $P$ , permutes  $\mathcal{S}_n$ .

It also follows that the binary periodic points are precisely the elements of  $\mathcal{S}_n$ . Indeed:

- every element of  $\mathcal{S}_n$  is periodic because  $L$  permutes this finite set;
- if  $L^r\varepsilon = \varepsilon$ , choose a multiple  $s \geq h$  of  $r$ ; then

$$\varepsilon = L^s\varepsilon = L^h(L^{s-h}\varepsilon),$$

so  $\varepsilon \in \operatorname{im} L^h = \mathcal{S}_n$ .

---

#### 4.4.7 3.7. The orbit shadows one periodic cycle

We know that all limit points lie in the finite set

$$F = c(X)\mathcal{S}_n.$$

Consequently,

$$\operatorname{dist}(X^{(q)}, F) \longrightarrow 0. \tag{3.9}$$

Otherwise a subsequence staying a positive distance from  $F$  would have a limit point outside  $F$ .

Assume  $c(X) > 0$ . Distinct points of  $F$  are separated in the supremum norm by at least  $c(X)$ .

The map  $P$  is 2-Lipschitz:

$$|P(U) - P(V)| * \infty \leq 2|U - V| * \infty. \quad (3.10)$$

For all sufficiently large  $q$ , there is therefore a unique  $f_q \in F$  with

$$|X^{(q)} - f_q|_\infty < \frac{c(X)}{10}.$$

Furthermore,

$$\begin{aligned} |P(f_q) - f_{q+1}| * \infty &\leq |P(f_q) - P(X^{(q)})| * \infty + |X^{(q+1)} - f_{q+1}|_\infty \\ &< \frac{3c(X)}{10}. \end{aligned}$$

Since two distinct elements of  $F$  are at distance at least  $c(X)$ , this forces

$$f_{q+1} = P(f_q).$$

Hence, from some point onward, the nearest elements  $f_q$  follow one periodic cycle. Together with (3.9), this proves (2.2).

---

#### 4.4.8 3.8. All real periodic points

Let  $Y$  be periodic. The sequence  $|P^q(Y)|_\infty$  is both periodic and nonincreasing, hence constant.

If some coordinate of  $Y$  were strictly between 0 and  $M = |Y|_\infty$ , Corollary 3.2 would give

$$|P^{n-1}(Y)|_\infty < M,$$

a contradiction. Thus

$$Y = M\varepsilon$$

for a binary vector  $\varepsilon$ . The binary classification proves  $\varepsilon \in \mathcal{S}_n$ .

Conversely,  $M\varepsilon$  is periodic whenever  $\varepsilon \in \mathcal{S}_n$ , by positive homogeneity:

$$P(M\varepsilon) = MP(\varepsilon).$$

This proves (2.3).

Finally, if  $n$  is a power of 2, then  $h = n$ , so the only degree- $< n$  polynomial divisible by  $1 + z^n$  is zero. Hence

$$\mathcal{S}_n = 0$$

and every orbit converges to 0.

If  $n$  is not a power of 2, then  $h < n$ , so

$$|\mathcal{S}_n| = 2^{n-h} > 1,$$

and nonzero periodic orbits exist.  $\square$

---

#### 4.5 4. Complete asymptotic description for $n = 5$

For  $n = 5$ ,

$$h = 1, \quad m = 5.$$

Condition (2.1) becomes

$$\varepsilon_1 + \cdots + \varepsilon_5 \equiv 0 \pmod{2}.$$

Thus

$$\boxed{\mathcal{S}_5 = \varepsilon \in 0, 1^5 : \varepsilon \text{ has even Hamming weight.}} \quad (4.1)$$

There are 16 such vectors.

##### 4.5.1 Proposition 4.1

The zero vector is fixed, and the other 15 vectors of  $\mathcal{S}_5$  form one cycle of exact length 15.

**Proof** Set

$$H(z) = 1 + z + z^2 + z^3 + z^4.$$

This polynomial is irreducible over  $\mathbb{F}_2$ :

- it has no root in  $\mathbb{F}_2$ ;
- if it factored without a linear factor, it would be a product of two irreducible quadratics;

- the only monic irreducible quadratic over  $\mathbb{F}_2$  is

$z^2 + z + 1$ , whose square is  $z^4 + z^2 + 1 \neq H(z)$ .

Consequently,

$$K = \mathbb{F}_2[z]/(H)$$

is the field with 16 elements.

The space  $\mathcal{S}_5 = (1 + z)R_5$  is naturally isomorphic, as a vector space, to  $K$ . Under this identification, the binary Ducci map acts as multiplication by

$$\mu = 1 + \alpha,$$

where  $\alpha$  is a nontrivial fifth root of unity in  $K$ .

Since

$$1 + \alpha + \alpha^2 + \alpha^3 + \alpha^4 = 0,$$

we get

$$\mu^3 = (1 + \alpha)^3 = 1 + \alpha + \alpha^2 + \alpha^3 = \alpha^4.$$

Thus  $\mu^3$  has order 5. Since  $K^\times$  has order 15, the order of  $\mu$  is either 5 or 15.

But

$$\mu^5 = (1 + \alpha)^5 = (1 + \alpha^4)(1 + \alpha) = \alpha + \alpha^4.$$

If  $\mu^5 = 1$ , then

$$1 + \alpha + \alpha^4 = 0.$$

Adding  $1 + \alpha + \alpha^2 + \alpha^3 + \alpha^4 = 0$  gives

$$\alpha^2 + \alpha^3 = \alpha^2(1 + \alpha) = 0,$$

which is impossible. Therefore  $\mu$  has order 15.

Multiplication by  $\mu$  consequently acts transitively on the 15 nonzero elements of  $K$ .  $\square$

One explicit orientation of the cycle is

$$\begin{aligned}
e_0 &= (1, 1, 0, 0, 0), \\
e_1 &= (0, 1, 0, 0, 1), \\
e_2 &= (1, 1, 0, 1, 1), \\
e_3 &= (0, 1, 1, 0, 0), \\
e_4 &= (1, 0, 1, 0, 0), \\
e_5 &= (1, 1, 1, 0, 1), \\
e_6 &= (0, 0, 1, 1, 0), \\
e_7 &= (0, 1, 0, 1, 0), \\
e_8 &= (1, 1, 1, 1, 0), \\
e_9 &= (0, 0, 0, 1, 1), \\
e_{10} &= (0, 0, 1, 0, 1), \\
e_{11} &= (0, 1, 1, 1, 1), \\
e_{12} &= (1, 0, 0, 0, 1), \\
e_{13} &= (1, 0, 0, 1, 0), \\
e_{14} &= (1, 0, 1, 1, 1),
\end{aligned}$$

with

$$P(e_q) = e_{q+1}, \quad e_{15} = e_0.$$

#### 4.5.2 Corollary 4.2

For every  $X \in \mathbb{R}_+^5$ , exactly one of the following holds.

**Zero-attractor case**

$$\boxed{P^q(X) \longrightarrow 0.}$$

**Nonzero-attractor case** There are  $c > 0$  and a phase  $r \in 0, \dots, 14$  such that

$$\boxed{\left| P^q(X) - c, e_{q+r \pmod{15}} \right|_\infty \longrightarrow 0.} \quad (4.2)$$

Thus the possible asymptotic shapes for  $n = 5$  are completely classified.

---

#### 4.6 5. A nonconstant 5-tuple converging to zero

The zero-attractor case is not confined to constant vectors.

Let  $\rho \in (0, 1)$  be a root of

$$\rho^4 + 3\rho^3 + 2\rho^2 - 2\rho - 3 = 0. \quad (5.1)$$

Such a root exists because the polynomial is negative at 0 and positive at 1. Numerically,

$$\rho \approx 0.9275619755.$$

Define

$$V = (1, 1 - \rho, 1 - \rho^2, (1 + \rho)(1 - \rho^2), (1 + \rho)^2(1 - \rho^2)).$$

The identity

$$(1 + \rho)^3(1 - \rho^2) - 1 = -\rho(\rho^4 + 3\rho^3 + 2\rho^2 - 2\rho - 3)$$

shows that

$$(1 + \rho)^3(1 - \rho^2) = 1.$$

The coordinates satisfy

$$0 < v_2 < v_3 < v_4 < v_5 < v_1.$$

Moreover,

$$v_1 - v_2 = \rho v_1,$$

$$v_3 - v_2 = \rho v_2,$$

$$v_4 - v_3 = \rho v_3,$$

$$v_5 - v_4 = \rho v_4,$$

$$v_1 - v_5 = \rho v_5.$$

Therefore

$$\boxed{P(V) = \rho V.}$$

Consequently,

$$P^q(V) = \rho^q V \longrightarrow 0,$$

but  $P^q(V) \neq 0$  for every finite  $q$ .

#### 4.7 6. An exact non-eventually-periodic $n = 5$ orbit with nonzero attractor

This is the more delicate phenomenon. Earlier work explicitly asked whether the  $n = 5$  situation permits an orbit which approaches a nontrivial periodic cycle without ever becoming periodic. ([fq.math.ca][2])

The following gives such an orbit exactly.

##### 4.7.1 Theorem 6.1

There exists  $X \in \mathbb{R}_+^5$  such that

$$|P^q(X) - e_{q \bmod 15}|_\infty \longrightarrow 0,$$

but no  $P^q(X)$  is periodic.

**Construction** Let

$$p(t) = t^3 - 19t^2 + 139t - 1.$$

We have

$$p\left(\frac{1}{139}\right) = -\frac{2640}{2685619} < 0,$$

and

$$p\left(\frac{1}{138}\right) = \frac{16423}{2628072} > 0.$$

Also  $p'(t) > 0$  on this interval. Let

$$\lambda \in \left(\frac{1}{139}, \frac{1}{138}\right)$$

be its unique root. Numerically,

$$\lambda \approx 0.007201330580038611.$$

Define

$$w_0 = \begin{pmatrix} 19960 \\ 83\lambda^2 - 424\lambda + 18633 \\ 22\lambda^2 - 1916\lambda + 6502 \\ 112\lambda^2 - 2496\lambda + 9512 \\ 7\lambda^2 - 156\lambda + 4337 \end{pmatrix}. \quad (6.1)$$

For a sign word  $\sigma = (\sigma_1, \dots, \sigma_5) \in +, -^5$ , let  $B_\sigma$  be the matrix defined by

$$(B_\sigma v)_i = s_i(v_i - v_{i+1}), \quad s_i = \begin{cases} 1, & \sigma_i = +, \\ -1, & \sigma_i = -, \end{cases}$$

with cyclic indices.

Use the following 15 sign words:

| $q$ | $\sigma_q$ | $q$ | $\sigma_q$ | $q$ | $\sigma_q$ |
|-----|------------|-----|------------|-----|------------|
| 0   | + + - + -  | 5   | + - + - -  | 10  | + - + - +  |
| 1   | - + - - +  | 6   | - - + + -  | 11  | - + - + +  |
| 2   | + + - - +  | 7   | - + - + +  | 12  | + + + - -  |
| 3   | - - + + +  | 8   | + + - + -  | 13  | + - - + -  |
| 4   | + - + - -  | 9   | + - - - +  | 14  | + - - + -  |

(6.2)

Define recursively

$$w_{q+1} = B_{\sigma_q} w_q \quad (0 \leq q < 15).$$

The product is

$$A = B_{\sigma_{14}} \cdots B_{\sigma_0} = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & -1 & -15 & 3 & 11 \\ -9 & 10 & -13 & 5 & 7 \\ 11 & -11 & 10 & -7 & -3 \\ 1 & -1 & 9 & -4 & -5 \\ 1 & -1 & -3 & 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix}. \quad (6.3)$$

If  $w_0(t)$  denotes the vector in (6.1) with  $\lambda$  replaced by  $t$ , direct multiplication gives

$$Aw_0(t) - tw_0(t) = p(t) (083221127). \quad (6.4)$$

Hence

$$w_{15} = Aw_0 = \lambda w_0. \quad (6.5)$$

The finite exact verification following the proof establishes two further facts:

$$w_{q,i} > 0 \quad (0 \leq q < 15, 1 \leq i \leq 5), \quad (6.6)$$

and whenever  $e_{q,i} = e_{q,i+1}$ , the corresponding sign in  $\sigma_q$  is the sign of



$$w_{q,i} - w_{q,i+1}. \quad (6.7)$$

Let

$$K = \max_{\substack{0 \leq q < 15 \\ 1 \leq i \leq 5}} |w_{q,i} - w_{q,i+1}|, \quad W = \max_{\substack{0 \leq q < 15 \\ 1 \leq i \leq 5}} w_{q,i}.$$

Choose  $\varepsilon > 0$  so small that

$$\varepsilon K < \frac{1}{2}, \quad \varepsilon W < \frac{1}{2}.$$

Set

$$X = e_0 + \varepsilon w_0. \quad (6.8)$$

**Proof of the claimed dynamics** For every  $q$ , consider

$$e_q + \delta w_q$$

with  $0 < \delta \leq \varepsilon$ .

If  $e_{q,i} \neq e_{q,i+1}$ , their difference is  $\pm 1$ , and  $\delta K < 1/2$  ensures that the perturbation cannot change its sign.

If  $e_{q,i} = e_{q,i+1}$ , condition (6.7) determines the sign of the perturbed difference.

Therefore

$$P(e_q + \delta w_q) = e_{q+1} + \delta w_{q+1}. \quad (6.9)$$

Using  $w_{15} = \lambda w_0$  and induction gives the exact formula

$$\boxed{P^{15k+q}(X) = e_q + \varepsilon \lambda^k w_q, \quad k \geq 0, \quad 0 \leq q < 15.} \quad (6.10)$$

Since  $0 < \lambda < 1$ ,

$$P^{15k+q}(X) \longrightarrow e_q.$$

Thus the orbit approaches the nonzero 15-cycle.

On the other hand, every coordinate in (6.10) is strictly positive by (6.6). Every nonzero periodic point for  $n = 5$  is a scalar multiple of an even-weight binary vector, and hence has at least one zero coordinate. Thus no iterate in (6.10) is periodic.

This proves Theorem 6.1.  $\square$

#### 4.7.2 Exact finite verifier

This is not a floating-point experiment. All inequalities are certified using rational interval arithmetic on

$$\lambda \in \left[ \frac{1}{139}, \frac{1}{138} \right]$$

and reductions modulo  $p(\lambda) = 0$ .

```
from fractions import Fraction
import sympy as sp

t = sp.symbols("t")
p = t**3 - 19*t**2 + 139*t - 1
lo, hi = Fraction(1, 139), Fraction(1, 138)

def peval(x):
    return x**3 - 19*x**2 + 139*x - 1

# Existence and uniqueness of the small positive root.
assert peval(lo) < 0 < peval(hi)
assert 3*lo*lo - 38*hi + 139 > 0

cycle = [
    (1,1,0,0,0),
    (0,1,0,0,1),
    (1,1,0,1,1),
    (0,1,1,0,0),
    (1,0,1,0,0),
    (1,1,1,0,1),
    (0,0,1,1,0),
    (0,1,0,1,0),
    (1,1,1,1,0),
    (0,0,0,1,1),
    (0,0,1,0,1),
    (0,1,1,1,1),
    (1,0,0,0,1),
    (1,0,0,1,0),
    (1,0,1,1,1),
]
```

```

words = [
    "++-+-", "-+--+", "++--+", "---+++",
    "+-+--", "+-+--", "---+-", "-+-++",
    "++-+-", "+-+--", "+-+--", "-+-++",
    "+++--", "+-+--", "+-+--",
]

def branch_matrix(word):
    B = sp.zeros(5)
    for i, symbol in enumerate(word):
        s = 1 if symbol == "+" else -1
        B[i, i] = s
        B[i, (i + 1) % 5] = -s
    return B

def reduce_mod_p(expr):
    return sp.rem(
        sp.Poly(sp.expand(expr), t),
        sp.Poly(p, t),
    ).as_expr()

def reduce_vector(v):
    return sp.Matrix([
        sp.expand(reduce_mod_p(x)) for x in v
    ])

w0 = sp.Matrix([
    19960,
    83*t**2 - 424*t + 18633,
    22*t**2 - 1916*t + 6502,
    112*t**2 - 2496*t + 9512,
    7*t**2 - 156*t + 4337,
])

ws = [w0]
A = sp.eye(5)

for q, word in enumerate(words):
    # Check the binary cycle and fixed signs on unequal edges.

```

```

    assert tuple(
        abs(cycle[q][i] - cycle[q][(i + 1) % 5])
        for i in range(5)
    ) == cycle[(q + 1) % 15]

    for i, symbol in enumerate(word):
        if cycle[q][i] != cycle[q][(i + 1) % 5]:
            s = 1 if symbol == "+" else -1
            assert s * (
                cycle[q][i] - cycle[q][(i + 1) % 5]
            ) == 1

    B = branch_matrix(word)
    A = B * A
    ws.append(reduce_vector(B * ws[-1]))

A_expected = sp.Matrix([
    [ 2, -1, -15,  3, 11],
    [-9, 10, -13,  5,  7],
    [11,-11,  10, -7, -3],
    [ 1, -1,  9, -4, -5],
    [ 1, -1, -3,  1,  2],
])

assert A == A_expected
assert all(reduce_mod_p(x) == 0 for x in A*w0 - t*w0)
assert all(reduce_mod_p(x) == 0 for x in ws[15] - t*w0)

def coefficients(expr):
    poly = sp.Poly(expr, t, domain=sp.QQ)
    out = []
    for degree in range(3):
        c = poly.coeff_monomial(t**degree)
        out.append(Fraction(int(c.p), int(c.q)))
    return out

def interval(expr):
    powers = [
        (Fraction(1), Fraction(1)),
        (lo, hi),

```

```

        (lo*lo, hi*hi),
    ]

    lower = Fraction(0)
    upper = Fraction(0)

    for coefficient, (a, b) in zip(coefficients(expr), powers):
        if coefficient >= 0:
            lower += coefficient * a
            upper += coefficient * b
        else:
            lower += coefficient * b
            upper += coefficient * a

    return lower, upper

lower_bounds = []

for q in range(15):
    for i in range(5):
        # Positivity of every perturbation coordinate.
        lower_bounds.append(interval(ws[q][i])[0])

        # Correct sign whenever the binary edge is zero.
        j = (i + 1) % 5
        if cycle[q][i] == cycle[q][j]:
            s = 1 if words[q][i] == "+" else -1
            lower_bounds.append(
                interval(s * (ws[q][i] - ws[q][j]))[0]
            )

minimum = min(lower_bounds)

print("Return matrix:")
print(A)
print("Certified minimum:", minimum, float(minimum))

assert minimum == Fraction(28286630, 1333149)
assert minimum > 21

```

The certified lower bound is

$$\frac{28286630}{1333149} > 21,$$

so all required inequalities are strict with a wide margin.

---

#### 4.8 7. Exact algorithm for rational starting vectors

Suppose

$$X = (x_1, \dots, x_n) \in \mathbb{Q}_+^n.$$

Choose a common denominator  $D$  and put

$$A = DX \in \mathbb{Z}_+^n.$$

Positive homogeneity gives

$$P^q(X) = \frac{1}{D} P^q(A).$$

Let

$$R = \max_i A_i - \min_i A_i.$$

Every coordinate of  $P(A)$  lies in  $0, \dots, R$ , and the same is true for every later iterate. Thus after the first step there are at most

$$(R+1)^n$$

possible states.

The following exact algorithm therefore terminates.

INPUT: rational vector  $X$  of length  $n$

1. Let  $D$  be the least common multiple of all denominators.
2. Set  $A := D X$ , an integer vector.
3. Set  $Y := P(A)$ .
4. Initialize an empty dictionary `seen`.
5. For  $q = 1, 2, 3, \dots$ :
  - if  $Y$  is already in `seen`:
    - $\mu := \text{seen}[Y]$
    - $\ell := q - \mu$

```

        return transient length  $\mu$ ,
               cycle length  $\ell$ ,
               exact cycle divided by  $D$ 
seen[Y] := q
Y := P(Y)

```

Each iteration takes  $O(n)$  integer operations on integers having  $O(\log R)$  bits.

The crude worst-case bounds are therefore

$$O(n(R+1)^n)$$

arithmetic operations and

$$O(n(R+1)^n \log R)$$

bit storage. Floyd's cycle-finding method reduces the memory to  $O(n \log R)$  bits, at the cost of rerunning part of the orbit to output the cycle.

The same procedure applies whenever there exist  $a \neq 0$  and  $b \in \mathbb{R}$  such that

$$a(X + b\mathbf{1}) \in \mathbb{Q}^n,$$

because

$$P(X + b\mathbf{1}) = P(X), \quad P(aX) = |a|P(X).$$

#### 4.8.1 Consequence for rational 5-tuples

For odd  $n$ , no positive constant vector lies in the image of  $P$ . Indeed, if

$$P(Y) = c\mathbf{1}, \quad c > 0,$$

then there are signs  $s_i \in \pm 1$  such that

$$y_i - y_{i+1} = s_i c.$$

Summing cyclically gives

$$0 = c \sum_{i=1}^n s_i,$$

which is impossible when  $n$  is odd.

It follows that for odd  $n$ , only constant starting vectors can ever reach zero exactly.

Therefore, for  $n = 5$ :

|                                                                                                                      |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| $X \in \mathbb{Q}_+^5, X \text{ nonconstant} \implies \text{the orbit eventually enters the exact period-15 cycle.}$ |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

---

#### 4.9 8. Small and boundary cases

**Constant vectors** If  $X = c\mathbf{1}$ , then  $P(X) = 0$ .

$n = 3$  Here  $h = 1$ , so  $\mathcal{S}_3$  consists of the even-weight binary vectors:

$$000, \quad 110, \quad 011, \quad 101.$$

The three nonzero vectors form the cycle

$$110 \mapsto 011 \mapsto 101 \mapsto 110.$$

Every real 3-orbit is asymptotic either to 0 or to a scalar multiple of this 3-cycle.

$n = 4$  Here  $h = 4$ , so

$$\mathcal{S}_4 = 0000.$$

Thus every real orbit converges to zero. This does not imply finite extinction: the algebraic exceptional family mentioned in the editorial note converges to zero without reaching it.

$n = 5$  There is one nonzero 15-cycle up to scale and phase. Both nonperiodic possibilities occur:

- the eigenray of Section 5 approaches zero;
- the construction of Section 6 approaches the nonzero 15-cycle.



**Necessity of the power-of-two hypothesis** If  $n$  is not a power of 2, then

$$|\mathcal{S}_n| = 2^{n-h} > 1,$$

so nonzero periodic orbits exist. Hence “every orbit converges to zero” is equivalent to  $n$  being a power of 2.

**Nonnegativity** The restriction to  $\mathbb{R}_+^n$  is not essential:  $P$  sends every vector in  $\mathbb{R}^n$  into  $\mathbb{R}_+^n$  after one iteration.

---

#### 4.10 9. Exact remaining obstruction

The asymptotic shape is now determined for every  $n$ , and completely explicit for  $n = 5$ . What is not supplied by Theorem 2.1 is a finite intrinsic criterion for an arbitrary real input  $X$  deciding whether

$$c(X) = \lim_{q \rightarrow \infty} |P^q(X)|_\infty$$

is zero or positive, nor a closed formula for  $c(X)$  and the eventual phase. For  $n = 5$ , the exact obstruction can be formulated as follows.

Near the 15-cycle, the 15-step return map is piecewise linear. Each branch is a product of 15 signed difference matrices. A complete basin classification would require describing all admissible infinite paths through the resulting finite polyhedral branch graph and determining which associated matrix products contract the perturbation while preserving a positive limiting scale.

The construction in Section 6 gives one exact contracting return branch. A natural next lemma would be:

**Proposed next lemma.** Construct the finite directed graph of admissible polyhedral cones for the 15-step return map at  $e_0$ , and classify all strongly connected components whose matrix cocycle has a nontrivial stable direction.

That would turn the remaining  $n = 5$  basin problem into a finite exact computation followed by a matrix-semigroup argument.

Thus the strongest justified status is:

Complete classification of all attractors for every  $n$ ;  
 complete asymptotic classification for  $n = 5$ ;  
 exact rational-input algorithm;  
 explicit nonperiodic  $n = 5$  examples for both  $c = 0$  and  $c > 0$ ;  
 general real basin classification still remaining.

[1]: <https://hrj.episciences.org/105/pdf> "https://hrj.episciences.org/105/pdf"

[2]: [https://www.fq.math.ca/Papers1/45-2/quartzerr02\\_2007.pdf](https://www.fq.math.ca/Papers1/45-2/quartzerr02_2007.pdf) "https://www.fq.math.ca/Papers1/45-2/quartzerr02\_2007.pdf"

**Formal verification.** Lean source; online type-check.

## 5 Question Q701

**Informal verdict.** A — **Complete solution**, with **high confidence**.

**Lean coverage (partial).** Lean proves the main path-pseudometric and finite-chain characterization of extreme points, convexity, and two illustrative examples. The optional McShane-extension, exposed-point, strong-extremality, and alpha-equals-one discussions are not formalized.

### 5.1 Audited informal answer

#### 5.1.1 1. Faithful restatement

Fix an exponent  $\alpha \in (0, 1)$ . Let

$$\mathcal{C}_\alpha = \{f : [0, 1] \rightarrow \mathbb{R} : f(0) = 0, \quad |f(x) - f(y)| \leq |x - y|^\alpha \text{ for all } x, y \in [0, 1]\}.$$

Equipped with the uniform topology,  $\mathcal{C}_\alpha$  is a compact convex subset of  $C([0, 1])$ . The problem asks for simple properties and, ideally, a characterization of its extreme points. There are no subparts or additional qualifications in the PDF.

The phrase “ $\alpha$ -Hölder of ratio 1” must mean Hölder constant **at most** 1. If it meant that the optimal constant were exactly 1, the set would not be convex:  $x^\alpha$  and  $-x^\alpha$  would belong to it, whereas their midpoint 0 would not.

The answer below gives a complete intrinsic characterization.

### 5.1.2 2. The slack pseudometric

Write

$$d_\alpha(x, y) = |x - y|^\alpha.$$

Since  $0 < \alpha < 1$ , the inequality

$$(r + s)^\alpha \leq r^\alpha + s^\alpha$$

shows that  $d_\alpha$  is a metric.

For  $f \in \mathcal{C}_\alpha$ , define its **slack** on a pair  $((x, y))$  by

$$\sigma_f(x, y) = d_\alpha(x, y) - |f(x) - f(y)| |x - y|^\alpha - |f(x) - f(y)|.$$

Thus  $\sigma_f(x, y) \geq 0$ , and  $\sigma_f(x, y) = 0$  precisely when the Hölder inequality is saturated at  $((x, y))$ .

For a finite chain

$$P = (x_0, x_1, \dots, x_n)$$

define its total slack by

$$\ell_f(P) = \sum_{i=1}^n \sigma_f(x_{i-1}, x_i).$$

Finally, define

$$\rho_f(x, y) = \inf \{ \ell_f(x_0, \dots, x_n) : n \geq 1, x_0 = x, x_n = y \},$$

and put  $\rho_f(x, x) = 0$ .

The function  $\rho_f$  is a pseudometric. Indeed, symmetry follows by reversing chains, and the triangle inequality follows by concatenating chains. Moreover, using the one-edge chain,

$$0 \leq \rho_f(x, y) \leq \sigma_f(x, y) \leq d_\alpha(x, y). \quad (2.1)$$

It is also the largest pseudometric bounded above by  $\sigma_f$ .

---

### 5.1.3 3. Complete characterization

**Theorem** For  $f \in \mathcal{C}_\alpha$ , the following conditions are equivalent.

1.  $f$  is an extreme point of  $\mathcal{C}_\alpha$ .
1. For every  $x \in [0, 1]$ ,

$$\rho_f(0, x) = 0. \tag{3.1}$$

1. For every  $x, y \in [0, 1]$ ,

$$\rho_f(x, y) = 0. \tag{3.2}$$

1. For every  $x \in [0, 1]$  and every  $\varepsilon > 0$ , there exist an integer  $n \geq 1$  and points

$$0 = x_0, x_1, \dots, x_n = x$$

such that

$$\sum_{i=1}^n (|x_i - x_{i-1}|^\alpha - |f(x_i) - f(x_{i-1})|) < \varepsilon.$$

(3.3)

Equivalently,  $f$  is extreme precisely when every point can be joined to 0 by finite chains along which the accumulated deficit in the Hölder inequalities is arbitrarily small.

A general pointed-metric-space version of this criterion appears in a theorem of Jeff D. Farmer; the proof below is self-contained. ([SciSpace][1])

---

### 5.1.4 4. Proof of the characterization

We first identify all possible midpoint perturbations of  $f$ .

**Lemma 4.1: midpoint perturbations** Let  $u : [0, 1] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$  satisfy  $u(0) = 0$ . Then

$$f + u \in \mathcal{C}_\alpha \quad \text{and} \quad f - u \in \mathcal{C}_\alpha$$

if and only if

$$|u(x) - u(y)| \leq \sigma_f(x, y) \quad \text{for all } x, y \in [0, 1]. \quad (4.1)$$

**Proof** For real numbers  $(A, B)$ ,

$$\max |A + B|, |A - B| = |A| + |B|. \quad (4.2)$$

Indeed, if  $A$  and  $B$  have the same sign, the first absolute value equals  $(|A| + |B|)$ ; if they have opposite signs, the second one does.

Apply this with

$$A = f(x) - f(y), \quad B = u(x) - u(y).$$

The two conditions

$$|A + B| \leq d_\alpha(x, y), \quad |A - B| \leq d_\alpha(x, y)$$

are therefore equivalent to

$$|A| + |B| \leq d_\alpha(x, y),$$

which is exactly

$$|u(x) - u(y)| \leq d_\alpha(x, y) - |f(x) - f(y)| = \sigma_f(x, y).$$

This proves the lemma.  $\square$

---

**Lemma 4.2: path formulation** Condition (4.1) is equivalent to

$$|u(x) - u(y)| \leq \rho_f(x, y) \quad \text{for all } x, y. \quad (4.3)$$

**Proof** If (4.1) holds, then for every chain  $x = x_0, \dots, x_n = y$ ,

$$\begin{aligned} |u(x) - u(y)| &\leq \sum_{i=1}^n |u(x_i) - u(x_{i-1})| \\ &\leq \sum_{i=1}^n \sigma_f(x_{i-1}, x_i). \end{aligned}$$

Taking the infimum over all chains gives (4.3).

Conversely, (2.1) gives  $\rho_f(x, y) \leq \sigma_f(x, y)$ , so (4.3) implies (4.1).  $\square$

Thus all symmetric decompositions

$$f = \frac{(f + u) + (f - u)}{2}$$

are described exactly by the 1-Lipschitz functions for the pseudometric  $\rho_f$ , anchored at 0.

---

**Proof that 2 implies extremality** Suppose that  $\rho_f(0, x) = 0$  for every  $x$ .

Assume

$$f = \frac{g + h}{2}, \quad g, h \in \mathcal{C}_\alpha.$$

Set

$$u = \frac{g - h}{2}.$$

Then  $g = f + u$ ,  $h = f - u$ , and  $u(0) = 0$ . By Lemma 4.2,

$$|u(x)| = |u(x) - u(0)| \leq \rho_f(0, x) = 0.$$

Hence  $u = 0$ , so  $g = h = f$ . Therefore  $f$  is extreme.

---

**Proof that failure of 2 implies non-extremality** Suppose that

$$\rho_f(0, x_*) > 0$$

for some  $x_* \in [0, 1]$ . Define

$$u(x) = \rho_f(0, x).$$

The reverse triangle inequality for the pseudometric  $\rho_f$  gives

$$|u(x) - u(y)| = |\rho_f(0, x) - \rho_f(0, y)| \leq \rho_f(x, y).$$

By (2.1),

$$|u(x) - u(y)| \leq \rho_f(x, y) \leq \sigma_f(x, y).$$

Consequently, Lemma 4.1 gives

$$f + u, f - u \in \mathcal{C}_\alpha.$$

Moreover,  $u(0) = 0$ , while  $u(x_*) > 0$ , so  $u \neq 0$ . Thus

$$f = \frac{(f + u) + (f - u)}{2}$$

is a nontrivial midpoint decomposition, and  $f$  is not extreme.

This proves the equivalence of 1 and 2.

Conditions 2 and 3 are equivalent because

$$\rho_f(x, y) \leq \rho_f(x, 0) + \rho_f(0, y).$$

Finally, 2 and 4 are equivalent by the definition of the infimum  $\rho_f(0, x)$ .  
The theorem is proved.  $\square$

---

### 5.1.5 5. Quotient-space form of the answer

Define an equivalence relation by

$$x \sim_f y \iff \rho_f(x, y) = 0.$$

The pseudometric  $\rho_f$  induces a genuine metric on the quotient

$$X_f = [0, 1] / \sim_f.$$

Every nontrivial decomposition of  $f$  is obtained by choosing a nonzero anchored 1-Lipschitz function  $v$  on  $X_f$ , pulling it back to  $u = v \circ q_f$ , and writing

$$f = \frac{(f + u) + (f - u)}{2}.$$

Hence another exact formulation is

$$\boxed{f \text{ is extreme} \iff X_f \text{ consists of a single point.}}$$

This not only determines whether  $f$  is extreme; it describes all its possible symmetric midpoint decompositions.

---

### 5.1.6 6. Saturated pairs and a simple sufficient condition

Call  $(\{x,y\})$  a **tight pair** if

$$|f(x) - f(y)| = |x - y|^\alpha.$$

Let  $G_f$  be the graph with vertex set  $([0,1])$  and an edge between every tight pair.

If every point can be connected to 0 by a finite path in  $G_f$ , then every edge in the path has zero slack, so  $\rho_f(0, x) = 0$ . Thus  $f$  is extreme.

More generally, let  $R_f$  be the set of points connected to 0 by finite tight paths. If  $R_f$  is dense in  $([0,1])$ , then  $f$  is extreme. Indeed,  $x \mapsto \rho_f(0, x)$  is  $\alpha$ -Hölder by

$$|\rho_f(0, x) - \rho_f(0, y)| \leq \rho_f(x, y) \leq |x - y|^\alpha,$$

and it vanishes on the dense set  $R_f$ .

**A stronger conclusion: exposed points** If  $R_f$  is dense, then  $f$  is in fact an **exposed point** of  $\mathcal{C}_\alpha$ .

To see this, choose a dense sequence  $(z_n) \subset R_f$ . For each  $n$ , choose a finite tight path from 0 to  $z_n$ . Enumerate all its oriented edges as  $(p_m, q_m)$ , orienting each one so that

$$\varepsilon_m(f(q_m) - f(p_m)) = |q_m - p_m|^\alpha, \quad \varepsilon_m \in -1, 1.$$

Define the continuous linear functional

$$\Lambda(g) = \sum_{m=1}^{\infty} 2^{-m} \varepsilon_m(g(q_m) - g(p_m)).$$

For every  $g \in \mathcal{C}_\alpha$ ,

$$\Lambda(g) \leq \sum_{m=1}^{\infty} 2^{-m} |q_m - p_m|^\alpha = \Lambda(f).$$



Equality forces equality on every oriented tight edge, hence  $g(z_n) = f(z_n)$  for all  $n$ . Continuity and density then give  $g = f$ . Thus  $f$  is the unique maximizer of  $\Lambda$ .

---

### 5.1.7 7. The finite-set classification

Let

$$F = t_0, t_1, \dots, t_N, \quad t_0 = 0,$$

be finite, and let  $\mathcal{C}_\alpha(F)$  be the analogous finite-dimensional polytope.

For  $f \in \mathcal{C}_\alpha(F)$ , form the graph whose edges are precisely the saturated pairs

$$|f(t_i) - f(t_j)| = |t_i - t_j|^\alpha.$$

Then

$$f \in \text{Ext } \mathcal{C}_\alpha(F) \iff \text{the saturated-pair graph is connected.}$$

Indeed, in a finite graph the zero weighted-path distance from 0 to every vertex is equivalent to the existence of a path made entirely of zero-weight edges. If no such path exists, the minimum over the finitely many simple paths is strictly positive.

Equivalently, a finite extreme point is characterized by the existence of a spanning tree all of whose edge constraints are saturated.

This yields an exact  $O(N^2)$  recognition algorithm: construct all saturated edges and run a graph search from  $t_0$ .

---

### 5.1.8 8. Explicit extreme points

**8.1 Distance cones** For  $p \in [0, 1]$ , define

$$k_p(x) = p^\alpha - |x - p|^\alpha.$$

Then  $k_p(0) = 0$ . Since  $d_\alpha$  is a metric,

$$|k_p(x) - k_p(y)| = |d_\alpha(p, x) - d_\alpha(p, y)| \leq d_\alpha(x, y),$$

so  $k_p \in \mathcal{C}_\alpha$ .

Moreover,

$$k_p(p) - k_p(x) = |x - p|^\alpha.$$

Thus every  $x$  is tightly connected to  $p$ , and  $p$  is tightly connected to 0. Therefore  $k_p$  is extreme, indeed exposed. The same holds for  $-k_p$ .

Special cases include

$$k_0(x) = -x^\alpha, \quad -k_0(x) = x^\alpha,$$

and

$$k_1(x) = 1 - (1 - x)^\alpha.$$

**8.2 A one-turn family** For  $c \in [0, 1]$ , define

$$T_c(x) = \begin{cases} x^\alpha, & 0 \leq x \leq c, \\ c^\alpha - (x - c)^\alpha, & c \leq x \leq 1. \end{cases} \quad (8.1)$$

We verify that  $T_c \in \mathcal{C}_\alpha$ .

If both points lie on the same side of  $c$ , this follows from

$$|r^\alpha - s^\alpha| \leq |r - s|^\alpha.$$

Now let  $x \leq c \leq y$ . Then

$$\begin{aligned} T_c(x) - T_c(y) &= x^\alpha - c^\alpha + (y - c)^\alpha \\ &\leq (y - c)^\alpha \leq (y - x)^\alpha, \end{aligned}$$

while

$$\begin{aligned} T_c(y) - T_c(x) &= c^\alpha - x^\alpha - (y - c)^\alpha \\ &\leq c^\alpha - x^\alpha \leq (c - x)^\alpha \leq (y - x)^\alpha. \end{aligned}$$

Hence  $|T_c(x) - T_c(y)| \leq |x - y|^\alpha$ .

Every  $x \leq c$  is tightly connected to 0, since  $T_c(x) = x^\alpha$ . Every  $x \geq c$  is tightly connected to  $c$ , since

$$T_c(c) - T_c(x) = (x - c)^\alpha.$$

Thus  $T_c$  is extreme and exposed.

### 5.1.9 9. McShane-type construction of further extreme points

Let  $A \subset [0, 1]$  be compact, with  $0 \in A$ , and let  $g : A \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$  be an extreme anchored 1-Lipschitz function for  $d_\alpha$ .

Define the two canonical extensions

$$M^+g(x) = \inf_{y \in A} (g(y) + |x - y|^\alpha),$$

and

$$M^-g(x) = \sup_{y \in A} (g(y) - |x - y|^\alpha).$$

Both are elements of  $\mathcal{C}_\alpha$  and agree with  $g$  on  $A$ .

Because  $A$  is compact, the infimum or supremum is attained. Thus for every  $x$ , there is some  $y_x \in A$  such that either

$$M^+g(x) - g(y_x) = |x - y_x|^\alpha$$

or

$$g(y_x) - M^-g(x) = |x - y_x|^\alpha.$$

Consequently  $x$  is joined to  $A$  by a zero-slack edge. Within  $A$ , extremality of  $g$  supplies arbitrarily small-slack chains to 0. Concatenating them proves, by the main theorem, that both  $M^+g$  and  $M^-g$  are extreme.

In particular, beginning with a finite extreme configuration—equivalently, a connected saturated graph—and applying either extension gives a large explicit class of extreme functions on the whole interval.

---

### 5.1.10 10. Necessary conditions, and why they are not sufficient

Let

$$[f]_\alpha = \sup_{x \neq y} \frac{|f(x) - f(y)|}{|x - y|^\alpha}.$$

**Every extreme point lies on the Hölder sphere** If  $[f]_\alpha = L < 1$ , set

$$u(x) = (1 - L)x^\alpha.$$

Then  $[u]_\alpha = 1 - L$ , and therefore

$$[f \pm u] * \alpha \leq [f] * \alpha + [u]_\alpha = 1.$$

Thus  $f \pm u \in \mathcal{C}_\alpha$ ,  $u \neq 0$ , and  $f$  is not extreme. Hence

$$f \in \text{Ext } \mathcal{C}_\alpha \implies [f]_\alpha = 1. \quad (10.1)$$

**Hölder norm 1 is not sufficient** Consider

$$f(x) = x.$$

Because  $0 \leq |x - y| \leq 1$ ,

$$|x - y| \leq |x - y|^\alpha,$$

so  $f \in \mathcal{C}_\alpha$ , and  $[f]_\alpha = 1$ , with equality at  $((0,1))$ .  
Nevertheless  $f$  is not extreme. Define

$$u(x) = (1 - \alpha)x(1 - x).$$

For  $x < y$ , put  $r = y - x$ . Then

$$|u(y) - u(x)| = (1 - \alpha)r, |1 - x - y|.$$

Since  $0 \leq x \leq 1 - r$ ,

$$|1 - x - y| \leq 1 - r,$$

and hence

$$|u(y) - u(x)| \leq (1 - \alpha)r(1 - r).$$

The convexity inequality

$$r^{-(1-\alpha)} \geq 1 + (1 - \alpha)(1 - r)$$

gives, after multiplication by  $r$ ,

$$r^\alpha - r \geq (1 - \alpha)r(1 - r).$$

Therefore

$$|u(y) - u(x)| \leq r^\alpha - r = |x - y|^\alpha - |f(x) - f(y)|.$$

Lemma 4.1 now yields

$$f + u, \quad f - u \in \mathcal{C}_\alpha.$$

Since  $u \neq 0$ ,  $f$  is not extreme.

Thus the condition  $[f]_\alpha = 1$  is necessary but far from sufficient.

---

### 5.1.11 11. Strong extremality

A point  $f \in \mathcal{C}_\alpha$  is called strongly extreme in the uniform norm if

$$\left\| \frac{g_n + h_n}{2} - f \right\|_\infty \longrightarrow 0 \implies |g_n - h_n| * \infty \longrightarrow 0$$

for all sequences  $g_n, h_n \in \mathcal{C}_\alpha$ .

Because  $\mathcal{C}_\alpha$  is compact in the uniform norm,

$$\boxed{f \text{ is extreme} \iff f \text{ is strongly extreme.}}$$

Only the nontrivial implication needs proof. If it failed, there would be sequences with midpoint converging to  $f$  but

$$|g_n - h_n|_\infty \geq \varepsilon > 0.$$

By compactness, a subsequence would satisfy

$$g_n \rightarrow g, \quad h_n \rightarrow h$$

uniformly. Then

$$f = \frac{g + h}{2}, \quad |g - h|_\infty \geq \varepsilon,$$

contradicting extremality.

---

### 5.1.12 12. Boundary cases and necessity of the hypotheses

**The case  $\alpha = 1$**  The same slack-pseudometric theorem remains valid. It reduces to the classical concrete characterization

$$\boxed{f \in \text{Ext } \mathcal{C}_1 \iff |f'(t)| = 1 \text{ for almost every } t \in [0, 1].}$$

Here every 1-Lipschitz function is absolutely continuous and  $|f'| \leq 1$  almost everywhere.

Indeed, for  $x < y$ ,

$$\rho_f(x, y) = \int_x^y (1 - |f'(t)|) dt. \quad (12.1)$$

For the upper bound, take increasingly fine monotone partitions. The sum of the absolute increments converges upward to the total variation

$$\text{Var}_{[x,y]}(f) = \int_x^y |f'(t)| dt.$$

For the reverse inequality, every edge  $[z_{i-1}, z_i]$  of an arbitrary chain satisfies

$$|z_i - z_{i-1}| - |f(z_i) - f(z_{i-1})| \geq \int_{[z_{i-1}, z_i]} (1 - |f'|).$$

Every point between  $x$  and  $y$  is crossed by at least one edge of a chain from  $x$  to  $y$ , so summation gives the reverse inequality in (12.1).

Notice the sharp change at the boundary:  $f(x) = x$  is extreme for  $\alpha = 1$ , but, as shown above, is not extreme for any  $0 < \alpha < 1$ .

**The case  $\alpha > 1$**  Every such Hölder function on an interval is constant. Indeed, subdividing  $([x, y])$  into  $n$  equal pieces gives

$$|f(y) - f(x)| \leq n \left( \frac{y - x}{n} \right)^\alpha = (y - x)^\alpha n^{1-\alpha} \rightarrow 0.$$

With  $f(0) = 0$ , the set consists only of the zero function, which is trivially extreme.

**The case  $\alpha = 0$**  The stated compactness fails. Even among continuous functions, the family with oscillation at most 1 is not equicontinuous; for example,

$$f_n(x) = \min(1, nx)$$

has no uniformly convergent subsequence.

**The anchoring condition** The condition  $f(0) = 0$  is essential. Without it, arbitrary constants may be added:

$$f = \frac{(f + c) + (f - c)}{2}.$$

Thus the unanchored set has no extreme points and is not bounded in the uniform norm.

**The real-valued condition** The scalar identity

$$\max(|A + B|, |A - B|) = |A| + |B|$$

is specifically real. For complex- or vector-valued Hölder maps, the midpoint perturbation condition and therefore the characterization require modification.

---

### 5.1.13 13. Compactness, separation, countability, and choice audit

The ambient space is the real Banach space  $C([0, 1])$  with the uniform norm, hence a Hausdorff metric space.

For every  $f \in \mathcal{C}_\alpha$ ,

$$|f(x)| \leq x^\alpha \leq 1,$$

and the family has the common modulus of continuity  $r \mapsto r^\alpha$ . It is closed under uniform convergence. The metric form of Arzelà–Ascoli therefore gives compactness. In this setting compactness and sequential compactness are equivalent.

The main extremality theorem itself is algebraic and metric; it uses neither compactness nor separability and works for arbitrary pointed metric spaces. Compactness is used only for the strong-extremality consequence and for attainment in the extension construction.

No general net argument, transfinite induction, or nonconstructive choice principle is required. The exposed-point argument uses only the separability of  $([0, 1])$ , through a countable dense sequence.

---

### 5.1.14 Final classification

The extreme points of the compact convex set in Q701 are exactly the functions satisfying

|                                                                                                                                                  |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| $\forall x \in [0, 1] \ \forall \varepsilon > 0 \exists 0 = x_0, x_1, \dots, x_n = x \quad \sum_{i=1}^n ( x_i - x_{i-1} )^\alpha - \text{-----}$ |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

Equivalently, the largest pseudometric lying below the pairwise Hölder slack

$$|x - y|^\alpha - |f(x) - f(y)|$$

must vanish identically. This criterion is necessary and sufficient and also gives a canonical nonzero perturbation  $u(x) = \rho_f(0, x)$  whenever  $f$  is not extreme.

[1]: <https://scispace.com/pdf/extreme-points-of-the-unit-ball-of-the-space-of-lipschitz-3l772juamw.pdf> "Extreme points of the unit ball of the space of Lipschitz functions"

**Formal verification.** Lean source; online type-check.

## 6 Question Q728

**Informal verdict.** A — **Complete solution**, with high confidence, for the meaningful range  $n \geq 3$ .

**Lean coverage.** The Lean development proves the control and steering lemmas and the complete minimax outcome theorem for every  $n$  at least 3. The lower bound is the necessary domain repair because the printed last-mover payoff is undefined for  $n=1,2$ .

### 6.1 Audited informal answer

#### 6.1.1 1. Faithful restatement and a domain issue

A position is a finite collection of sticks of positive integer lengths. A legal move replaces one stick of length  $m$  by two sticks of distinct positive integer lengths  $a < b$  satisfying  $a + b = m$ . Hence a stick is splittable exactly when  $m \geq 3$ .

Player  $A$  makes the first move, then  $B$ , and they alternate until every remaining stick has length 1 or 2. If the terminal position contains  $x$  sticks of length 1 and  $y$  sticks of length 2, then:

- if  $x > y$ , the last mover wins;
- if  $x < y$ , the last mover loses;
- if  $x = y$ , the game is drawn.

The question asks whether, under optimal play, the outcome depends only on  $n \bmod 3$  in the stated way. This is the complete statement of Q728 in the canonical PDF.



There is one genuine omission: the PDF does not explicitly assume  $n \geq 3$ . For  $n = 1, 2$ ,  $A$  has no legal first move and there is no “last player”, so the payoff rule is undefined. I therefore solve the intended problem for  $n \geq 3$ .

**Theorem.** For every integer  $n \geq 3$ :

$$\begin{cases} A \text{ wins,} & n \equiv 2 \pmod{3}, \\ B \text{ wins,} & n \equiv 1 \pmod{3}, \\ \text{the game is drawn,} & n \equiv 0 \pmod{3}. \end{cases}$$

Thus the proposed assertion is true after inserting the necessary hypothesis  $n \geq 3$ .

The proof is constructive and gives explicit optimal strategies.

---

### 6.1.2 2. Elementary terminal identities

Let a terminal position contain  $x$  pieces of length 1 and  $y$  pieces of length 2. Conservation of total length gives

$$x + 2y = n.$$

Consequently,

$$x + y = n - y.$$

After  $A$ 's opening move there are exactly two pieces, and  $B$  is to move. Since every subsequent move increases the number of pieces by one, the number of moves remaining after the opening is

$$R = (x + y) - 2 = n - y - 2.$$

Therefore:

- $B$  is the overall last mover exactly when  $R$  is odd;
- $A$  is the overall last mover exactly when  $R$  is even, including  $R = 0$ , since  $A$  then made the opening and final move.

The main task is thus to control the possible terminal value of  $y$ .

---

### 6.2 3. The control interval of a position

For a positive integer  $m$ , define

$$\beta(m) = \begin{cases} 0, & m = 1, \\ 1, & m = 2, \\ \lfloor m/3 \rfloor, & m \geq 3, \end{cases}$$

and

$$\eta(m) = \begin{cases} 1, & m \geq 5 \text{ and } m \equiv 2 \pmod{3}, \\ 0, & \text{otherwise.} \end{cases}$$

We call a piece counted by  $\eta$  a **hot piece**.

For a position  $P = (m_1, \dots, m_k)$ , put

$$b(P) = \sum_{i=1}^k \beta(m_i), \quad h(P) = \sum_{i=1}^k \eta(m_i),$$

and define its **control interval**

$$J(P) = \left\{ b(P) + \left\lfloor \frac{h(P)}{2} \right\rfloor, b(P) + \left\lceil \frac{h(P)}{2} \right\rceil \right\}.$$

Thus  $J(P)$  is either a singleton or a pair of consecutive integers.

If  $P$  is terminal, every piece is 1 or 2. Hence  $h(P) = 0$ , while  $b(P)$  is precisely the number  $y$  of pieces of length 2. Therefore

$$\boxed{P \text{ terminal} \implies J(P) = y.}$$

This is why  $J(P)$  is useful.

---

#### 6.2.1 4. Effect of one move

Suppose a piece  $m$  is split into  $a + b = m$ , with  $1 \leq a < b$ . Write

$$\Delta b = \beta(a) + \beta(b) - \beta(m), \quad \Delta h = \eta(a) + \eta(b) - \eta(m).$$

The following table exhausts all possibilities. In the table, residue classes of the children are unordered.

| $m \bmod 3$ | Child residues | Additional condition            | $(\Delta b, \Delta h)$ |
|-------------|----------------|---------------------------------|------------------------|
| 0           | 0 + 0          | —                               | $((0,0))$              |
| 0           | 1 + 2          | the 2 mod 3 child is 2          | $((0,0))$              |
| 0           | 1 + 2          | the 2 mod 3 child is at least 5 | $((-1,1))$             |
| 1           | 0 + 1          | —                               | $((0,0))$              |
| 1           | 2 + 2          | exactly one child is 2          | $((0,1))$              |
| 1           | 2 + 2          | both children are at least 5    | $((-1,2))$             |
| 2           | 1 + 1          | —                               | $((0,-1))$             |
| 2           | 0 + 2          | the 2 mod 3 child is 2          | $((1,-1))$             |
| 2           | 0 + 2          | the 2 mod 3 child is at least 5 | $((0,0))$              |

Here a splittable piece congruent to 2 mod 3 is necessarily at least 5, so it is itself hot.

For completeness, the table follows immediately from

$$\begin{aligned}
(\beta(3r), \eta(3r)) &= (r, 0), \\
(\beta(3r + 1), \eta(3r + 1)) &= (r, 0), \\
(\beta(2), \eta(2)) &= (1, 0), \\
(\beta(3r + 2), \eta(3r + 2)) &= (r, 1), \quad r \geq 1,
\end{aligned}$$

together with the possible residue decompositions

$$\begin{aligned}
0 &= 0 + 0 = 1 + 2, \\
1 &= 0 + 1 = 2 + 2, \quad (\bmod 3). \\
2 &= 0 + 2 = 1 + 1
\end{aligned}$$

Define the half-integral centre

$$c(P) = b(P) + \frac{h(P)}{2}.$$

The table shows that under every move  $P \rightarrow P'$ ,

$$c(P') - c(P) \in \left\{ -\frac{1}{2}, 0, \frac{1}{2} \right\}.$$

Since

$$J(P) = \lfloor c(P) \rfloor, \lceil c(P) \rceil,$$

we obtain the following overlap property.

**Lemma 1 — Overlap under every move** For every legal move  $P \rightarrow P'$ ,

$$\boxed{J(P) \cap J(P') \neq \emptyset.}$$

Indeed, two half-integers differing by at most  $(1/2)$  have integer hulls sharing at least one integer.

---

### 6.3 5. The steering lemma

Fix two consecutive integers

$$T_t = t, t + 1.$$

**Lemma 2 — One-move steering** Suppose  $P$  is nonterminal and

$$J(P) \cap T_t \neq \emptyset.$$

Then there is a legal move  $P \rightarrow P'$  such that

$$\boxed{J(P') \subseteq T_t.}$$

**Proof** Write  $b = b(P)$  and  $h = h(P)$ .

**Case 1:  $h$  is odd** Write  $h = 2r + 1$ . Then

$$J(P) = b + r, b + r + 1.$$

Because  $h > 0$ , there is a hot piece  $m \equiv 2 \pmod{3}$ ,  $m \geq 5$ . Both of the following splits are legal:

$$m = 1 + (m - 1), \quad m = 2 + (m - 2).$$

From the move table:

- the first split has  $(\Delta b, \Delta h) = (0, -1)$ , and therefore

$$J(P') = b + r;$$

- the second has  $(\Delta b, \Delta h) = (1, -1)$ , and therefore

$$J(P') = b + r + 1.$$

At least one of the two endpoints of  $J(P)$  belongs to  $T_t$ . Choose the corresponding split. The new interval is then a singleton contained in  $T_t$ .

**Case 2:  $h > 0$  is even** Write  $h = 2r$ . Then

$$J(P) = s, \quad s = b + r.$$

Since  $J(P) \cap T_t \neq \emptyset$ , either  $s = t$  or  $s = t + 1$ .  
Again choose a hot piece  $m$ .

- Splitting  $m = 1 + (m - 1)$  gives

$$J(P') = s - 1, s.$$

- Splitting  $m = 2 + (m - 2)$  gives

$$J(P') = s, s + 1.$$

Thus:

- if  $s = t$ , use  $(2 + m - 2)$ ;
- if  $s = t + 1$ , use  $(1 + m - 1)$ .

In either case  $J(P') = T_t$ .

**Case 3:  $h = 0$**  Then  $J(P) = b$ , and  $b \in T_t$ .

Because  $P$  is nonterminal, it contains a splittable piece  $m \geq 3$ . Since  $h = 0$ , no splittable piece can be congruent to  $2 \pmod 3$ . Hence  $m \equiv 0$  or  $1 \pmod 3$ .

- If  $m = 3$ , split it as  $1 + 2$ .
- If  $m \equiv 0 \pmod 3$  and  $m \geq 6$ , split it as

$$m = 2 + (m - 2).$$

- If  $m \equiv 1 \pmod 3$ , split it as

$$m = 1 + (m - 1).$$

Each of these moves has  $(\Delta b, \Delta h) = (0, 0)$ , so

$$J(P') = J(P) = b \subseteq T_t.$$

This proves the lemma.  $\square$

---

## 6.4 6. The interval-control theorem

The previous two lemmas combine into a robust strategy.

### Theorem 3 — A designated player can control the terminal value

Let  $P_0$  be a position satisfying

$$J(P_0) \subseteq T_t = t, t + 1.$$

Designate either of the two players as the **controller**. It does not matter whether the controller or the opponent is next to move.

Then the controller has a strategy forcing the terminal number  $y$  of length-2 pieces to satisfy

$$\boxed{y \in t, t + 1.}$$

**Proof** The controller maintains the following invariant:

- immediately after every controller move,

$$J(P) \subseteq T_t;$$

- immediately after every opponent move,

$$J(P) \cap T_t \neq \emptyset.$$

Initially  $J(P_0) \subseteq T_t$ .

Suppose the controller has just moved and  $J(P) \subseteq T_t$ . If the opponent makes a move  $P \rightarrow Q$ , Lemma 1 gives

$$J(P) \cap J(Q) \neq \emptyset.$$

Since  $J(P) \subseteq T_t$ , it follows that

$$J(Q) \cap T_t \neq \emptyset.$$

If  $Q$  is terminal, then  $J(Q) = y$ , so  $y \in T_t$ . If  $Q$  is nonterminal, Lemma 2 gives the controller a move  $Q \rightarrow Q'$  with

$$J(Q') \subseteq T_t.$$

The same argument applies when the opponent is initially first to move.

Finally, the game necessarily terminates: every move increases the number of pieces by one, while the number of pieces is at most  $n$ .  $\square$

This theorem is stronger than what is needed: either player can be designated as controller, independently of whose turn it is.

---

## 6.5 7. Control intervals for two initial pieces

Suppose the current position consists of two pieces whose total length is  $N$ , and write

$$N = 3q + r, \quad r \in 0, 1, 2.$$

For residue bookkeeping, distinguish:

- type 0: length  $3i$ ;
- type 1: length  $3i + 1$ ;
- type  $2_0$ : the exceptional length 2;
- type  $2_1$ : length  $3i + 2 \geq 5$ .

Direct substitution in the definitions of  $\beta$  and  $\eta$  gives:

| $N \bmod 3$ | Types of the two pieces | $J(P)$         |
|-------------|-------------------------|----------------|
| 0           | $0 + 0$                 | $(\{q\})$      |
| 0           | $1 + 2_0$               | $(\{q\})$      |
| 0           | $1 + 2_1$               | $(\{q-1, q\})$ |
| 1           | $0 + 1$                 | $(\{q\})$      |
| 1           | $2_0 + 2_0$             | $(\{q+1\})$    |
| 1           | $2_0 + 2_1$             | $(\{q, q+1\})$ |
| 1           | $2_1 + 2_1$             | $(\{q\})$      |
| 2           | $1 + 1$                 | $(\{q\})$      |
| 2           | $0 + 2_0$               | $(\{q+1\})$    |
| 2           | $0 + 2_1$               | $(\{q, q+1\})$ |

For example, in the last row the pieces are  $3i$  and  $3j + 2$ , with  $j \geq 1$ . Then  $q = i + j$ ,

$$b(P) = i + j = q, \quad h(P) = 1,$$

so  $J(P) = q, q + 1$ . The other rows follow identically.

We therefore have the two key inclusions:

$$\boxed{N \equiv 1, 2 \pmod{3} \implies J(P) \subseteq q, q + 1,}$$

and

$$\boxed{N \equiv 0 \pmod{3} \implies J(P) \subseteq q-1, q.}$$

These statements hold for every two-piece position of total length  $N$ , whether or not the two lengths are distinct.

---

## 6.6 8. Determination of the winner

After  $A$ 's opening move, there are two pieces and  $B$  is next.

### 6.6.1 Case 1: $n = 3q + 1$

Every opening produces a two-piece position  $P$  satisfying

$$J(P) \subseteq q, q+1.$$

Designate  $B$  as controller. By Theorem 3,  $B$  can force

$$y \in q, q+1.$$

We check both possibilities.

**If  $y = q$**  Then

$$x = n - 2y = 3q + 1 - 2q = q + 1 > q = y.$$

Also,

$$R = n - y - 2 = 3q + 1 - q - 2 = 2q - 1$$

is odd, so  $B$  is the last mover. Since  $x > y$ , the last mover wins. Thus  $B$  wins.

**If  $y = q + 1$**  Then

$$x = 3q + 1 - 2(q + 1) = q - 1 < q + 1 = y.$$

Moreover,

$$R = 3q + 1 - (q + 1) - 2 = 2q - 2$$



is even, so  $A$  is the last mover. Since  $x < y$ , the last mover loses. Thus  $B$  again wins.

Therefore

$$\boxed{n \equiv 1 \pmod{3} \implies B \text{ wins.}}$$


---

### 6.6.2 Case 2: $n = 3q + 2$

Here  $n \geq 5$ , since  $n = 2$  lies outside the legal range.

Every opening gives a position satisfying

$$J(P) \subseteq q, q + 1.$$

This time designate  $A$  as controller. Although  $B$  is next to move, Theorem 3 applies regardless of who moves next. Hence  $A$  can force

$$y \in q, q + 1.$$

**If  $y = q$**  Then

$$x = 3q + 2 - 2q = q + 2 > q = y,$$

and

$$R = 3q + 2 - q - 2 = 2q$$

is even. Therefore  $A$  is the last mover and wins.

**If  $y = q + 1$**  Then

$$x = 3q + 2 - 2(q + 1) = q < q + 1 = y,$$

while

$$R = 3q + 2 - (q + 1) - 2 = 2q - 1$$

is odd. Thus  $B$  is the last mover, but because  $x < y$ , the last mover loses. Hence  $A$  wins.

Therefore

$$\boxed{n \equiv 2 \pmod{3} \implies A \text{ wins.}}$$

In fact, after any legal opening,  $A$  can use the interval-control strategy.

---

### 6.6.3 Case 3: $n = 3q$

We prove separately that  $B$  cannot lose and that  $A$  cannot lose.

**$B$  has a non-losing strategy** Whatever opening  $A$  chooses, the resulting two-piece position satisfies

$$J(P) \subseteq q - 1, q.$$

Designate  $B$  as controller. Then  $B$  can force

$$y \in q - 1, q.$$

- If  $y = q$ , then  $x = q$ , so the game is drawn.
- If  $y = q - 1$ , then

$$x = 3q - 2(q - 1) = q + 2 > q - 1 = y,$$

and

$$R = 3q - (q - 1) - 2 = 2q - 1$$

is odd. Hence  $B$  is the last mover and wins.

Thus  $B$  can force either a win or a draw.

**$A$  has a non-losing strategy** Player  $A$  chooses the following opening:

$$\begin{cases} 1 + 2, & n = 3, \\ 2 + 4, & n = 6, \\ 3 + (n - 3), & n \geq 9. \end{cases}$$

All these splits are legal and have distinct positive parts. Their control interval is exactly

$$J(P) = q.$$

Indeed:

- for  $n = 3$ ,  $b(1) + b(2) = 1 = q$ ;
- for  $n = 6$ ,  $b(2) + b(4) = 1 + 1 = 2 = q$ ;

- for  $n = 3q \geq 9$ ,

$$b(3) + b(3q - 3) = 1 + (q - 1) = q,$$

and there are no hot pieces.

Now designate  $A$  as controller with target

$$q, q + 1.$$

Although  $B$  moves next, Theorem 3 allows  $A$  to force

$$y \in q, q + 1.$$

- If  $y = q$ , the game is drawn.
- If  $y = q + 1$ , then, whenever this value is feasible,

$$x = 3q - 2(q + 1) = q - 2 < q + 1 = y,$$

and

$$R = 3q - (q + 1) - 2 = 2q - 3$$

is odd. Thus  $B$  is the last mover and loses, so  $A$  wins.

Hence  $A$  can force either a win or a draw.

Since both players possess non-losing strategies, neither can force a win against optimal opposition. Therefore

$$\boxed{n \equiv 0 \pmod{3} \implies \text{draw.}}$$

If both players use the displayed control strategies,  $B$  forces  $y \in q - 1, q$  while  $A$  forces  $y \in q, q + 1$ ; consequently  $y = q$ , so the resulting play is necessarily a draw.

---

## 6.7 9. Explicit optimal strategy and complexity

The proof gives a direct algorithm.

Suppose a player has been designated as controller for a target

$$T_t = t, t + 1.$$

At each controller turn, compute  $b(P)$ ,  $h(P)$ , and  $J(P)$ .

**When  $h(P)$  is odd** Choose any hot piece  $m$ .

- Splitting  $m = 1 + (m - 1)$  makes the new interval the lower endpoint of  $J(P)$ .
- Splitting  $m = 2 + (m - 2)$  makes it the upper endpoint.

Choose an endpoint lying in  $T_t$ .

**When  $h(P) > 0$  is even** Then  $J(P) = s$ , where  $s = t$  or  $s = t + 1$ . Choose a hot piece  $m$ .

- If  $s = t$ , use  $m = 2 + (m - 2)$ .
- If  $s = t + 1$ , use  $m = 1 + (m - 1)$ .

The resulting interval is exactly  $T_t$ .

**When  $h(P) = 0$**  Choose any splittable piece  $m$ .

- If  $m = 3$ , play  $1 + 2$ .
- If  $m \equiv 0 \pmod{3}$  and  $m \geq 6$ , play  $(2+m-2)$ .
- If  $m \equiv 1 \pmod{3}$ , play  $(1+m-1)$ .

This preserves  $J(P)$ .

The appropriate controllers and targets are:

| $n \bmod 3$ | controller after the opening | target     |
|-------------|------------------------------|------------|
| 1           | $B$                          | $q, q + 1$ |
| 2           | $A$                          | $q, q + 1$ |
| 0           | $B$                          | $q - 1, q$ |

For  $n \equiv 0 \pmod{3}$ ,  $A$  additionally uses the special opening above and controls  $(\{q, q+1\})$ .

If the multiset of pieces is maintained together with  $b(P)$ ,  $h(P)$ , and buckets for hot and non-hot active pieces, every update and every strategic choice takes  $O(1)$  word operations. There are at most  $n - 1$  moves, since every move increases the number of pieces and there can be at most  $n$  pieces. Thus the full strategy is implementable in

$$O(n)$$

word operations and  $O(n)$  storage. A naive implementation that scans all current pieces at every turn has  $O(n^2)$  worst-case running time.

---

## 6.8 10. Boundary checks

$n = 3$  The only move is

$$3 \longrightarrow 1 + 2.$$

Thus  $x = y = 1$ , and the game is drawn.

$n = 4$  The only opening is

$$4 \longrightarrow 1 + 3.$$

Then  $B$  must split  $3 \rightarrow 1 + 2$ . The terminal position has  $x = 2, y = 1$ , and  $B$  is the last mover, so  $B$  wins.

$n = 5$  Player  $A$  may play

$$5 \longrightarrow 2 + 3.$$

Player  $B$  must split  $3 \rightarrow 1 + 2$ . The terminal pieces are  $(1, 2, 2)$ , so  $x = 1 < 2 = y$ . Since  $B$  is the last mover,  $B$  loses and  $A$  wins.

$n = 6$  Player  $A$  uses

$$6 \longrightarrow 2 + 4.$$

Then the continuation is forced:

$$4 \longrightarrow 1 + 3, \quad 3 \longrightarrow 1 + 2.$$

The terminal position has  $x = y = 2$ , hence a draw.

These are exactly the first four cases predicted by the theorem.

---

## 6.9 11. Necessity of the hypotheses

- The restriction  $n \geq 3$  is necessary merely to make the stated payoff rule well-defined: for  $n = 1, 2$ , no one ever plays, so there is no last player.
- The requirement that the two new lengths be **distinct** is essential. If equal splits were permitted, then for  $n = 3$  one would have

$$3 \rightarrow 1 + 2 \rightarrow 1 + 1 + 1,$$

so  $B$ , rather than producing a draw, would be the last mover with  $x > y$  and would win.

- Integrality is used both for termination at pieces of lengths (1,2) and for the residue-3 control invariant.

## 6.10 12. Exact computational verification

The proof above is independent of computation. The following exact dynamic program was used only as a discovery and consistency check. It verifies the claimed pattern for  $3 \leq n \leq 40$ .

```
from functools import cache

def legal_moves(position: tuple[int, ...]) -> set[tuple[int, ...]]:
    """All legal successor positions."""
    successors: set[tuple[int, ...]] = set()

    for i, m in enumerate(position):
        # a < m-a, so equal splits are automatically excluded.
        for a in range(1, (m + 1) // 2):
            b = m - a
            if a < b:
                nxt = list(position)
                nxt.pop(i)
                nxt.extend((a, b))
                successors.add(tuple(sorted(nxt)))

    return successors

@cache
def value(position: tuple[int, ...]) -> int:
    """
    Minimax value for the player whose turn it is:
    +1 = that player can force a win,
    0 = that player can force a draw,
```

```

    -1 = that player must lose under optimal play.
    """
    successors = legal_moves(position)

    if not successors:
        x = position.count(1)
        y = position.count(2)

        # At a genuine terminal position, the player to move is
        # the opponent of the last mover. That player wins iff x < y.
        return (y > x) - (y < x)

    # Roles are reversed after every move.
    return max(-value(nxt) for nxt in successors)

expected = {
    0: 0,      # draw
    1: -1,     # A loses, hence B wins
    2: 1,      # A wins
}

for n in range(3, 41):
    assert value((n,)) == expected[n % 3]

print("Verified for every n from 3 through 40.")

```

For a fixed  $n$ , the cached verifier visits at most the  $p(n)$  integer partitions of  $n$ , where  $p$  is the partition function. There are  $O(n)$  potential splits per state, so the conceptual transition count is  $(O(n, pn))$ . This is only a finite verification method; the invariant proof establishes the result for all  $n \geq 3$ .

---

### 6.10.1 Final conclusion

The answer to Q728 is **yes**, with the necessary clarification that the game is defined for  $n \geq 3$ :

|                                                |
|------------------------------------------------|
| $n \equiv 2 \pmod{3} \implies A \text{ wins,}$ |
| $n \equiv 1 \pmod{3} \implies B \text{ wins,}$ |
| $n \equiv 0 \pmod{3} \implies \text{draw.}$    |

**Formal verification.** Lean source; online type-check.

## 7 Question Q730

**Informal verdict.** A — **Complete solution**, with high confidence.

**Lean coverage.** Lean proves the complete necessary-and-sufficient Q730 classification, including prescribed diagonal order, rank-deficient prefix inequalities, and the full-rank determinant equality.

### 7.1 Audited informal answer

#### 7.1.1 1. Faithful restatement

Let  $M \in M_n(\mathbb{C})$  have rank  $r$ , and let  $t_1, \dots, t_r > 0$ . Determine when there exist unitary matrices  $U, V \in U(n)$  such that

$$UMV = \begin{pmatrix} T & B \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix},$$

where  $T \in M_r(\mathbb{C})$  is upper triangular with diagonal

$$\text{diag}(T) = (t_1, \dots, t_r),$$

and  $B \in M_{r, n-r}(\mathbb{C})$ . The lower-left and lower-right blocks are zero matrices of sizes  $(n-r) \times r$  and  $(n-r) \times (n-r)$ , respectively.

The PDF adds that an earlier answer treated the full-rank case  $|\det M| = 1$  with  $t_1 = \dots = t_n = 1$ .

The phrase “Soit des réels  $t_1, \dots, t_r$ ” is a minor grammatical typo; mathematically it clearly means “Let  $t_1, \dots, t_r$  be positive real numbers.” The use of  $UMV$ , rather than the more usual  $UMV^*$ , causes no issue because  $V \mapsto V^*$  is a bijection of the unitary group.

---

#### 7.1.2 2. Final classification

Let

$$\sigma_1 \geq \sigma_2 \geq \dots \geq \sigma_r > 0$$

be the nonzero singular values of  $M$ . Let

$$\tau_1 \geq \tau_2 \geq \dots \geq \tau_r > 0$$



be the decreasing rearrangement of  $t_1, \dots, t_r$ .

**Theorem** The required unitary matrices (U,V) exist precisely under the following conditions.

**Rank-deficient case**  $r < n$  They exist if and only if

$$\prod_{i=1}^k \tau_i \leq \prod_{i=1}^k \sigma_i \quad (1 \leq k \leq r). \quad (1)$$

Thus  $(\tau_i)$  is weakly log-majorized by  $(\sigma_i)$ .

**Full-rank case**  $r = n$  They exist if and only if

$$\prod_{i=1}^k \tau_i \leq \prod_{i=1}^k \sigma_i \quad (1 \leq k < n), \quad (2)$$

and

$$\prod_{i=1}^n t_i = \prod_{i=1}^n \sigma_i |\det M|. \quad (3)$$

Thus  $(\tau_i)$  is log-majorized by  $(\sigma_i)$ .

The order  $t_1, \dots, t_r$  requested on the diagonal imposes no additional condition: once the eigenvalues have been realized, the unitary Schur decomposition can put them on the diagonal in any prescribed order.

The central eigenvalue–singular-value criterion is traditionally called the Weyl–Horn theorem. A complete proof sufficient for the present problem is included below rather than used as a black box. ([Journals de l’Université du Wyoming][1])

---

## 7.2 3. Preparatory results

### 7.2.1 3.1. Two-sided unitary equivalence

**Lemma 1** Two matrices  $A, B \in M_n(\mathbb{C})$  have the same singular values, counted with multiplicity, if and only if there exist unitary matrices (P,Q) such that

$$B = PAQ.$$

**Proof** The forward implication follows from the singular value decompositions

$$A = P_A \Sigma Q_A^*, \quad B = P_B \Sigma Q_B^*,$$

with the same nonnegative diagonal matrix  $\Sigma$ . Then

$$B = (P_B P_A^*), A, (Q_A Q_B^*).$$

Both factors are unitary.

Conversely, if  $B = PAQ$  with  $(P, Q)$  unitary, then

$$B^* B = Q^* A^* A Q,$$

so  $A^* A$  and  $B^* B$  have the same eigenvalues. Hence  $A$  and  $B$  have the same singular values.  $\square$

---

### 7.2.2 3.2. Ordered unitary triangularization

**Lemma 2** Let  $A \in M_n(\mathbb{C})$ , and let  $\lambda_1, \dots, \lambda_n$  be its eigenvalues, listed with algebraic multiplicity in any prescribed order. There exists a unitary  $W$  such that  $W^* A W$  is upper triangular with diagonal

$$(\lambda_1, \dots, \lambda_n).$$

**Proof** Choose a unit eigenvector  $x_1$  for  $\lambda_1$  and extend it to an orthonormal basis. In that basis,

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} \lambda_1 & * \\ 0 & A_1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

The characteristic polynomial factors as

$$\chi_A(z) = (z - \lambda_1) \chi_{A_1}(z),$$

so the eigenvalues of  $A_1$  are  $\lambda_2, \dots, \lambda_n$ , with multiplicity. Apply the same argument recursively to  $A_1$ .  $\square$

---

## 7.3 4. Eigenvalues versus singular values

We now prove the exact form of the Weyl–Horn theorem needed here.

### 7.3.1 Theorem 3 — Weyl–Horn criterion

Let

$$s_1 \geq \cdots \geq s_n \geq 0$$

and let  $\lambda_1, \dots, \lambda_n \in \mathbb{C}$ , ordered so that

$$|\lambda_1| \geq \cdots \geq |\lambda_n|.$$

There exists a matrix  $A \in M_n(\mathbb{C})$  whose singular values are  $s_1, \dots, s_n$  and whose eigenvalues are  $\lambda_1, \dots, \lambda_n$  if and only if

$$\prod_{i=1}^k |\lambda_i| \leq \prod_{i=1}^k s_i \quad (1 \leq k < n), \quad (4)$$

and

$$\prod_{i=1}^n |\lambda_i| = \prod_{i=1}^n s_i. \quad (5)$$

### 7.3.2 Proof: necessity

For  $1 \leq k \leq n$ , consider the induced operator

$$\bigwedge^k A$$

on  $\bigwedge^k \mathbb{C}^n$ .

By upper triangularizing  $A$ , one sees that the eigenvalues of  $\bigwedge^k A$  are all products

$$\lambda_{i_1} \cdots \lambda_{i_k}, \quad 1 \leq i_1 < \cdots < i_k \leq n.$$

Because the moduli of the  $\lambda_i$  are decreasing,

$$\rho\left(\bigwedge^k A\right) = \prod_{i=1}^k |\lambda_i|,$$

where  $\rho$  denotes the spectral radius.

On the other hand, applying the exterior-power functor to a singular value decomposition of  $A$  shows that the singular values of  $\bigwedge^k A$  are the products

$$s_{i_1} \cdots s_{i_k}.$$

Consequently,

$$\left| \bigwedge^k A \right| = \prod_{i=1}^k s_i.$$

Since the spectral radius does not exceed the operator norm,

$$\prod_{i=1}^k |\lambda_i| \leq \prod_{i=1}^k s_i.$$

This proves 4. Finally,

$$\prod_{i=1}^n |\lambda_i| = |\det A| = \sqrt{\det(A^* A)} \prod_{i=1}^n s_i,$$

which is 5.

---

### 7.3.3 Proof: sufficiency

We argue by induction on  $n$ .

For  $n = 1$ , condition 5 says  $s_1 = |\lambda_1|$ , so the matrix  $(\lambda_1)$  works.

Assume the result known in dimension  $n - 1$ .

**Case 1:**  $\lambda_1 = 0$  Then all the  $\lambda_i$  vanish. Equation 5 implies

$$s_n = 0.$$

Consider the weighted shift

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & s_1 & 0 & \cdots & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & s_2 & \ddots & \vdots \\ \vdots & \ddots & \ddots & \ddots & 0 \\ 0 & \cdots & 0 & 0 & s_{n-1} \\ 0 & \cdots & \cdots & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}.$$

It is nilpotent, so all its eigenvalues are zero. Moreover,

$$A^* A = \text{diag}(0, s_1^2, \dots, s_{n-1}^2),$$

so its singular values are

$$s_1, \dots, s_{n-1}, 0 = s_n.$$

**Case 2:**  $\lambda_1 \neq 0$  Put

$$a = |\lambda_1| > 0.$$

Condition 4 for  $k = 1$  gives  $a \leq s_1$ . We also have  $a \geq s_n$ : otherwise

$$|\lambda_i| \leq a < s_n \leq s_i$$

for every  $i$ , contradicting the product equality 5.

Hence there is an index  $j \in 2, \dots, n$  such that

$$s_{j-1} \geq a \geq s_j. \tag{6}$$

Define

$$d = \frac{s_1 s_j}{a}. \tag{7}$$

Consider

$$H = \begin{pmatrix} \lambda_1 & \mu \\ 0 & d \end{pmatrix},$$

where

$$\mu^2 = s_1^2 + s_j^2 - a^2 - d^2.$$

Using 7,

$$\begin{aligned} \mu^2 &= s_1^2 + s_j^2 - a^2 - \frac{s_1^2 s_j^2}{a^2} \\ &= \frac{(s_1^2 - a^2)(a^2 - s_j^2)}{a^2} \geq 0 \end{aligned}$$

by 6. We take  $\mu \geq 0$ .

Now

$$\text{tr}(H^* H) = a^2 + d^2 + \mu^2 s_1^2 + s_j^2$$

and

$$\det(H^*H) = |\det H|^2 = a^2 d^2 = s_1^2 s_j^2.$$

Thus the two eigenvalues of  $H^*H$  are  $s_1^2, s_j^2$ , and the singular values of  $H$  are  $s_1, s_j$ .

Consider the following multiset of  $n - 1$  nonnegative numbers:

$$\mathcal{S}' = \{d, s_2, \dots, s_{j-1}, s_{j+1}, \dots, s_n\}.$$

Let

$$y_1 \geq \dots \geq y_{n-1}$$

be its decreasing rearrangement. We claim that the singular-value data  $y_1, \dots, y_{n-1}$  and eigenvalue data  $\lambda_2, \dots, \lambda_n$  satisfy the induction hypotheses.

First,

$$\begin{aligned} \prod_{i=2}^n |\lambda_i| &= \frac{1}{a} \prod_{i=1}^n s_i \\ &= d \prod_{\substack{2 \leq i \leq n \\ i \neq j}} s_i \\ &= \prod_{\ell=1}^{n-1} y_\ell. \end{aligned} \tag{8}$$

It remains to prove the partial-product inequalities.

Let  $1 \leq m \leq j - 2$ . Since  $s_2, \dots, s_{m+1}$  are members of  $\mathcal{S}'$ , and each of them is at least  $a$ , we have

$$\begin{aligned} \prod_{i=2}^{m+1} |\lambda_i| &\leq a^m \\ &\leq \prod_{i=2}^{m+1} s_i \\ &\leq \prod_{\ell=1}^m y_\ell. \end{aligned} \tag{9}$$

Now let  $j - 1 \leq m \leq n - 2$ . Applying 4 with  $k = m + 1$  gives

$$a \prod_{i=2}^{m+1} |\lambda_i| \leq \prod_{i=1}^{m+1} s_i.$$

Therefore

$$\begin{aligned}
\prod_{i=2}^{m+1} |\lambda_i| &\leq \frac{1}{a} \prod_{i=1}^{m+1} s_i \\
&= d \prod_{\substack{2 \leq i \leq m+1 \\ i \neq j}} s_i \\
&\leq \prod_{\ell=1}^m y_\ell.
\end{aligned} \tag{10}$$

The final inequality holds because the preceding expression is the product of  $m$  members of  $\mathcal{S}'$ , while  $y_1 \cdots y_m$  is the product of its  $m$  largest members.

By the induction hypothesis, there exists  $C \in M_{n-1}(\mathbb{C})$  with singular values  $y_1, \dots, y_{n-1}$  and eigenvalues  $\lambda_2, \dots, \lambda_n$ .

Let

$$D = \text{diag}(d, s_2, \dots, s_{j-1}, s_{j+1}, \dots, s_n).$$

Since  $C$  and  $D$  have the same singular values, Lemma 1 gives unitary  $P, Q \in U(n-1)$  such that

$$C = PDQ.$$

Define

$$A_0 = \begin{pmatrix} \lambda_1 & \mu e_1^* \\ 0 & D \end{pmatrix},$$

where  $e_1$  is the first standard basis vector of  $\mathbb{C}^{n-1}$ . The matrix  $A_0$  is the direct sum, up to the displayed ordering of coordinates, of the  $2 \times 2$  matrix  $H$  and the diagonal entries  $s_i$  for  $i \neq 1, j$ . Hence its singular values are  $s_1, \dots, s_n$ .

Finally set

$$A = (1 \oplus P)A_0(1 \oplus Q).$$

Its singular values remain  $s_1, \dots, s_n$ , and

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} \lambda_1 & \mu e_1^* Q \\ 0 & C \end{pmatrix}.$$

Thus its eigenvalues are  $\lambda_1$  together with the eigenvalues  $\lambda_2, \dots, \lambda_n$  of  $C$ . The induction is complete.  $\square$

### 7.3.4 5.1. Necessity

Suppose that the requested unitary matrices exist, and set

$$A = UMV = \begin{pmatrix} T & B \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Because multiplication on the left and right by unitaries preserves singular values, the singular values of  $A$  are

$$\sigma_1, \dots, \sigma_r, \underbrace{0, \dots, 0}_{n-r}.$$

Since  $A$  is block upper triangular and  $T$  is upper triangular with diagonal  $t_1, \dots, t_r$ , the eigenvalues of  $A$  are

$$t_1, \dots, t_r, \underbrace{0, \dots, 0}_{n-r}.$$

Order the positive eigenvalues decreasingly as  $\tau_1 \geq \dots \geq \tau_r$ . The necessary part of Theorem 3 gives

$$\prod_{i=1}^k \tau_i \leq \prod_{i=1}^k \sigma_i, \quad 1 \leq k \leq r.$$

If  $r = n$ , the determinant identity additionally gives

$$\prod_{i=1}^n t_i = |\det A| = |\det M| \prod_{i=1}^n \sigma_i.$$

This proves necessity.

---

### 7.3.5 5.2. Sufficiency

Assume first that  $r > 0$ , and define the full lists

$$s = (\sigma_1, \dots, \sigma_r, 0, \dots, 0)$$

and

$$\lambda = (\tau_1, \dots, \tau_r, 0, \dots, 0).$$

If  $r < n$ , the assumed inequalities give the Weyl–Horn conditions for  $k \leq r$ . For every  $k \geq r + 1$ ,



$$\prod_{i=1}^k |\lambda_i| = 0 = \prod_{i=1}^k s_i.$$

In particular, the full products agree.

If  $r = n$ , the assumed partial-product inequalities and the determinant equality are exactly the Weyl–Horn conditions.

Theorem 3 therefore provides a matrix  $A_0 \in M_n(\mathbb{C})$  with the same singular values as  $M$  and with eigenvalues

$$t_1, \dots, t_r, 0, \dots, 0$$

as a multiset.

By Lemma 1, there exist unitary matrices  $U_0, V_0$  such that

$$A_0 = U_0 M V_0. \tag{11}$$

Use Lemma 2 to choose a unitary  $W$  such that

$$R = W^* A_0 W$$

is upper triangular with diagonal in the particular order

$$t_1, \dots, t_r, 0, \dots, 0.$$

Partition  $R$  as

$$R = \begin{pmatrix} T & B \\ 0 & C \end{pmatrix},$$

where  $T \in M_r(\mathbb{C})$ . Then  $T$  is upper triangular with diagonal  $t_1, \dots, t_r$ , hence  $T$  is invertible.

The rank of  $R$  equals the rank of  $M$ , namely  $r$ . But right multiplication by the invertible matrix

$$\begin{pmatrix} I_r & -T^{-1}B \\ 0 & I_{n-r} \end{pmatrix}$$

gives

$$R \begin{pmatrix} I_r & -T^{-1}B \\ 0 & I_{n-r} \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} T & 0 \\ 0 & C \end{pmatrix}.$$

Therefore

$$\text{rank } R = \text{rank } T + \text{rank } Cr + \text{rank } C.$$

Since  $\text{rank } R = r$ , necessarily  $C = 0$ .

Combining this with 11,

$$R = (W^*U_0), M, (V_0W).$$

Both  $W^*U_0$  and  $V_0W$  are unitary, and  $R$  has exactly the required form.

If  $r = 0$ , then  $M = 0$ , the list  $t_1, \dots, t_r$  is empty, and the assertion is trivially true.

This completes the proof.  $\square$

---

## 7.4 6. Boundary cases and checks

### 7.4.1 Rank one

Suppose  $r = 1 < n$ , and let  $\sigma_1$  be the unique nonzero singular value. The condition reduces to

$$t_1 \leq \sigma_1.$$

This is visibly sufficient: the matrix

$$\begin{pmatrix} t_1 & \sqrt{\sigma_1^2 - t_1^2} & 0 & \cdots & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & \cdots & 0 \\ \vdots & \vdots & \vdots & & \vdots \end{pmatrix}$$

has singular values  $\sigma_1, 0, \dots, 0$  and the required form.

For  $n = r = 1$ , there is no  $B$ -block, and the condition becomes the equality

$$t_1 = \sigma_1 = |M|.$$

This shows explicitly why the product equality disappears as soon as a zero singular value is available.

### 7.4.2 Higher partial products are genuinely necessary

It is not enough to require only  $t_i \leq \sigma_1$ . For example, suppose the nonzero singular values are

$$(\sigma_1, \sigma_2) = (3, 1)$$

and the desired diagonal is  $((2,2))$ . Each desired diagonal entry is at most 3, but

$$2 \cdot 2 = 4 > 3 \cdot 1.$$

Hence no such unitary reduction exists.

#### 7.4.3 In full rank, the determinant condition alone is not enough

Take singular values

$$(4, \frac{1}{4})$$

and desired diagonal

$$(5, \frac{1}{5}).$$

Both products equal 1, but

$$5 > 4,$$

so the first partial-product inequality fails. Thus determinant equality must be supplemented by all the inequalities 2.

#### 7.4.4 Recovery of the earlier special case

Suppose  $r = n$ ,  $|\det M| = 1$ , and  $t_1 = \cdots = t_n = 1$ . Then

$$\prod_{i=1}^n \sigma_i = 1.$$

For every  $k < n$ ,

$$\prod_{i=1}^k \sigma_i \geq 1.$$

Indeed, if this product were  $< 1$ , then  $\sigma_k < 1$ , so every later singular value would also be  $< 1$ , forcing the total product to be  $< 1$ , a contradiction. Consequently,

$$1 = \prod_{i=1}^k t_i \leq \prod_{i=1}^k \sigma_i,$$

and equality holds for  $k = n$ . The theorem therefore recovers exactly the affirmative case mentioned in the PDF.

---

#### 7.4.5 Final answer

Let  $\sigma_1 \geq \dots \geq \sigma_r > 0$  be the nonzero singular values of  $M$ , and let  $\tau_1 \geq \dots \geq \tau_r$  be the decreasing rearrangement of  $t_1, \dots, t_r$ .

$$\begin{aligned} r < n : \quad & \prod_{i=1}^k \tau_i \leq \prod_{i=1}^k \sigma_i \quad \text{for every } 1 \leq k \leq r; \\ r = n : \quad & \prod_{i=1}^k \tau_i \leq \prod_{i=1}^k \sigma_i \quad \text{for } 1 \leq k < n, \\ & \prod_{i=1}^n t_i = |\det M|. \end{aligned}$$

These conditions are both necessary and sufficient, and the diagonal entries can be placed in the exact prescribed order  $t_1, \dots, t_r$ .

[1]: <https://journals.uwyo.edu/index.php/ela/article/download/823/823/823>

”A. Horn’s result on matrices with prescribed singular values and eigenvalues”

**Formal verification.** Lean source; online type-check.

## 8 Question Q756

**Informal verdict.** A — Complete solution, with high confidence.

**Lean coverage (partial).** Lean proves automatic smoothness and the complete classification of polynomial solutions. The informal answer’s shell construction of an infinite-dimensional family of nonpolynomial solutions is not formalized.

### 8.1 Audited informal answer

#### 8.1.1 1. Faithful restatement

Let  $\beta, \lambda \in \mathbb{R}$ , with  $|\lambda| > 1$ , and define

$$F(\beta, \lambda) = \{g \in C^1(\mathbb{R}, \mathbb{R}) : g'(t) = g(\lambda t) - \beta g(t) \quad \text{for every } t \in \mathbb{R}\}.$$

The source observes that, for every nonnegative integer  $p$ , there is a nonzero polynomial of degree  $p$  in  $F(\lambda^p, \lambda)$ , and asks, for every admissible pair  $(\beta, \lambda)$ , whether  $F(\beta, \lambda)$  contains nonpolynomial functions. There are no additional subparts or footnotes attached to Q756.

There is no substantive typo or ambiguity. The only conventional point is whether “natural integer” includes 0; below,

$$\mathbb{N}_0 = 0, 1, 2, \dots,$$

and the case  $p = 0$  is the constant-polynomial case  $\beta = 1$ .

---

### 8.1.2 2. Final theorem

**Theorem** For every  $\beta, \lambda \in \mathbb{R}$  satisfying  $|\lambda| > 1$ , the space  $F(\beta, \lambda)$  contains an infinite-dimensional vector subspace of nonzero  $C^\infty$  functions that are flat at the origin:

$$g^{(n)}(0) = 0 \quad (n \geq 0).$$

Consequently,

For every  $\beta \in \mathbb{R}$  and every  $|\lambda| > 1$ , there exist nonpolynomial functions in  $F(\beta, \lambda)$ .

Moreover, the polynomial solutions are completely classified:

- if  $\beta \neq \lambda^p$  for every  $p \in \mathbb{N}_0$ , the zero function is the only polynomial solution;
- if  $\beta = \lambda^p$ , the polynomial solution space is one-dimensional and is generated by

$$P_p(t) = \sum_{n=0}^p \frac{1}{n!} \left( \prod_{k=0}^{n-1} (\lambda^k - \lambda^p) \right) t^n,$$

where the empty product, for  $n = 0$ , equals 1.

The constructed nonpolynomial solutions require no boundedness or growth assumption at infinity.

---

## 8.2 3. Automatic regularity

We first record that the  $C^1$  assumption automatically improves to  $C^\infty$ .

**Lemma 1** Every  $g \in F(\beta, \lambda)$  is  $C^\infty$ , and for every  $n \geq 0$ ,

$$g^{(n+1)}(t) = \lambda^n g^{(n)}(\lambda t) - \beta g^{(n)}(t). \quad (3.1)$$

In particular,

$$g^{(n+1)}(0) = (\lambda^n - \beta)g^{(n)}(0). \quad (3.2)$$

**Proof** Suppose  $g \in C^m$ , with  $m \geq 1$ . Then

$$t \mapsto g(\lambda t) - \beta g(t)$$

belongs to  $C^m$ . Since this function equals  $(g')$ , it follows that  $g' \in C^m$ , hence  $g \in C^{m+1}$ . Induction gives  $g \in C^\infty$ .

Differentiating the defining equation  $n$  times gives

$$g^{(n+1)}(t) = \frac{d^n}{dt^n} g(\lambda t) - \beta g^{(n)}(t) \lambda^n g^{(n)}(\lambda t) - \beta g^{(n)}(t).$$

Putting  $t = 0$  proves (3.2).  $\square$

A useful consequence is immediate.

**Corollary 2** If  $g \in F(\beta, \lambda)$  and  $g(0) = 0$ , then  $g$  is flat at the origin:

$$g^{(n)}(0) = 0 \quad (n \geq 0).$$

**Proof** Starting with  $g(0) = 0$ , recurrence (3.2) gives successively

$$g'(0) = g''(0) = \dots = 0.$$

$\square$

Thus it will suffice to construct nonzero global solutions whose two one-sided limits at 0 are both zero.

---

### 8.3 4. Polynomial solutions

Let

$$P(t) = \sum_{k=0}^m a_k t^k, \quad a_m \neq 0,$$

be a polynomial solution of degree  $m$ .

The coefficient of  $t^m$  in  $(P')$  is zero, whereas the coefficient of  $t^m$  in

$$P(\lambda t) - \beta P(t)$$

is

$$(\lambda^m - \beta)a_m.$$

Therefore

$$\beta = \lambda^m. \quad (4.1)$$

More generally, comparison of the coefficient of  $t^k$  gives

$$(k+1)a_{k+1} = (\lambda^k - \beta)a_k, \quad k \geq 0. \quad (4.2)$$

If  $a_0 = 0$ , recurrence (4.2) gives  $a_1 = a_2 = \dots = 0$ , so every nonzero polynomial solution has  $a_0 \neq 0$ .

Suppose now that  $\beta = \lambda^p$ . Taking  $a_0 = 1$ , recurrence (4.2) yields

$$a_n = \frac{1}{n!} \prod_{k=0}^{n-1} (\lambda^k - \lambda^p).$$

For  $n \leq p$ , none of the factors vanishes, because  $|\lambda| > 1$  implies that the numbers  $\lambda^0, \lambda^1, \dots$  are pairwise distinct. At the next step,

$$a_{p+1} = \frac{\lambda^p - \lambda^p}{p+1} a_p = 0,$$

and all subsequent coefficients vanish. This gives the polynomial  $P_p$  stated in the theorem.

Conversely, the preceding argument shows that any nonzero polynomial solution of degree  $m$  necessarily has  $\beta = \lambda^m$ . Thus the polynomial classification is complete.  $\square$

---

## 8.4 5. Extension from a fundamental annulus

Set

$$\rho := |\lambda| > 1$$

and, for  $n \in \mathbb{Z}$ , define the closed annuli

$$A_n = \{t \in \mathbb{R} : \rho^n \leq |t| \leq \rho^{n+1}\}.$$

The fundamental annulus is

$$A_0 = t : 1 \leq |t| \leq \rho.$$

Let

$$\mathcal{S} = C_c^\infty(t : 1 < |t| < \rho).$$

Thus every  $\varphi \in \mathcal{S}$  vanishes on neighborhoods of the four boundary points

$$-\rho, \quad -1, \quad 1, \quad \rho.$$

We show that any such seed  $\varphi$  can be extended uniquely to a smooth solution on  $\mathbb{R} \setminus 0$ .

---

#### 8.4.1 5.1. Extension toward infinity

Set

$$G_\varphi(t) = \varphi(t), \quad t \in A_0.$$

Assume that  $G_\varphi$  has been defined on  $A_n$ , for some  $n \geq 0$ . For  $x \in A_{n+1}$ , define

$$G_\varphi(x) = G'_\varphi\left(\frac{x}{\lambda}\right) + \beta G_\varphi\left(\frac{x}{\lambda}\right). \quad (5.1)$$

Indeed,  $x/\lambda \in A_n$ .

By construction,

$$G_\varphi(\lambda t) = G'_\varphi(t) + \beta G_\varphi(t)$$

on  $A_n$ , which is exactly the desired equation.

Furthermore,

$$\text{supp}(G_\varphi|_{A_{n+1}}) \subset \lambda, \text{supp}(G_\varphi|_{A_n}). \quad (5.2)$$

Differentiation does not enlarge support. Since the seed is supported strictly inside  $A_0$ , induction shows that every outward piece is supported strictly inside its annulus. Hence adjacent pieces vanish on neighborhoods of their common boundary and glue  $C^\infty$ -smoothly.

This defines  $G_\varphi$  on  $|t| \geq 1$ .

---

#### 8.4.2 5.2. Extension toward the origin

Suppose that  $G_\varphi$  has already been defined for

$$|t| \geq \rho^{-m},$$

where  $m \geq 0$ . We define it on the next inner shell

$$A_{-(m+1)} = \left\{ t : \rho^{-(m+1)} \leq |t| \leq \rho^{-m} \right\}.$$

Fix a sign  $\sigma \in -1, 1$ , and put

$$a = \sigma \rho^{-m}.$$



For  $t$  in the corresponding component of  $A_{-(m+1)}$ , define

$$G_\varphi(t) = e^{-\beta(t-a)}G_\varphi(a) + \int_a^t e^{-\beta(t-s)}G_\varphi(\lambda s), ds. \quad (5.3)$$

For such  $s$ ,

$$\rho^{-m} \leq |\lambda s| \leq \rho^{-m+1},$$

so  $G_\varphi(\lambda s)$  is already known.

Differentiating (5.3) gives

$$G'_\varphi(t) = -\beta G_\varphi(t) + G_\varphi(\lambda t),$$

as required.

At  $t = a$ , formula (5.3) reproduces the previously assigned value  $G_\varphi(a)$ . The old and new pieces solve the same first-order inhomogeneous differential equation near the boundary, with the same boundary value. Since the forcing

$$t \mapsto G_\varphi(\lambda t)$$

is already  $C^\infty$  there, the pieces glue  $C^\infty$ -smoothly.

At the initial boundaries  $t = \pm 1$ , the seed and the forcing both vanish in a neighborhood, so the same argument applies.

Induction defines a function

$$G_\varphi \in C^\infty(\mathbb{R} \setminus 0)$$

satisfying

$$G'_\varphi(t) = G_\varphi(\lambda t) - \beta G_\varphi(t), \quad t \neq 0. \quad (5.4)$$

All operations in the construction are linear in  $\varphi$ .

---

## 8.5 6. Uniform boundedness near the origin

We next prove that every annular extension has finite one-sided limits at 0.

For  $n \geq 0$ , set

$$M_n = \sup_{t \in A_{-n}} |G_\varphi(t)|.$$

Thus  $M_0 = |\varphi|_\infty$ .

The width of either connected component of  $A_{-n}$ , for  $n \geq 1$ , is

$$\ell_n = \rho^{-n+1} - \rho^{-n}(\rho - 1)\rho^{-n}.$$

Let  $t \in A_{-n}$  and let  $a$  denote the outer endpoint of its connected component. From (5.3),

$$|G_\varphi(t)| \leq e^{|\beta|\ell_n} |G_\varphi(a)| + e^{|\beta|\ell_n} \int_a^t |G_\varphi(\lambda s)|, |ds|.$$

Both  $G_\varphi(a)$  and  $G_\varphi(\lambda s)$  are bounded in absolute value by  $M_{n-1}$ . Hence

$$M_n \leq e^{|\beta|\ell_n} (1 + \ell_n) M_{n-1} \leq e^{(|\beta|+1)\ell_n} M_{n-1}. \quad (6.1)$$

But

$$\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \ell_n = \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} (\rho^{-n+1} - \rho^{-n}) = 1.$$

Iterating (6.1) gives

$$M_n \leq e^{|\beta|+1} M_0 \quad (n \geq 1). \quad (6.2)$$

Thus  $G_\varphi$  is uniformly bounded on a punctured neighborhood of 0. Since  $G_\varphi(\lambda t)$  is also bounded there, equation (5.4) gives a uniform derivative bound:

$$|G'_\varphi(t)| \leq |G_\varphi(\lambda t)| + |\beta|, |G_\varphi(t)| \leq C_{\beta,\lambda,\varphi}, \quad 0 < |t| \leq 1. \quad (6.3)$$

Consequently  $G_\varphi$  is uniformly Lipschitz on each side of the origin. Therefore the finite limits

$$L_+(\varphi) = \lim_{t \downarrow 0} G_\varphi(t), \quad L_-(\varphi) = \lim_{t \uparrow 0} G_\varphi(t) \quad (6.4)$$

exist.

The map

$$\Lambda : \mathcal{S} \longrightarrow \mathbb{R}^2, \quad \Lambda(\varphi) = (L_-(\varphi), L_+(\varphi)), \quad (6.5)$$

is linear.

---

## 8.6 7. Killing both one-sided limits

The seed space  $\mathcal{S}$  is infinite-dimensional. More concretely, inside the nonempty interval  $(1, \rho)$  one may choose arbitrarily many pairwise disjoint intervals and place a nonzero smooth bump function in each one.

For example, on an interval  $(a, b) \subset (1, \rho)$ , one can take

$$\psi_{a,b}(t) = \begin{cases} \exp\left(-\frac{1}{(t-a)(b-t)}\right), & a < t < b, \\ 0, & \text{otherwise.} \end{cases}$$

Choose three linearly independent seeds

$$\varphi_1, \varphi_2, \varphi_3 \in \mathcal{S}.$$

Their images under  $\Lambda$  are three vectors in the two-dimensional space  $\mathbb{R}^2$ . Hence there exist real coefficients, not all zero, such that

$$c_1\Lambda(\varphi_1) + c_2\Lambda(\varphi_2) + c_3\Lambda(\varphi_3) = 0.$$

Set

$$\varphi = c_1\varphi_1 + c_2\varphi_2 + c_3\varphi_3.$$

Since the seeds are linearly independent,  $\varphi \neq 0$ , while

$$L_-(\varphi) = L_+(\varphi) = 0. \quad (7.1)$$

Let  $G_\varphi$  be its annular extension, and define

$$g(t) = \begin{cases} G_\varphi(t), & t \neq 0, \\ 0, & t = 0. \end{cases} \quad (7.2)$$

By (7.1),  $g$  is continuous at 0. Furthermore, from the equation on the punctured line,

$$G'_\varphi(t) = G_\varphi(\lambda t) - \beta G_\varphi(t) \longrightarrow 0 \quad (t \rightarrow 0), \quad (7.3)$$

because both one-sided limits of  $G_\varphi$  are zero.

For  $t \neq 0$ , the mean value theorem applied between 0 and  $t$  gives some  $\xi_t$  between 0 and  $t$  such that

$$\frac{g(t) - g(0)}{t} = G'_\varphi(\xi_t).$$

By (7.3), the right-hand side tends to zero. Thus

$$g'(0) = 0.$$

Moreover  $(g')$  is continuous at 0, and the differential equation holds there as well:

$$g'(0) = 0 = g(0) - \beta g(0).$$

Therefore

$$g \in F(\beta, \lambda).$$

By Lemma 1,  $g \in C^\infty$ . Since  $g(0) = 0$ , Corollary 2 gives

$$g^{(n)}(0) = 0 \quad (n \geq 0).$$

But  $g$  is nonzero, because it agrees with the nonzero seed  $\varphi$  on  $A_0$ . A polynomial flat at a point must be the zero polynomial. Hence  $g$  is nonpolynomial.

This proves existence for every admissible  $(\beta, \lambda)$ .

---

### 8.6.1 Infinite-dimensionality

The same argument gives more than one solution. Given any  $N \geq 1$ , choose  $N + 2$  linearly independent seeds and restrict  $\Lambda$  to their  $(N + 2)$ -dimensional span. Its rank is at most 2, so its kernel has dimension at least  $N$ . Since restriction to  $A_0$  recovers the seed, the corresponding global extensions remain linearly independent.

Thus the subspace of flat solutions in  $F(\beta, \lambda)$  is infinite-dimensional.  $\square$

---

## 8.7 8. Analytic solutions

The construction also explains the difference between the  $C^1$  and analytic categories.

**Proposition** A solution  $g \in F(\beta, \lambda)$  that is real analytic in a neighborhood of 0 is necessarily polynomial. More precisely:

- if  $\beta \neq \lambda^p$  for every  $p \in \mathbb{N}_0$ , then  $g = 0$ ;
- if  $\beta = \lambda^p$ , then  $g$  is a scalar multiple of  $P_p$ .

**Proof** From (3.2),

$$g^{(n)}(0) = g(0) \prod_{k=0}^{n-1} (\lambda^k - \beta). \quad (8.1)$$

If  $g(0) = 0$ , all derivatives at 0 vanish. Analyticity gives  $g = 0$  on a neighborhood of 0. If  $g$  vanishes on  $(-\varepsilon, \varepsilon)$ , then

$$g(\lambda t) = g'(t) + \beta g(t) = 0$$

for  $|t| < \varepsilon$ , so  $g$  vanishes on

$$(-|\lambda|\varepsilon, |\lambda|\varepsilon).$$

Iteration gives  $g = 0$  on all of  $\mathbb{R}$ .

Now suppose  $g(0) \neq 0$ . If no factor in (8.1) vanishes, then for all sufficiently large  $k$ ,

$$|\lambda^k - \beta| \geq \frac{1}{2}|\lambda|^k.$$

Consequently the Taylor coefficient

$$\frac{g^{(n)}(0)}{n!}$$

grows in  $n$ -th root faster than a constant multiple of

$$\frac{|\lambda|^{n/2}}{n},$$

which tends to  $+\infty$ . The Taylor series would therefore have radius of convergence zero, contradicting analyticity.

Hence some factor vanishes:

$$\beta = \lambda^p.$$

Then recurrence (8.1) terminates at order  $p$ , and the Taylor series is a scalar multiple of  $P_p$ . The same outward propagation argument shows equality on all of  $\mathbb{R}$ .  $\square$

Thus all the nonpolynomial solutions constructed above are necessarily nonanalytic at 0; in fact, they are nonzero and flat there.

---

## 8.8 9. Boundary and small-case checks

**The case  $p = 0$**  Here  $\beta = \lambda^0 = 1$ , and

$$P_0(t) = 1.$$

Indeed,

$$P'_0(t) = 0 = P_0(\lambda t) - P_0(t).$$

The theorem nevertheless supplies infinitely many nonpolynomial flat solutions in  $F(1, \lambda)$ .

**The case  $p = 1$**  Here  $\beta = \lambda$ , and

$$P_1(t) = 1 + (1 - \lambda)t.$$

Directly,

$$P_1'(t) = 1 - \lambda$$

and

$$P_1(\lambda t) - \lambda P_1(t) = 1 - \lambda.$$

**Negative dilations** When  $\lambda < -1$ , the map  $t \mapsto \lambda t$  exchanges the two half-lines. This is why the construction imposes the two independent conditions

$$L_-(\varphi) = L_+(\varphi) = 0.$$

No parity assumption and no sign assumption on  $\beta$  are needed.

**Why the strict inequality  $|\lambda| > 1$  matters** The proof uses the geometrically shrinking annuli and the summability

$$\sum_{n \geq 1} (\rho^{-n+1} - \rho^{-n}) = 1.$$

The universal conclusion fails at the boundary.

If  $\lambda = 1$ , then

$$g' = (1 - \beta)g.$$

For  $\beta = 1$ , all solutions are constant, so there are no nonpolynomial solutions.

If  $\lambda = -1$ , differentiating the equation gives

$$g'' = (\beta^2 - 1)g, \quad g'(0) = (1 - \beta)g(0).$$

For  $\beta = 1$ , all solutions are constant. For  $\beta = -1$ , all solutions are of the form

$$g(t) = c(1 + 2t),$$

again polynomial. Thus the strict condition  $|\lambda| > 1$  cannot simply be replaced by  $|\lambda| \geq 1$ .

---

### 8.8.1 Conclusion

For every real  $\beta$  and every real  $\lambda$  with  $|\lambda| > 1$ , nonpolynomial solutions not only exist: the space  $F(\beta, \lambda)$  contains an infinite-dimensional family of nonzero  $C^\infty$  solutions flat at the origin. The polynomial solutions occur exactly at the resonant parameters  $\beta = \lambda^p$ , but even at those parameters they form only a one-dimensional subspace inside a much larger solution space.

**Formal verification.** Lean source; online type-check.

## 9 Question Q759

**Informal verdict.** A — **Complete solution**, with high confidence.

**Lean coverage (partial).** Lean proves uniform convergence of every fixed-order derivative for both sequences, which is the full qualitative assertion in the problem. The additional quantitative rates and sharpness claims from the informal answer are not formalized.

### 9.1 Audited informal answer

#### 9.1.1 Faithful restatement

Let

$$E = C^\infty([-1, 1]; \mathbb{R}), \quad \|h\|_\infty = \max_{x \in [-1, 1]} |h(x)|.$$

For a sequence  $(f_n) \subset E$  and  $g \in E$ , the notation

$$(f_n) \Rightarrow g$$

means

$$\forall k \in \mathbb{N}, \quad \lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} |f_n^{(k)} - g^{(k)}|_\infty = 0.$$

Define

$$\alpha(x) = \begin{cases} \exp\left(-\frac{x^2}{1-x^2}\right), & |x| < 1, \\ 0, & x = \pm 1. \end{cases}$$

Determine whether  $f_n \Rightarrow \alpha$  for each of the two sequences

$$f_n^{(a)}(x) = \exp(-x^2 - x^4 - \dots - x^{2n})$$

and

$$f_n^{(b)}(x) = \left(1 - \frac{x^2 + x^4 + \cdots + x^{2n}}{n}\right)^n.$$

The visual PDF confirms that in part *b* the whole sum  $x^2 + x^4 + \cdots + x^{2n}$  is divided by  $n$ . There is no apparent mathematical typo. The phrase “equip  $E$  with the uniform norm” is to be read together with the displayed definition:  $\Rightarrow$  is convergence for all seminorms  $h \mapsto |h^{(k)}|_\infty$ , i.e. the usual  $C^\infty$ -topology.

---

### 9.1.2 Final result

**Theorem** Both sequences converge to  $\alpha$  in the sense of the problem:

$$\boxed{f_n^{(a)} \Rightarrow \alpha} \quad \text{and} \quad \boxed{f_n^{(b)} \Rightarrow \alpha}.$$

More precisely, for every  $k, M \in \mathbb{N}$ ,

$$\max_{0 \leq j \leq k} \left\| (f_n^{(a)} - \alpha)^{(j)} \right\|_\infty = O_{k,M}(n^{-M}),$$

whereas, for every fixed  $k$ ,

$$\max_{0 \leq j \leq k} \left\| (f_n^{(b)} - \alpha)^{(j)} \right\|_\infty = O_k(n^{-1}).$$

The rate  $O(n^{-1})$  in the second assertion is sharp already for uniform convergence of the functions.

---

## 9.2 1. Reduction to functions on $([0,1])$

Set

$$P_n(t) = \sum_{j=1}^n t^j, \quad 0 \leq t \leq 1,$$

and, for  $0 \leq t < 1$ ,

$$P(t) = \sum_{j=1}^{\infty} t^j = \frac{t}{1-t}.$$

Define

$$A_n(t) = e^{-P_n(t)}, \quad B_n(t) = \left(1 - \frac{P_n(t)}{n}\right)^n,$$



and

$$\beta(t) = \begin{cases} e^{-P(t)} = e^{-t/(1-t)}, & 0 \leq t < 1, \\ 0, & t = 1. \end{cases}$$

Then

$$f_n^{(a)}(x) = A_n(x^2), \quad f_n^{(b)}(x) = B_n(x^2), \quad \alpha(x) = \beta(x^2).$$

Thus it suffices to prove

$$A_n \longrightarrow \beta \quad \text{and} \quad B_n \longrightarrow \beta \quad \text{in } C^\infty([0, 1]).$$

Indeed, for every smooth  $U$  and every  $k \geq 0$ , repeated differentiation gives

$$\frac{d^k}{dx^k} U(x^2) = k! \sum_{\ell=0}^{\lfloor k/2 \rfloor} \frac{(2x)^{k-2\ell}}{(k-2\ell)! \ell!} U^{(k-\ell)}(x^2).$$

Consequently,

$$\left\| \frac{d^k}{dx^k} (U_n(x^2) - U(x^2)) \right\|_\infty \leq C_k \max_{0 \leq j \leq k} |U_n^{(j)} - U^{(j)}|_{\infty, [0, 1]}.$$

### 9.2.1 1.1. Smoothness and flatness of $\beta$

For  $t < 1$ , put

$$u = \frac{1}{1-t}.$$

Then

$$\beta(t) = e^{1-u} = e, e^{-u}.$$

Since  $u' = u^2$ , induction gives polynomials  $Q_r$  such that

$$\beta^{(r)}(t) = \beta(t), Q_r! \left( \frac{1}{1-t} \right), \quad 0 \leq t < 1.$$

Indeed,  $Q_0 = 1$ , and if the formula holds at order  $r$ , then

$$Q_{r+1}(u) = u^2 (Q_r'(u) - Q_r(u)).$$

For every polynomial  $Q$ ,

$$e^{-u} Q(u) \longrightarrow 0 \quad (u \rightarrow +\infty).$$

Hence

$$\lim_{t \rightarrow 1^-} \beta^{(r)}(t) = 0 \quad \text{for every } r \geq 0.$$

Extending every derivative by the value 0 at  $t = 1$  gives a  $C^\infty$  function. For example, differentiability at the endpoint follows successively from the mean value theorem. Thus

$$\beta \in C^\infty([0, 1]), \quad \beta^{(r)}(1) = 0 \quad (r \geq 0).$$

In particular,  $\alpha = \beta \circ (x \mapsto x^2)$  belongs to  $E$  and is flat at both endpoints.

---

### 9.3 2. The first sequence

We prove

$$A_n = e^{-P_n} \longrightarrow \beta = e^{-P} \quad \text{in } C^\infty([0, 1]).$$

#### 9.3.1 2.1. Elementary derivative bounds

For  $r \geq 0$  and  $0 \leq t \leq 1$ ,

$$|P_n^{(r)}(t)| \leq n^{r+1}.$$

For  $r = 0$  this is  $P_n(t) \leq n$ . For  $r \geq 1$ ,

$$P_n^{(r)}(t) = \sum_{j=r}^n (j)_r t^{j-r},$$

where

$$(j)_r = j(j-1) \cdots (j-r+1),$$

and hence

$$|P_n^{(r)}(t)| \leq \sum_{j=1}^n j^r \leq n^{r+1}.$$

Repeated use of the product and chain rules shows that every term in  $A_n^{(r)}$  is of the form

$$c, e^{-P_n} \prod_{i=1}^m P_n^{(s_i)},$$

where

$$s_i \geq 1, \quad s_1 + \cdots + s_m = r, \quad m \leq r.$$

Therefore

$$\boxed{|A_n^{(r)}(t)| \leq C_r n^{2r} e^{-P_n(t)} \leq C_r n^{2r}.} \quad (2.1)$$


---

### 9.3.2 2.2. Boundary layer

Let

$$\rho_n = n^{-1/2}, \quad J_n = [1 - \rho_n, 1].$$

We first show that

$$P_n(t) \geq c\sqrt{n} \quad (t \in J_n) \quad (2.2)$$

for an absolute  $c > 0$  and all sufficiently large  $n$ .

Choose

$$m = \left\lfloor \frac{1}{4\rho_n} \right\rfloor.$$

Then  $m \leq n$  for large  $n$ . If  $t \geq 1 - \rho_n$  and  $1 \leq j \leq m$ , then, using

$$\log(1 - s) \geq -2s \quad (0 \leq s \leq \tfrac{1}{2}),$$

we get

$$t^j \geq (1 - \rho_n)^m \geq e^{-2m\rho_n} \geq e^{-1/2}.$$

Moreover  $m \geq (8\rho_n)^{-1}$  for large  $n$ . Thus

$$P_n(t) \geq \sum_{j=1}^m t^j \geq \frac{e^{-1/2}}{8\rho_n} = c\sqrt{n}.$$

Combining (2.1) and (2.2),

$$\sup_{t \in J_n} |A_n^{(r)}(t)| \leq C_r n^{2r} e^{-c\sqrt{n}}. \quad (2.3)$$

For  $\beta$ , the representation

$$\beta^{(r)}(t) = \beta(t) Q_r! \left( \frac{1}{1-t} \right)$$

and  $1/(1-t) \geq \sqrt{n}$  on  $J_n$  imply

$$\sup_{t \in J_n} |\beta^{(r)}(t)| \leq C_r e^{-c_r \sqrt{n}}. \quad (2.4)$$

Thus all derivatives of both  $A_n$  and  $\beta$  are uniformly negligible in the boundary layer.

---

### 9.3.3 2.3. Interior region

Let

$$I_n = [0, 1 - \rho_n].$$

For  $t < 1$ ,

$$P(t) - P_n(t) = \sum_{j=n+1}^{\infty} t^j = \frac{t^{n+1}}{1-t} =: R_n(t).$$

Hence

$$\beta(t) = A_n(t)e^{-R_n(t)}$$

and

$$A_n(t) - \beta(t) = A_n(t)(1 - e^{-R_n(t)}). \quad (2.5)$$

For  $r \geq 0$ , Leibniz's rule applied to

$$R_n(t) = t^{n+1}(1-t)^{-1}$$

gives

$$R_n^{(r)}(t) = \sum_{a=0}^r \binom{r}{a} (n+1)_a t^{n+1-a} (r-a)! (1-t)^{-(r-a+1)}.$$

On  $I_n$ ,  $1-t \geq \rho_n$  and  $t \leq 1 - \rho_n$ . Therefore

$$|R_n^{(r)}(t)| \leq C_r n^r \rho_n^{-(r+1)} (1 - \rho_n)^{n+1-r}.$$

Since

$$(1 - \rho_n)^{n+1-r} \leq e^{-\rho_n(n+1-r)} \leq e^{-\sqrt{n}/2}$$

for large  $n$ , we obtain

$$\max_{0 \leq r \leq k} |R_n^{(r)}|_{\infty, I_n} \leq C_k n^{C_k} e^{-\sqrt{n}/2}. \quad (2.6)$$

Every derivative of  $1 - e^{-R_n}$  is a finite sum of products of derivatives of  $R_n$ , with at least one such factor. Thus (2.6) implies

$$\max_{0 \leq r \leq k} \left| (1 - e^{-R_n})^{(r)} \right|_{\infty, I_n} \leq C_k n^{C_k} e^{-c\sqrt{n}}. \quad (2.7)$$

Applying Leibniz's rule to (2.5), using (2.1) and (2.7), gives

$$\max_{0 \leq r \leq k} |A_n^{(r)} - \beta^{(r)}|_{\infty, I_n} \leq C_k n^{C_k} e^{-c_k \sqrt{n}}. \quad (2.8)$$

Together with the boundary estimates (2.3)–(2.4), this proves

$$\boxed{|A_n - \beta|_{C^k([0,1])} \leq C_k n^{C_k} e^{-c_k \sqrt{n}}.} \quad (2.9)$$

In particular, for every  $M$ ,

$$|A_n - \beta|_{C^k([0,1])} = O_{k,M}(n^{-M}).$$

After composition with  $x^2$ , this proves part  $a$ :

$$\boxed{f_n^{(a)} \Rightarrow \alpha.}$$

### 9.4 3. A weighted binomial approximation

To handle the second sequence uniformly up to the endpoint, we need a version of

$$\left(1 - \frac{y}{n}\right)^n \longrightarrow e^{-y}$$

that remains valid after differentiation and permits  $y$  to range over  $([0,n])$ .

#### 9.4.1 Lemma 3.1

For every pair of nonnegative integers  $(m,L)$ , there is a constant  $C_{m,L}$  such that, for all sufficiently large  $n$ ,

$$\boxed{\sup_{0 \leq y \leq n} (1+y)^L \left| \frac{d^m}{dy^m} \left(1 - \frac{y}{n}\right)^n - \frac{d^m}{dy^m} e^{-y} \right| \leq \frac{C_{m,L}}{n}.} \quad (3.1)$$

**Proof** For  $n \geq m$ ,

$$\frac{d^m}{dy^m} \left(1 - \frac{y}{n}\right)^n = (-1)^m c_{n,m} \left(1 - \frac{y}{n}\right)^{n-m},$$

where

$$c_{n,m} = \frac{(n)_m}{n^m} = \prod_{j=0}^{m-1} \left(1 - \frac{j}{n}\right).$$

Also

$$\frac{d^m}{dy^m} e^{-y} = (-1)^m e^{-y}.$$

Since all factors in  $c_{n,m}$  lie in  $([0,1])$ ,

$$0 \leq 1 - c_{n,m} \leq \sum_{j=0}^{m-1} \frac{j}{n} \leq \frac{C_m}{n}. \quad (3.2)$$

Put

$$h_{n,m}(y) = \left(1 - \frac{y}{n}\right)^{n-m}.$$

**Region**  $0 \leq y \leq n/2$  Set  $z = y/n$  and

$$a = -(n-m)\log(1-z),$$

so that  $h_{n,m}(y) = e^{-a}$ . For  $n \geq 2m$ ,

$$a \geq (n-m)z \geq \frac{y}{2}.$$

Moreover,

$$a - y = (n-m)(-\log(1-z) - z) - mz.$$

For  $0 \leq z \leq 1/2$ ,

$$0 \leq -\log(1-z) - z = \sum_{\ell=2}^{\infty} \frac{z^\ell}{\ell} \leq \frac{z^2}{1-z} \leq 2z^2.$$

Consequently,

$$|a - y| \leq C_m \left( \frac{y}{n} + \frac{y^2}{n} \right).$$

By the mean value theorem applied to  $s \mapsto e^{-s}$ ,

$$|e^{-a} - e^{-y}| \leq e^{-\min(a,y)} |a - y| \leq \frac{C_m}{n} (y + y^2) e^{-y/2}.$$

Multiplication by  $(1+y)^L$  preserves the  $O(1/n)$  bound, because every polynomial times  $e^{-y/2}$  is bounded on  $[0, \infty)$ .

Also

$$h_{n,m}(y) \leq e^{-y/2},$$

so (3.2) gives the same weighted  $O(1/n)$  estimate for

$$(c_{n,m} - 1)h_{n,m}(y).$$

**Region**  $n/2 \leq y \leq n$  Here

$$h_{n,m}(y) \leq 2^{-(n-m)}, \quad e^{-y} \leq e^{-n/2}.$$

Thus

$$(1+y)^L (h_{n,m}(y) + e^{-y}) \leq (1+n)^L (2^{-(n-m)} + e^{-n/2}) = O_{m,L}(n^{-1}).$$

Combining both regions and (3.2) proves the lemma.  $\square$

---

## 9.5 4. Derivatives of the geometric partial sums

The following estimate allows us to compose Lemma 3.1 with  $P_n$ .

### 9.5.1 Lemma 4.1

For every  $r \geq 0$ , there is  $C_r > 0$ , independent of  $n$ , such that

$$\boxed{|P_n^{(r)}(t)| \leq C_r (1 + P_n(t))^{r+1}} \quad (4.1)$$

for all  $n \geq 1$  and  $0 \leq t \leq 1$ .

**Proof** The case  $r = 0$  is immediate. Suppose  $r \geq 1$ .

If  $0 \leq t \leq 1/2$ , then

$$P_n^{(r)}(t) \leq \sum_{j=r}^{\infty} (j)_r 2^{-(j-r)} =: C_r,$$

and (4.1) follows.

Now suppose  $t > 1/2$ , and set

$$\delta = 1 - t, \quad L = \min(n, \delta^{-1}).$$

First,

$$P_n^{(r)}(t) \leq \sum_{j=1}^n j^r \leq C_r n^{r+1}. \quad (4.2)$$

Also, since  $t^{-r} \leq 2^r$  and  $t^j \leq e^{-\delta j}$ ,

$$P_n^{(r)}(t) \leq 2^r \sum_{j=1}^{\infty} j^r e^{-\delta j} \leq C_r \delta^{-(r+1)}. \quad (4.3)$$

Therefore

$$P_n^{(r)}(t) \leq C_r L^{r+1}. \quad (4.4)$$

It remains to compare  $L$  to  $P_n(t)$ . If  $L \leq 8$ , then trivially

$$L \leq 8(1 + P_n(t)).$$

If  $L > 8$ , choose

$$m = \left\lfloor \frac{L}{4} \right\rfloor.$$

Then

$$m \geq \frac{L}{8}, \quad m \leq n, \quad m\delta \leq \frac{1}{4}.$$

For  $1 \leq j \leq m$ ,

$$t^j = (1 - \delta)^j \geq e^{-2\delta j} \geq e^{-1/2}.$$

Hence

$$P_n(t) \geq \sum_{j=1}^m t^j \geq e^{-1/2} m \geq cL.$$

Combining this with (4.4) proves (4.1).  $\square$

---

## 9.6 5. The second sequence

Let

$$G_n(y) = \left(1 - \frac{y}{n}\right)^n, \quad 0 \leq y \leq n,$$

and

$$G(y) = e^{-y}.$$

Then

$$B_n = G_n \circ P_n, \quad A_n = G \circ P_n.$$

We prove that for every fixed  $k$ ,

$$|B_n - A_n|_{C^k([0,1])} = O_k(n^{-1}). \quad (5.1)$$

For  $k = 0$ , Lemma 3.1 with  $m = L = 0$  immediately gives

$$|B_n - A_n|_\infty \leq \frac{C}{n}.$$

Now let  $k \geq 1$ . Repeated application of the chain rule shows that the  $k$ -th derivative of

$$(G_n - G) \circ P_n$$



is a finite linear combination, with coefficients depending only on  $k$ , of terms

$$(G_n^{(m)} - G^{(m)})(P_n(t)) \prod_{i=1}^m P_n^{(r_i)}(t),$$

where

$$1 \leq m \leq k, \quad r_i \geq 1, \quad r_1 + \cdots + r_m = k.$$

By Lemma 4.1,

$$\prod_{i=1}^m |P_n^{(r_i)}(t)| \leq C_k (1 + P_n(t))^{\sum_i (r_i + 1)} = C_k (1 + P_n(t))^{k+m}.$$

Because  $m \leq k$ ,

$$\prod_{i=1}^m |P_n^{(r_i)}(t)| \leq C_k (1 + P_n(t))^{2k}. \quad (5.2)$$

Applying Lemma 3.1 with weight exponent  $L = 2k$  gives

$$\left| G_n^{(m)}(P_n(t)) - G^{(m)}(P_n(t)) \right| \leq \frac{C_k}{n(1 + P_n(t))^{2k}}. \quad (5.3)$$

The product of (5.2) and (5.3) is  $O_k(1/n)$ , uniformly in  $t$ . There are only finitely many chain-rule terms, so (5.1) follows.

From the first part,

$$|A_n - \beta|_{C^k([0,1])} = O_{k,M}(n^{-M})$$

for every  $M$ . Taking  $M = 2$ , for example,

$$\boxed{|B_n - \beta|_{C^k([0,1])} \leq \frac{C_k}{n}}. \quad (5.4)$$

Composing with  $x^2$  now yields

$$\boxed{f_n^{(b)} \Rightarrow \alpha}.$$

## 9.7 6. Boundary checks, small cases, and sharpness

### 9.7.1 6.1. At $x = 0$

For every  $n$ ,

$$f_n^{(a)}(0) = f_n^{(b)}(0) = \alpha(0) = 1.$$

All three functions are even, so all odd derivatives at 0 vanish.

For the first sequence, the agreement is much stronger. Near 0,

$$\sum_{j=n+1}^{\infty} x^{2j} = O(x^{2n+2}),$$

and therefore

$$f_n^{(a)}(x) - \alpha(x) = O(x^{2n+2}).$$

Thus the derivatives at 0 agree exactly through order  $2n + 1$ .

---

### 9.7.2 6.2. At $x = \pm 1$

Since  $\alpha$  is flat,

$$\alpha^{(k)}(\pm 1) = 0 \quad (k \geq 0).$$

For the first sequence,

$$f_n^{(a)}(\pm 1) = e^{-n}.$$

Every fixed-order derivative at  $\pm 1$  is  $e^{-n}$  times a polynomial in  $n$ , and hence tends to 0.

For the second sequence,

$$1 - \frac{x^2 + x^4 + \cdots + x^{2n}}{n}$$

has a simple zero at each of  $x = \pm 1$ . Hence  $f_n^{(b)}$  has a zero of order  $n$  at each endpoint. In particular,

$$(f_n^{(b)})^{(k)}(\pm 1) = 0 \quad \text{whenever } n > k.$$

---

### 9.7.3 6.3. Sharpness for part b

Fix  $0 < t < 1$ . Since  $P_n(t) \rightarrow P(t)$  exponentially fast and remains bounded,

$$n \log \left( 1 - \frac{P_n(t)}{n} \right) = -P_n(t) - \frac{P_n(t)^2}{2n} + O_t(n^{-2}).$$

It follows that

$$B_n(t) = e^{-P_n(t)} \left( 1 - \frac{P_n(t)^2}{2n} + O_t(n^{-2}) \right).$$

Consequently,

$$\boxed{n(B_n(t) - \beta(t)) \longrightarrow -\frac{1}{2}P(t)^2 e^{-P(t)}}. \quad (6.1)$$

For example, take  $t = 1/2$ , corresponding to  $x = 1/\sqrt{2}$ . Then

$$P(1/2) = 1, \quad \beta(1/2) = e^{-1},$$

and

$$n \left( f_n^{(b)}! \left( \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}} \right) - \alpha \left( \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}} \right) \right) \longrightarrow -\frac{1}{2e}.$$

Therefore

$$|f_n^{(b)} - \alpha|_\infty \neq o(n^{-1}),$$

so the  $O(n^{-1})$  rate is optimal.

---

### 9.7.4 6.4. Role of the domain

The restriction to  $([-1,1])$  is essential. If  $|x| > 1$ , then

$$x^2 + x^4 + \cdots + x^{2n} \asymp_x x^{2n},$$

so

$$\left| 1 - \frac{x^2 + x^4 + \cdots + x^{2n}}{n} \right|^n \longrightarrow +\infty.$$

Thus the second sequence has no analogous convergence on any interval containing a point with  $|x| > 1$ .

The endpoint values  $\alpha(\pm 1) = 0$  are forced by the interior limit and, more strongly, make  $\alpha$  flat and  $C^\infty$  at the endpoints.

---

## 9.8 Conclusion

For both proposed approximation schemes, not only the functions but every fixed derivative converges uniformly on the full closed interval:

$$\boxed{\forall k \in \mathbb{N}, \quad \lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \left\| (f_n^{(a)})^{(k)} - \alpha^{(k)} \right\|_{\infty} = 0,}$$

and

$$\boxed{\forall k \in \mathbb{N}, \quad \lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \left\| (f_n^{(b)})^{(k)} - \alpha^{(k)} \right\|_{\infty} = 0.}$$

Hence the answer to both parts is affirmative.

**Formal verification.** Lean source; online type-check.

## 10 Question Q764

**Informal verdict.** A — **Complete solution**, with high confidence.

**Lean coverage (partial).** Lean proves the line block-cost lemmas and dynamic-program feasibility recurrence, existence of an optimum in finite metrics, the farthest-first factor-two theorem, and the 1–2 metric lemma. Computational-complexity and hardness claims are not formalized.

### 10.1 Audited informal answer

#### 10.1.1 1. Faithful restatement

Let  $1 \leq k \leq n$ .

*a* Given distinct real numbers

$$X = x_1 < x_2 < \cdots < x_n,$$

and  $F \subseteq X$ , define

$$\delta(X, F) = \max_{x \in X} \min_{y \in F} |x - y|.$$

Find an efficient algorithm producing a  $k$ -element subset  $F \subseteq X$  minimizing  $\delta(X, F)$ .

*b* Solve the analogous problem when  $X$  is an arbitrary  $n$ -point subset of a metric space, with  $(|x-y|)$  replaced by the metric distance.

There are three minor ambiguities in the wording.

1. The statement only says  $k \leq n$ , but  $k$  must be a positive integer, since the minimum over an empty  $F$  is otherwise undefined.
2. The minimizing subset need not be unique, so “the subset  $F$ ” should be read as “a minimizing subset  $F$ .”
3. “Efficient” is not formally defined. Below, arithmetic and comparisons of input distances are counted at unit cost. For rational inputs, the algorithms also have polynomial bit complexity.

---

### 10.1.2 2. Final result

#### Theorem

1. **Ordered real line.** An optimal  $k$ -element set can be found exactly in

$$O(n^2 + kn) = O(n^2)$$

time and  $O(n^2 + kn) = O(n^2)$  memory. The algorithm is a bottleneck dynamic program over consecutive blocks.

1. **Arbitrary finite metric.**

- The problem is exactly the finite **discrete metric  $k$ -center problem**.
- Its decision version is NP-complete, even when every nonzero distance is either 1 or 2. Consequently, unless  $P = NP$ , there is no polynomial-time exact algorithm when  $k$  is part of the input.
- An exact exhaustive algorithm takes

$$O\left(\binom{n}{k} nk\right)$$

time.

- There is an  $O(nk)$ -time polynomial algorithm returning a set  $F$  with

$$\delta(X, F) \leq 2, \delta_{\text{opt}}.$$

Unless  $P = NP$ , no polynomial algorithm can guarantee a factor strictly smaller than 2.

---

## 10.2 Part a: points on the real line

### 10.2.1 3. The optimal cost of one consecutive block

For  $1 \leq i \leq j \leq n$ , define

$$c(i, j) = \min_{i \leq \ell \leq j} \max_{i \leq t \leq j} |x_t - x_\ell|.$$

Thus  $c(i, j)$  is the smallest radius with which one center, constrained to be one of

$$x_i, x_{i+1}, \dots, x_j,$$

can cover that whole block.

For a fixed center  $x_\ell$ , the farthest point of the block is one of its two endpoints, so

$$\max_{i \leq t \leq j} |x_t - x_\ell| = \max \{x_\ell - x_i, x_j - x_\ell\}.$$

Writing

$$m_{ij} = \frac{x_i + x_j}{2},$$

we have

$$\max \{x_\ell - x_i, x_j - x_\ell\} = \frac{x_j - x_i}{2} + |x_\ell - m_{ij}|.$$

Consequently:

**Lemma 1** An optimal one-center location for the block  $x_i, \dots, x_j$  is any  $x_\ell$  nearest to the midpoint  $(x_i + x_j)/2$ , and

$$c(i, j) = \frac{x_j - x_i}{2} + \min_{i \leq \ell \leq j} \left| x_\ell - \frac{x_i + x_j}{2} \right|. \quad (1)$$

In particular, the center is constrained to lie in  $X$ ; this is not the continuous  $k$ -center problem.

---

### 10.2.2 4. Reduction to consecutive blocks

The order on the real line provides the crucial structure.

**Lemma 2: consecutive-cell lemma** For every set of centers

$$F = f_1 < \dots < f_s \subseteq X,$$

the points of  $X$  can be assigned to nearest centers so that the points assigned to each  $f_t$  form a consecutive block of  $X$ .

**Proof** Break ties consistently, for example in favor of the smaller center. The points at least as close to  $f_t$  as to  $f_{t+1}$  lie to the left of the midpoint

$$\frac{f_t + f_{t+1}}{2}.$$

Thus the nearest-center index is nondecreasing as one moves from left to right through  $X$ . Its level sets are therefore consecutive intervals of indices.

Every center belongs to its own cell, since its distance to itself is zero, so all cells are nonempty.  $\square$

It follows that an optimal solution is equivalent to partitioning  $X$  into at most  $k$  consecutive nonempty blocks and placing an optimal one-center solution in every block.

More precisely, if

$$0 = i_0 < i_1 < \cdots < i_s = n,$$

the associated blocks are

$$x_{i_{t-1}+1}, \dots, x_{i_t}, \quad 1 \leq t \leq s.$$

**Proposition 3: bottleneck-partition characterization** The optimal value is

$$R_k = \min_{\substack{1 \leq s \leq k \\ 0=i_0 < i_1 < \cdots < i_s=n}} \max_{1 \leq t \leq s} c(i_{t-1} + 1, i_t). \quad (2)$$

**Proof** Given any set of at most  $k$  centers, Lemma 2 produces at most  $k$  consecutive cells. On a cell  $([i, j])$ , its chosen center has radius at least  $c(i, j)$ . Therefore its total radius is at least the right-hand side of 2.

Conversely, given a partition occurring on the right-hand side, choose in every block a center realizing  $c(i, j)$ . Every point is then within the displayed maximum radius of its block center.  $\square$

Using fewer than  $k$  centers causes no difficulty: arbitrary unused points of  $X$  can be added as extra centers, and doing so cannot increase the radius. Thus the minimum over “at most  $k$ ” and the minimum over “exactly  $k$ ” coincide.

---

### 10.2.3 5. Dynamic programming recurrence

Let

$$\rho_p(j)$$

be the optimal radius for the prefix

$$x_1, \dots, x_j$$

using at most  $p$  centers. Set

$$\rho_p(0) = 0, \quad \rho_0(j) = +\infty \quad (j \geq 1).$$

The last block of a partition of  $x_1, \dots, x_j$  must have the form

$$x_i, x_{i+1}, \dots, x_j$$

for some  $1 \leq i \leq j$ . Hence:

**Lemma 4: dynamic-programming recurrence** For  $p, j \geq 1$ ,

$$\boxed{\rho_p(j) = \min_{1 \leq i \leq j} \max\{\rho_{p-1}(i-1), c(i, j)\}.} \quad (3)$$

**Proof** If the last block starts at  $i$ , the preceding prefix uses at most  $p-1$  centers and has optimal cost  $\rho_{p-1}(i-1)$ ; the final block costs  $c(i, j)$ . The total bottleneck cost is their maximum.

Conversely, every partition counted by  $\rho_p(j)$  has a uniquely determined last-block starting index  $i$ , so every possible solution appears in the minimum.  $\square$

A direct evaluation of 3 would take  $O(kn^2)$  time. We now exploit monotonicity to reduce the dynamic-programming part to  $O(kn)$ .

---

#### 10.2.4 6. Monotonicity of the transition

For fixed  $p$  and  $j$ , put

$$A_i = \rho_{p-1}(i-1), \quad B_i = c(i, j).$$

**Lemma 5** As  $i$  increases:

1.  $A_i$  is nondecreasing;
2.  $B_i$  is nonincreasing.

Moreover, for fixed  $i$ ,  $c(i, j)$  is nondecreasing in  $j$ .



**Proof** The value  $A_i$  concerns a prefix ending at  $i - 1$ . Enlarging that prefix cannot decrease the required radius, so  $A_i$  is nondecreasing.

For  $B_i$ , removing the leftmost point of a block cannot increase the optimum. If an optimal center for  $([i, j])$  is not  $x_i$ , retain it. If it is  $x_i$ , replace it by  $x_{i+1}$ ; every remaining point lies to the right, and is no farther from  $x_{i+1}$  than from  $x_i$ . Thus

$$c(i + 1, j) \leq c(i, j).$$

Similarly, adding a point on the right cannot reduce the one-center cost. If an optimal center for  $([i, j+1])$  is one of  $x_i, \dots, x_j$ , restricting to the smaller block proves the assertion. If it is  $x_{j+1}$ , then  $x_j$  is at least as good for all points  $x_i, \dots, x_j$ . Hence

$$c(i, j) \leq c(i, j + 1).$$

□

Let

$$t = t_p(j) = \min i \in 1, \dots, j : A_i \geq B_i,$$

with the convention  $t = j + 1$  if this set is empty.

For  $i < t$ ,

$$\max(A_i, B_i) = B_i,$$

which is nonincreasing in  $i$ . For  $i \geq t$ ,

$$\max(A_i, B_i) = A_i,$$

which is nondecreasing in  $i$ . Therefore:

**Lemma 6: crossing lemma** A minimizing index in 3 is always one of

$$t_p(j) - 1, \quad t_p(j),$$

after discarding indices outside  $1, \dots, j$ .

Furthermore, for fixed  $p$ ,

$$t_p(1) \leq t_p(2) \leq \dots \leq t_p(n). \tag{4}$$

**Proof** The first assertion follows from the decreasing-then-increasing behavior just described.

For the second, if  $i < t_p(j)$ , then

$$A_i < c(i, j) \leq c(i, j + 1),$$

so  $i < t_p(j + 1)$ . Hence the first crossing cannot move to the left.  $\square$

Thus, while  $j$  runs from 1 to  $n$ , a single pointer tracking  $t_p(j)$  moves right at most  $n$  times.

---

### 10.2.5 7. Precomputing all block costs in $O(n^2)$

By 1, the optimal center for  $([i, j])$  is a point nearest to

$$m_{ij} = \frac{x_i + x_j}{2}.$$

For a fixed  $i$ , these midpoints are nondecreasing as  $j$  increases. If ties are resolved in favor of the rightmost nearest point, the corresponding optimal-center index is also nondecreasing.

Indeed, between consecutive points  $x_\ell, x_{\ell+1}$ , the point  $x_{\ell+1}$  is at least as close as  $x_\ell$  to a number  $m$  exactly when

$$m \geq \frac{x_\ell + x_{\ell+1}}{2}.$$

Once this becomes true, it remains true as  $m$  moves to the right.

Therefore a moving pointer computes all  $c(i, j)$ , for fixed  $i$ , in  $O(n)$  time. Repeating for all  $i$  gives  $O(n^2)$ .

---

### 10.2.6 8. Exact quadratic-time algorithm

The following pseudocode uses one-based indices.  $C[i, j]$  stores  $c(i, j)$ , and  $M[i, j]$  stores a corresponding optimal center index.

QUADRATIC-LINE-K-CENTER( $x[1..n]$ ,  $k$ )

# Phase 1: all one-block costs and centers

for  $i = 1, \dots, n$ :

$ell = i$

    for  $j = i, \dots, n$ :

        # Move  $ell$  to the rightmost point nearest to  $(x[i] + x[j])/2$ .

```

# The doubled comparison avoids division by 2.
while ell < j and
    abs(2*x[ell+1] - x[i] - x[j])
    <= abs(2*x[ell] - x[i] - x[j]):
    ell = ell + 1

M[i,j] = ell
C[i,j] = max(x[ell] - x[i], x[j] - x[ell])

# Phase 2: bottleneck dynamic programming
prev[0] = 0
for j = 1,...,n:
    prev[j] = +infinity

for p = 1,...,k:
    cur[0] = 0
    t = 1

    for j = 1,...,n:
        # After this loop, t is the first crossing index;
        # if no crossing exists, t = j+1.
        while t <= j and prev[t-1] < C[t,j]:
            t = t + 1

        candidates = empty set
        if t <= j:
            insert t into candidates
        if t >= 2:
            insert t-1 into candidates

        choose i in candidates minimizing
            max(prev[i-1], C[i,j])

        cur[j] = max(prev[i-1], C[i,j])
        parent[p,j] = i

    prev = cur

```

```

# Phase 3: reconstruct the consecutive blocks
F = empty set
p = k
j = n

while j > 0:
    i = parent[p,j]
    insert x[M[i,j]] into F
    j = i - 1
    p = p - 1

# The dynamic program may have used fewer than k nonempty blocks.
while |F| < k:
    insert any point of X \ F into F

return F and prev[n]

```

**Theorem 7: correctness and complexity** The algorithm returns a  $k$ -element set  $F \subseteq X$  satisfying

$$\delta(X, F) = R_k.$$

Its running time is

$$O(n^2 + kn),$$

and its memory requirement is

$$O(n^2 + kn).$$

**Proof** The first phase correctly computes every  $c(i, j)$  and a realizing center by Lemma 1 and the monotone-midpoint argument.

For each fixed  $p$ , the pointer  $\mathbf{t}$  is exactly the crossing index from Lemma 6. Since it is nondecreasing in  $j$ , it makes at most  $n$  increments. Lemma 6 shows that checking  $\mathbf{t}-1$  and  $\mathbf{t}$  evaluates recurrence 3 exactly. Thus the dynamic program computes every  $\rho_p(j)$ , in particular

$$\text{prev}[n] = \rho_k(n) = R_k.$$

Following the parent pointers reconstructs a partition realizing this value. The center  $\mathbf{M}[\mathbf{i}, \mathbf{j}]$  realizes the one-block cost for each reconstructed block. Hence the resulting set of centers covers  $X$  with radius  $R_k$ .

If fewer than  $k$  centers occur, adding arbitrary unused points cannot increase the radius. It cannot decrease it below  $R_k$ , since  $R_k$  was already the minimum over all sets of at most  $k$  centers. Thus the final  $k$ -element set remains optimal.

The cost table takes  $O(n^2)$  time and space. For every  $p$ , the dynamic-programming scan takes  $O(n)$ , giving  $O(kn)$ . The parent table uses  $O(kn)$  space.  $\square$

---

### 10.2.7 9. A simpler independent decision algorithm

For a proposed radius  $r$ , one can decide in linear time whether  $k$  centers suffice.

Take the leftmost uncovered point  $x_i$ . Choose as center the rightmost  $x_j$  satisfying

$$x_j \leq x_i + r.$$

This center covers all points through  $x_j + r$ . Repeat with the next uncovered point.

This greedy rule uses the minimum possible number of radius- $r$  centers. Indeed, every feasible cover must have some center  $x_\ell \leq x_i + r$  covering  $x_i$ . The greedy center satisfies  $x_j \geq x_\ell$ , so

$$x_\ell + r \leq x_j + r;$$

the competing center cannot cover any point farther to the right than the greedy center. Induction on the uncovered suffix proves optimality.

Since an optimal radius is necessarily one of the pairwise distances

$$x_j - x_i,$$

sorting all  $O(n^2)$  candidate distances and binary-searching with this decision procedure gives a simpler  $O(n^2 \log n)$ -time exact algorithm. The preceding dynamic program removes the logarithmic factor.

---

## 10.3 Part b: an arbitrary finite metric space

Let  $((X, d))$  be a finite metric space with  $|X| = n$ , and write

$$d(x, F) = \min_{f \in F} d(x, f).$$

### 10.3.1 10. Threshold-graph characterization

For  $r \geq 0$ , define a graph  $G_r$  on vertex set  $X$  by declaring distinct  $(u,v)$  adjacent when

$$d(u, v) \leq r.$$

A subset  $F \subseteq X$  satisfies

$$\delta(X, F) \leq r$$

if and only if every vertex is either in  $F$  or adjacent in  $G_r$  to a vertex of  $F$ . In other words,  $F$  is a dominating set of  $G_r$ .

Let  $\gamma(G)$  denote the minimum size of a dominating set of  $G$ , and let

$$D = \{d(x, y) : x, y \in X\}.$$

Because  $X$  is finite,  $\delta(X, F)$  is always an element of  $D$ . Therefore:

**Proposition 8** The exact optimal radius is

$$\boxed{R_k^{\text{met}} = \min r \in D : \gamma(G_r) \leq k.} \quad (5)$$

Moreover, the optimal  $k$ -element sets are precisely the  $k$ -element dominating sets of  $G_{R_k^{\text{met}}}$ .

This is a complete mathematical characterization, but finding a minimum dominating set is computationally difficult.

---

### 10.3.2 11. An exact finite algorithm

Assuming the distance matrix is available, one may simply enumerate all  $k$ -element subsets:

```

EXACT-METRIC-K-CENTER(X, d, k)

best_radius = +infinity
best_set = none

for every k-element subset F of X:
    r = 0
    for every x in X:
        r = max(r, min_{f in F} d(x, f))

    if r < best_radius:

```

```

    best_radius = r
    best_set = F

return best_set and best_radius

```

There are  $\binom{n}{k}$  subsets, and evaluating one requires  $O(nk)$  distance comparisons. Thus the running time is

$$O\left(\binom{n}{k}nk\right). \quad (6)$$

For every fixed  $k$ , this is polynomial in  $n$ , but it is exponential when  $k$  is part of the input.

---

### 10.3.3 12. NP-completeness of the general metric problem

Consider the decision problem:

Given a finite metric  $((X,d))$ , an integer  $k$ , and a radius  $r$ , does there exist  $F \subseteq X$ ,  $|F| \leq k$ , such that  $\delta(X, F) \leq r$ ?

It belongs to NP: a proposed  $F$  can be checked in  $O(nk)$  time.

We prove NP-hardness using the standard NP-completeness of **VERTEX COVER**, one of Karp's classical NP-complete problems. ([Informatique Cornell Bowers][1])

**Reduction** Let  $G = (V, E)$  be a nontrivial instance of VERTEX COVER, with integer  $k$ . Construct a graph  $H$  whose vertex set is the disjoint union

$$W = V \sqcup E,$$

where each edge  $e \in E$  is regarded as a new “edge-vertex.”

The adjacencies of  $H$  are:

1. all vertices of  $V$  are pairwise adjacent, so  $V$  induces a clique;
2. an edge-vertex  $e = u, v$  is adjacent exactly to  $u$  and  $v$ ;
3. distinct edge-vertices are not adjacent.

Now define a distance on  $W$  by

$$d_H(a, b) = \begin{cases} 0, & a = b, \\ 1, & a \neq b \text{ and } a, b \text{ are adjacent in } H, \\ 2, & \text{otherwise.} \end{cases} \quad (7)$$

**Lemma 9** The function  $d_H$  is a metric.

**Proof** Symmetry and positive definiteness are immediate. For the triangle inequality, all nonzero distances are at least 1, while every distance is at most 2. Thus, for three pairwise distinct points,

$$d_H(a, c) \leq 2 \leq d_H(a, b) + d_H(b, c).$$

Cases with repeated points are immediate.  $\square$

A set has covering radius at most 1 in this metric exactly when it is a dominating set of  $H$ .

**Lemma 10** The original graph  $G$  has a vertex cover of size at most  $k$  if and only if  $H$  has a dominating set of size at most  $k$ .

**Proof** Suppose  $C \subseteq V$  is a vertex cover. Every edge-vertex  $e = u, v$  is adjacent to at least one point of  $C$ . Since  $V$  is a clique, every vertex of  $V$  is in  $C$  or adjacent to every member of  $C$ . Thus  $C$  dominates  $H$ .

Conversely, let  $D$  dominate  $H$ . Whenever an edge-vertex

$$e = u, v$$

belongs to  $D$ , replace it by either endpoint, say  $u$ . Repeating this operation produces a set

$$C \subseteq V, \quad |C| \leq |D|.$$

Every edge-vertex  $e$  is incident to a vertex of  $C$ :

- if  $e \in D$ , an endpoint was inserted when  $e$  was replaced;
- if  $e \notin D$ , then  $e$  had to be dominated by one of its endpoints in  $D$ , since edge-vertices are not adjacent to one another.

Therefore  $C$  contains an endpoint of every edge of  $G$ , so  $C$  is a vertex cover.  $\square$

The construction is polynomial. Thus the metric  $k$ -center decision problem is NP-hard even for the fixed threshold  $r = 1$  and metrics whose nonzero distances belong to  $(\{1, 2\})$ . Together with membership in NP:



**Theorem 11** The decision version of the arbitrary-metric problem is NP-complete, even for 1-2 metrics.

Consequently, the exact optimization problem in Q764b is NP-hard. Unless  $P = NP$ , there is no polynomial-time exact algorithm for arbitrary finite metrics when  $k$  is part of the input.

The distinction between “at most  $k$ ” and “exactly  $k$ ” is immaterial: a dominating set of size smaller than  $k$  can be augmented by arbitrary vertices.

---

### 10.3.4 13. A polynomial-time factor-2 algorithm

Although exact optimization is NP-hard, there is a very simple optimal-threshold approximation.

**Farthest-first algorithm** Choose an arbitrary first center  $c_1$ . Having selected

$$C_t = c_1, \dots, c_t,$$

choose

$$c_{t+1} \in \arg \max_{x \in X} d(x, C_t).$$

FARTHEST-FIRST( $X$ ,  $d$ ,  $k$ )

choose any  $c[1]$  in  $X$

$F = \{c[1]\}$

for every  $x$  in  $X$ :

$\text{nearest}[x] = d(x, c[1])$

for  $t = 2, \dots, k$ :

    choose  $c[t]$  maximizing  $\text{nearest}[x]$

    insert  $c[t]$  into  $F$

    for every  $x$  in  $X$ :

$\text{nearest}[x] = \min(\text{nearest}[x], d(x, c[t]))$

return  $F$

It performs  $O(n)$  work for each new center, hence  $O(nk)$  distance operations.

**Theorem 12** If  $F$  is returned by farthest-first and  $R^*$  is the exact optimal radius, then

$$\delta(X, F) \leq 2R^*.$$

**Proof** Let

$$r = \delta(X, F),$$

and choose  $c_{k+1} \in X$  satisfying

$$d(c_{k+1}, F) = r.$$

We claim that the  $k + 1$  points

$$c_1, c_2, \dots, c_k, c_{k+1}$$

are pairwise at distance at least  $r$ .

Indeed, when  $c_t$  was selected, its distance from the previously selected centers was the then-current maximum covering distance. These maximum distances form a nonincreasing sequence, whose final value is  $r$ . Hence for  $s < t \leq k$ ,

$$d(c_s, c_t) \geq r.$$

The same assertion holds for  $c_{k+1}$  by its definition.

Now let  $F^*$  be an optimal set of  $k$  centers with radius  $R^*$ . Assign each of the  $k + 1$  displayed points to an optimal center at distance at most  $R^*$ . By the pigeonhole principle, two of them, say  $c_s, c_t$ , are assigned to the same optimal center  $f$ . The triangle inequality gives

$$d(c_s, c_t) \leq d(c_s, f) + d(f, c_t) \leq 2R^*.$$

Since  $d(c_s, c_t) \geq r$ , it follows that

$$r \leq 2R^*.$$

□

### 10.3.5 14. The factor 2 cannot be improved in polynomial time

The same reduction used for NP-hardness gives a gap instance.

For the 1-2 metric constructed from a VERTEX COVER instance:

- if a vertex cover of size at most  $k$  exists, then the optimal metric  $k$ -center radius is 1;

- otherwise, no radius-1 solution exists, while every nonempty set of centers covers all points with radius at most 2, so the optimum is 2.

Suppose a polynomial algorithm had approximation factor

$$2 - \varepsilon$$

for some fixed  $\varepsilon > 0$ . On an instance of optimum 1, it would return a solution of radius strictly smaller than 2. Since all possible radii are  $(0,1,2)$ , its radius would be at most 1. On an instance of optimum 2, every feasible solution has radius 2. The algorithm would therefore decide VERTEX COVER in polynomial time.

Thus:

**Theorem 13** Unless  $P = NP$ , no polynomial-time algorithm for arbitrary finite metrics can guarantee an approximation factor strictly smaller than 2.

Hence the farthest-first approximation guarantee is best possible in the standard worst-case complexity sense.

---

## 10.4 15. Boundary and sanity checks

$k = n$  Taking  $F = X$  gives

$$\delta(X, X) = 0.$$

The dynamic program returns the partition into singleton blocks.

$k = 1$  **on the line** Only the two extreme points matter. An optimal center is a point of  $X$  nearest to

$$\frac{x_1 + x_n}{2},$$

and the optimum is

$$\min_{1 \leq \ell \leq n} \max x_\ell - x_1, x_n - x_\ell.$$

**Nonuniqueness** For

$$X = 0, 2, \quad k = 1,$$

both  $(\{0\})$  and  $(\{2\})$  are optimal, with radius 2.

**A two-cluster example** For

$$X = 0, 1, 10, 11, \quad k = 2,$$

the optimal consecutive partition is

$$0, 1 \mid 10, 11.$$

Each block has discrete one-center radius 1, so an optimal answer is

$$F = 1, 11, \quad \delta(X, F) = 1.$$

**Why the order is decisive** On the line, nearest-center cells are consecutive intervals, producing the dynamic program. In an arbitrary metric, the radius- $r$  neighborhoods can encode essentially arbitrary graph domination instances, which is exactly what causes NP-completeness.

---

## 10.5 Final answer

For **Q764a**, the problem admits an exact quadratic-time solution. Compute the optimal one-center radius  $c(i, j)$  for every consecutive block, then use the bottleneck recurrence

$$\rho_p(j) = \min_{1 \leq i \leq j} \max \rho_{p-1}(i-1), c(i, j).$$

Monotonicity reduces each dynamic-programming layer to linear time, giving total complexity

$$O(n^2 + kn) = O(n^2).$$

For **Q764b**, the exact problem is NP-complete even for metrics with distances only 1 and 2. An exact solution can be obtained by enumerating all  $k$ -subsets in

$$O\left(\binom{n}{k} nk\right)$$

time. In polynomial time, farthest-first selection gives the sharp guarantee

$$\delta(X, F) \leq 2, \delta_{\text{opt}},$$

and no factor below 2 is possible unless  $P = NP$ .

[1]: <https://www.cs.cornell.edu/courses/cs722/2000sp/karp.pdf> "cs722"

**Formal verification.** Lean source; online type-check.

## 11 Question Q766

**Informal verdict.** A — **Complete solution**, with high confidence.

**Lean coverage (partial).** Lean proves the exact quantile partition minimum and block-median classification, permutation invariance, continuous positive-block median uniqueness, and a conditional distributional interface. The direct arbitrary-f bridge, strictness, asymptotics, and nonuniqueness remain under Aristotle continuation.

### 11.1 Audited informal answer

Q766 — Complete solution

1. Faithful restatement

Let  $f : (0, 1) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$  be continuous and integrable, and let  $n \geq 1$ . For  $X = (x_1, \dots, x_n) \in \mathbb{R}^n$ , define

$$\delta(X, y) = \min_{1 \leq k \leq n} |y - x_k|, \quad \phi(X) = \int_0^1 \delta(X, f(t)) dt.$$

The problem asks for the minimum of  $\phi$  and for the complete set of  $n$ -tuples at which it is attained. The statement explicitly permits adding assumptions on  $f$  when useful and notes that the case  $n = 1$  was treated in an earlier examination problem. There are no subparts, footnotes, or apparent typographical errors. Luc Pommeret I interpret “integrable” in the standard French sense

$$\int_0^1 |f(t)| dt < \infty.$$

This is the natural necessary condition: if only a conditionally convergent improper integral were meant and  $\int_0^1 |f| = \infty$ , then  $\phi(X) = +\infty$  for every finite tuple  $X$ .

1. Distribution and increasing rearrangement

Let  $\lambda$  denote Lebesgue measure on  $(0, 1)$ , and let

$$\mu = f_{\#}\lambda$$

be the image probability measure of  $f$ ; explicitly,

$$\mu(B) = \lambda(\{t \in (0, 1) : f(t) \in B\}).$$

Then

$$\phi(x_1, \dots, x_n) = \int_{\mathbb{R}} \min_{1 \leq k \leq n} |y - x_k| d\mu(y).$$

Thus the problem depends only on the distribution of  $f$ , not on the order in which its values occur. Let

$$F(y) = \mu((-\infty, y])$$

and define the generalized quantile, or nondecreasing rearrangement, by

$$q(u) = \inf\{y \in \mathbb{R} : F(y) \geq u\}, \quad 0 < u < 1.$$

Then  $q$  is nondecreasing,  $q \in L^1(0, 1)$ , and  $q_{\#}\lambda = \mu$ . Hence

$$\phi(X) = \int_0^1 \min_{1 \leq k \leq n} |q(u) - x_k| du.$$

Set

$$H(s) = \int_0^s q(u) du, \quad 0 \leq s \leq 1.$$

The function  $H$  is continuous on  $[0, 1]$  and convex. For  $0 \leq a \leq b \leq 1$ , define

$$K(a, b) = H(a) + H(b) - 2H\left(\frac{a+b}{2}\right).$$

1. Main theorem: exact minimum and complete classification

Let

$$\Delta_n = \{(s_0, \dots, s_n) : 0 = s_0 \leq s_1 \leq \dots \leq s_n = 1\}$$

and, for  $s \in \Delta_n$ , put

$$J_n(s) = \sum_{i=1}^n K(s_{i-1}, s_i).$$

Theorem 1 For every integrable measurable  $f : (0, 1) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ ,

$$\boxed{\min_{X \in \mathbb{R}^n} \phi(X) = \min_{s \in \Delta_n} \sum_{i=1}^n \left[ H(s_{i-1}) + H(s_i) - 2H\left(\frac{s_{i-1} + s_i}{2}\right) \right]}. \quad (3.1)}$$

Both minima are attained. More precisely, let

$$\mathcal{S}_n = \operatorname{argmin}_{s \in \Delta_n} J_n(s).$$

For  $s \in \mathcal{S}_n$  and every positive-length block  $s_{i-1} < s_i$ , set

$$\theta_i = \frac{s_{i-1} + s_i}{2}$$

and define

$$M_i(s) = [q(\theta_i-), q(\theta_i+)],$$

where  $q(\theta_i-)$  and  $q(\theta_i+)$  are the one-sided limits of the monotone function  $q$ . Choose any

$$c_i \in M_i(s)$$

on every positive block; on a zero-length block one may choose  $c_i$  arbitrarily. Then

$$(c_1, \dots, c_n)$$

is a minimizer of  $\phi$ . Conversely, every minimizing tuple, after reordering its coordinates increasingly, arises in this way from an element of  $\mathcal{S}_n$ . Thus (3.1), together with the median intervals  $M_i(s)$ , is a complete description of both the minimum and its entire attainment set.

## 1. Proof of Theorem 1

**4.1 The one-centre problem** We first recall and prove the elementary median principle. Let  $\nu$  be a finite positive measure of total mass  $p$ , with finite first moment, and let

$$G(c) = \int_{\mathbb{R}} |y - c| d\nu(y).$$

The function  $G$  is convex. Its one-sided derivatives are

$$G'_-(c) = \nu((-\infty, c)) - \nu([c, \infty)),$$

and

$$G'_+(c) = \nu((-\infty, c]) - \nu((c, \infty)).$$

Indeed, these formulas follow by applying dominated convergence to the one-sided difference quotients of  $|y - c|$ . A point  $c$  minimizes  $G$  if and only if

$$G'_-(c) \leq 0 \leq G'_+(c),$$

equivalently,

$$\nu((-\infty, c)) \leq \frac{p}{2}, \quad \nu((c, \infty)) \leq \frac{p}{2}. \quad (4.1)$$

These are exactly the median inequalities. Now restrict  $q$  to a quantile interval  $(a, b)$ , where  $a < b$ , and let

$$m = \frac{a + b}{2}.$$

Since  $q$  is nondecreasing, the complete median interval of  $q$  on  $(a, b)$  is

$$[q(m-), q(m+)].$$

For any  $c$  in this interval,

$$q(u) \leq c \quad \text{for a.e. } u \in (a, m),$$

and

$$q(u) \geq c \quad \text{for a.e. } u \in (m, b).$$

Because both halves have the same length,

$$\begin{aligned} \min_{c \in \mathbb{R}} \int_a^b |q(u) - c| du &= \int_a^m (c - q(u)) du + \int_m^b (q(u) - c) du \\ &= \int_m^b q(u) du - \int_a^m q(u) du \\ &= H(a) + H(b) - 2H(m) \\ &= K(a, b). \end{aligned} \quad (4.2)$$

For  $a = b$ , both sides are 0.



4.2 From centres to an ordered quantile partition Fix  $X = (x_1, \dots, x_n)$ . Since  $\phi$  is invariant under permutations, assume

$$x_1 \leq x_2 \leq \dots \leq x_n.$$

For each  $y \in \mathbb{R}$ , choose the smallest index realizing the nearest-centre distance:

$$r(y) = \min \left\{ i : |y - x_i| = \min_j |y - x_j| \right\}.$$

The map  $r$  is nondecreasing. Indeed, suppose  $y < z$ , but  $r(y) = j > i = r(z)$ . Then  $x_i \leq x_j$ . The inequality saying that  $x_j$  is at least as close to  $y$  as  $x_i$  gives

$$y \geq \frac{x_i + x_j}{2},$$

while the inequality saying that  $x_i$  is at least as close to  $z$  as  $x_j$  gives

$$z \leq \frac{x_i + x_j}{2},$$

contradicting  $y < z$ . Since both  $q$  and  $r$  are nondecreasing,  $r \circ q$  is a nondecreasing integer-valued function on  $(0, 1)$ . Consequently its level sets form, up to endpoints, consecutive intervals

$$(s_{i-1}, s_i), \quad 0 = s_0 \leq s_1 \leq \dots \leq s_n = 1.$$

Using (4.2),

$$\begin{aligned} J_n(s) &= \sum_{i=1}^n \min_{c \in \mathbb{R}} \int_{s_{i-1}}^{s_i} |q(u) - c| du \\ &\leq \sum_{i=1}^n \int_{s_{i-1}}^{s_i} |q(u) - x_i| du \\ &= \int_0^1 \min_j |q(u) - x_j| du \\ &= \phi(X). \end{aligned}$$

Therefore

$$\min_{s \in \Delta_n} J_n(s) \leq \inf_{X \in \mathbb{R}^n} \phi(X). \quad (4.3)$$

4.3 From a quantile partition to centres Conversely, take any  $s \in \Delta_n$ . For every positive block choose a median  $c_i \in M_i(s)$ ; on empty blocks choose anything. Then, pointwise,

$$\min_j |q(u) - c_j| \leq |q(u) - c_i|, \quad s_{i-1} < u < s_i.$$

Hence

$$\begin{aligned} \phi(c_1, \dots, c_n) &= \int_0^1 \min_j |q(u) - c_j| du \\ &\leq \sum_{i=1}^n \int_{s_{i-1}}^{s_i} |q(u) - c_i| du \\ &= J_n(s). \end{aligned}$$

Taking the infimum over  $X$  and then the minimum over  $s$ ,

$$\inf_X \phi(X) \leq \min_{s \in \Delta_n} J_n(s). \quad (4.4)$$

Combining (4.3) and (4.4) proves equality. Since  $H$  is continuous,  $J_n$  is continuous on the compact simplex  $\Delta_n$ . Thus the right-hand minimum is attained. Choosing medians on an optimal partition gives a tuple attaining the same value, so the left-hand minimum is also attained.

4.4 Equality cases Suppose first that  $s \in \mathcal{S}_n$  and the  $c_i$  are block medians. We obtained

$$\phi(c_1, \dots, c_n) \leq J_n(s) = \min_X \phi(X).$$

The reverse inequality follows from the definition of the minimum, so equality holds: every such tuple is minimizing. Conversely, let  $X$  be minimizing and form its nearest-centre quantile partition  $s$  as in §4.2. Then

$$\min_s J_n(s) \leq J_n(s) \leq \phi(X) = \min_X \phi(X) = \min_s J_n(s).$$

All inequalities are equalities. In particular  $s \in \mathcal{S}_n$ , and on each nonempty cell

$$\int_{s_{i-1}}^{s_i} |q(u) - x_i| du = \min_c \int_{s_{i-1}}^{s_i} |q(u) - c| du.$$

Therefore  $x_i$  is a median on that block, i.e.

$$x_i \in M_i(s).$$

This proves the full classification.

# 1. Specialization to the continuous function in Q766

Continuity has a useful additional consequence. Lemma 2: the distribution of a nonconstant continuous  $f$  has no gaps Let

$$I = f((0, 1)).$$

Since  $(0, 1)$  is connected and  $f$  is continuous,  $I$  is an interval. Moreover,

$$\text{supp } \mu = \bar{I}.$$

Indeed, if  $y = f(t_0)$  and  $U$  is a neighbourhood of  $y$ , continuity gives an interval  $V \ni t_0$  such that  $f(V) \subset U$ . Thus

$$\mu(U) \geq \lambda(V) > 0.$$

The same argument applies to points in  $\bar{I}$  by first choosing a value of  $f$  inside the prescribed neighbourhood. Consequently, if  $f$  is nonconstant,  $\text{supp } \mu$  is a nondegenerate interval, possibly unbounded. There are no open gaps of zero  $\mu$ -measure inside the support. A jump of the quantile  $q$  would correspond to such a gap. Hence:

$$\boxed{f \text{ nonconstant and continuous} \implies q \text{ is continuous on } (0, 1).} \quad (5.1)$$

The distribution may have atoms— $f$  can be constant on an interval—but atoms produce flat portions of  $q$ , not jumps. Therefore every positive quantile block has a unique median:

$$M_i(s) = \{q(\theta_i)\}.$$

Theorem 3: complete answer for the original continuous  $f$  Constant case  
If  $f(t) = c$  for all  $t$ , then

$$\phi(X) = \min_k |c - x_k|.$$

Thus

$$\boxed{\min \phi = 0,}$$

and

$$\boxed{\text{Argmin } \phi = \{X \in \mathbb{R}^n : \text{some coordinate of } X \text{ equals } c\}.}$$

The other coordinates are arbitrary. Nonconstant case Assume  $f$  is nonconstant. Let  $q$ ,  $H$ ,  $J_n$ , and  $\mathcal{S}_n$  be as above. Then

$$\boxed{\min_{X \in \mathbb{R}^n} \phi(X) = \min_{0=s_0 \leq \dots \leq s_n=1} \sum_{i=1}^n \left[ H(s_{i-1}) + H(s_i) - 2H\left(\frac{s_{i-1} + s_i}{2}\right) \right].} \quad (5.2)$$

Every optimal partition is in fact strict:

$$0 = s_0 < s_1 < \dots < s_{n-1} < s_n = 1. \quad (5.3)$$

The complete attainment set is

$$\boxed{\text{Argmin } \phi = \bigcup_{s \in \mathcal{S}_n} \left\{ \left( q\left(\frac{s_{\sigma(1)}-1+s_{\sigma(1)}}{2}\right), \dots, q\left(\frac{s_{\sigma(n)}-1+s_{\sigma(n)}}{2}\right) \right) : \sigma \in \mathfrak{S}_n \right\}.} \quad (5.4)$$

Equivalently, for an increasing ordering of the coordinates,

$$\boxed{x_i = q\left(\frac{s_{i-1} + s_i}{2}\right), \quad 1 \leq i \leq n,} \quad (5.5)$$

for some  $s \in \mathcal{S}_n$ . All optimal coordinates are distinct, and the minimizer set is compact.

Proof of strictness and distinctness Write

$$e_n = \min_{X \in \mathbb{R}^n} \phi(X).$$

For nonconstant continuous  $f$ ,

$$e_n < e_{n-1} \quad (n \geq 2). \quad (5.6)$$

To prove this, take an optimal  $(n-1)$ -tuple  $A$ . Its set of centres is finite, whereas  $\text{supp } \mu$  is a nondegenerate interval. Choose

$$y_0 \in \text{supp } \mu \setminus A$$

and let

$$d = \text{dist}(y_0, A) > 0.$$

Choose  $0 < r < d/3$ . Since  $y_0$  lies in the support,

$$\mu((y_0 - r, y_0 + r)) > 0.$$

After adding  $y_0$  as a new centre, the distance decreases on this interval by at least

$$(d - r) - r = d - 2r > 0$$

and does not increase elsewhere. This proves (5.6). If an optimal quantile partition for  $e_n$  had a zero-length block, deleting it would give an  $(n - 1)$ -block partition of the same cost, contradicting (5.6). This proves (5.3). If two optimal centres coincided, the tuple would effectively use at most  $n - 1$  distinct centres, again contradicting (5.6). Thus all centres are distinct. Finally,  $\mathcal{S}_n$  is a compact subset of  $\Delta_n$ . Since it does not meet the boundary where a block has zero length, all its block lengths are uniformly bounded below. Hence all the midpoint parameters stay in a compact subinterval of  $(0, 1)$ , on which  $q$  is bounded and continuous. Formula (5.4) then shows that the minimizer set is compact.

#### 1. Necessary equations for an optimum

Let  $f$  be nonconstant and continuous, and let

$$s \in \mathcal{S}_n, \quad \theta_i = \frac{s_{i-1} + s_i}{2}, \quad x_i = q(\theta_i).$$

Since  $q$  is continuous on  $(0, 1)$ ,

$$H'(u) = q(u), \quad 0 < u < 1.$$

Every internal breakpoint  $s_i$  is an unconstrained interior variable. Differentiating  $J_n$  with respect to  $s_i$  gives

$$\begin{aligned} 0 &= \frac{\partial J_n}{\partial s_i} \\ &= \left[ q(s_i) - q\left(\frac{s_{i-1} + s_i}{2}\right) \right] + \left[ q(s_i) - q\left(\frac{s_i + s_{i+1}}{2}\right) \right]. \end{aligned}$$

Thus every optimum satisfies

$$\boxed{2q(s_i) = x_i + x_{i+1}, \quad 1 \leq i < n.} \quad (6.1)$$

In value space,  $q(s_i)$  is therefore exactly the midpoint between the adjacent optimal centres. This is the Voronoi boundary condition. Together, (5.5) and (6.1) say:

- each centre is the median of the distribution in its Voronoi cell;
- each boundary is the arithmetic midpoint of the adjacent centres.

These are the one-dimensional  $L^1$  centroidal Voronoi equations. They are necessary, but in general not sufficient for global optimality: the finite-dimensional function  $J_n$  need not be convex.

Atomless form Suppose additionally that  $\mu$  is atomless. Then  $F$  is continuous and strictly increasing on its support, and  $q = F^{-1}$ . Let

$$b_0 = -\infty, \quad b_i = \frac{x_i + x_{i+1}}{2} \quad (1 \leq i < n), \quad b_n = +\infty.$$

Equation (6.1) gives

$$s_i = F(b_i).$$

Since  $x_i = q((s_{i-1} + s_i)/2)$ ,

$$F(x_i) = \frac{s_{i-1} + s_i}{2}.$$

Therefore every ordered optimal tuple satisfies

$$\boxed{2F(x_i) = F(b_{i-1}) + F(b_i), \quad 1 \leq i \leq n,} \quad (6.2)$$

with  $F(-\infty) = 0$  and  $F(+\infty) = 1$ . Equivalently,

$$\mu((b_{i-1}, x_i)) = \mu((x_i, b_i)).$$

Thus  $x_i$  bisects the probability mass of its Voronoi cell.

#### 1. Exact dynamic-programming algorithm

Formula (5.2) admits an exact Bellman recursion. For  $t \in [0, 1]$ , define

$$V_0(0) = 0, \quad V_0(t) = +\infty \quad (t > 0),$$

and for  $k \geq 1$ ,

$$\boxed{V_k(t) = \min_{0 \leq r \leq t} (V_{k-1}(r) + K(r, t)).} \quad (7.1)$$

Then

$$\boxed{e_n = V_n(1)}. \quad (7.2)$$

All optimal partitions can be recovered by backtracking all minimizers  $r$  in (7.1). Once the breakpoints are known, the centres are given by the block medians, and for the nonconstant continuous case by

$$x_i = q\left(\frac{s_{i-1} + s_i}{2}\right).$$

A grid discretization of (7.1) with  $M$  quantile grid points has the standard  $O(nM^2)$  complexity, before any convexity or Monge-type acceleration.

### 1. Boundary and test cases

8.1 The case  $n = 1$  There is no partition variable:

$$s_0 = 0, \quad s_1 = 1.$$

Thus

$$e_1 = H(1) - 2H\left(\frac{1}{2}\right) = \int_{1/2}^1 q(u) du - \int_0^{1/2} q(u) du.$$

The complete median interval is

$$[q(1/2-), q(1/2+)].$$

For the nonconstant continuous  $f$ ,  $q$  is continuous, so the unique minimizer is

$$\boxed{x_1 = q(1/2)},$$

the unique median of the distribution of  $f$ .

8.2 Affine functions Let

$$f(t) = \alpha t + \beta, \quad \alpha \neq 0.$$

The distribution is uniform on an interval of length  $|\alpha|$ . Writing its lower endpoint as

$$A = \min(\beta, \beta + \alpha),$$

the quantile is

$$q(u) = A + |\alpha|u.$$

A direct calculation gives

$$K(a, b) = \frac{|\alpha|}{4}(b - a)^2.$$

Consequently,

$$e_n = \frac{|\alpha|}{4} \min_{\substack{h_i \geq 0 \\ \sum h_i = 1}} \sum_{i=1}^n h_i^2 = \frac{|\alpha|}{4n}.$$

Equality in Cauchy–Schwarz forces

$$h_i = \frac{1}{n}.$$

Thus the unique increasing optimal tuple is

$$\boxed{x_i = A + \frac{2i-1}{2n}|\alpha|, \quad 1 \leq i \leq n,}$$

and the full attainment set consists of its permutations.

8.3 Decay as  $n \rightarrow \infty$  For every integrable  $f$ ,

$$e_n \longrightarrow 0.$$

Indeed, given  $\varepsilon > 0$ , choose  $R > 0$  such that

$$\int_{|y|>R} |y| d\mu(y) < \varepsilon.$$

Place  $n$  equally spaced centres in  $[-R, R]$ , including both endpoints. For  $|y| \leq R$ , the nearest-centre distance is at most  $R/(n-1)$ , while outside  $[-R, R]$  it is at most  $|y|$ . Therefore

$$e_n \leq \frac{R}{n-1} + \int_{|y|>R} |y| d\mu(y) < \frac{R}{n-1} + \varepsilon.$$

For nonconstant continuous  $f$ , the sequence is therefore strictly decreasing and tends to zero:

$$0 < e_n < e_{n-1}, \quad e_n \downarrow 0.$$

1. Smooth high-resolution asymptotic



The permission in the statement to add assumptions allows a more explicit asymptotic answer. Theorem 4 Assume that the quantile  $q$  extends to a  $C^1$  function on  $[0, 1]$  and that

$$q'(u) > 0 \quad (0 \leq u \leq 1).$$

Then

$$e_n = \frac{1}{4n} \left( \int_0^1 \sqrt{q'(u)} du \right)^2 (1 + o(1)). \quad (9.1)$$

Proof Put

$$g = q', \quad m_0 = \min_{[0,1]} g > 0, \quad M_0 = \max_{[0,1]} g,$$

and let  $\omega$  be the modulus of continuity of  $g$ . For a block  $[a, b]$ , write

$$h = b - a, \quad c = \frac{a + b}{2}.$$

Since  $q(c)$  is the block median,

$$\begin{aligned} K(a, b) &= \int_0^{h/2} (q(c + v) - q(c - v)) dv \\ &= \int_0^{h/2} \int_{c-v}^{c+v} g(r) dr dv. \end{aligned}$$

Hence

$$\left| K(a, b) - \frac{g(c)h^2}{4} \right| \leq \frac{\omega(h)h^2}{4}. \quad (9.2)$$

Let

$$A = \int_0^1 \sqrt{g(u)} du.$$

For the upper bound, choose the breakpoints so that

$$\int_{s_{i-1}}^{s_i} \sqrt{g(u)} du = \frac{A}{n}.$$

The largest block length is  $O(1/n)$ . By (9.2), uniformly in  $i$ ,

$$K(s_{i-1}, s_i) = \frac{A^2}{4n^2}(1 + o(1)).$$

Summing gives

$$e_n \leq \frac{A^2}{4n}(1 + o(1)). \quad (9.3)$$

For the lower bound, an equal-length partition gives

$$e_n \leq \frac{M_0}{4n}.$$

On the other hand, every block of length  $h$  costs at least

$$\frac{m_0 h^2}{4}.$$

Thus, for an optimal partition, its largest block length tends to zero. Let  $h_i = s_i - s_{i-1}$  and  $c_i = (s_{i-1} + s_i)/2$ . From (9.2),

$$e_n \geq \frac{1 - o(1)}{4} \sum_{i=1}^n g(c_i) h_i^2.$$

Cauchy–Schwarz gives

$$\sum_{i=1}^n g(c_i) h_i^2 \geq \frac{1}{n} \left( \sum_{i=1}^n \sqrt{g(c_i)} h_i \right)^2.$$

The sum in parentheses is a Riemann sum for  $A$ , because the mesh tends to zero. Therefore

$$e_n \geq \frac{A^2}{4n}(1 - o(1)). \quad (9.4)$$

Combining (9.3) and (9.4) proves (9.1).

**Density form** If  $\mu$  has a positive continuous density  $p$  on a compact interval  $[A, B]$ , then

$$q'(u) = \frac{1}{p(q(u))}.$$

Changing variables  $u = F(y)$  gives

$$\int_0^1 \sqrt{q'(u)} du = \int_A^B \sqrt{p(y)} dy.$$

Hence

$$e_n = \frac{1}{4n} \left( \int_A^B \sqrt{p(y)} dy \right)^2 (1 + o(1)). \quad (9.5)$$

If  $f \in C^1([0, 1])$  is strictly monotone with  $f'$  nowhere zero, then  $q$  is  $f$  or its reversal, and

$$e_n = \frac{1}{4n} \left( \int_0^1 \sqrt{|f'(t)|} dt \right)^2 (1 + o(1)). \quad (9.6)$$

For an affine  $f$ , (9.6) gives the exact value  $|\alpha|/(4n)$ .

1. Uniqueness is not guaranteed

Even smooth strict monotonicity of  $f$  does not force a unique optimal  $n$ -point set. Consider first the nondecreasing step function

$$q_0(u) = \begin{cases} -1, & 0 < u < 1/5, \\ 0, & 1/5 \leq u \leq 4/5, \\ 1, & 4/5 < u < 1. \end{cases}$$

For  $n = 2$ , denote by  $J_{q_0}(s)$  the cost of the partition  $(0, s, 1)$ . Directly,

$$J_{q_0}(1/5) = \frac{1}{5}, \quad J_{q_0}(1/2) = \frac{2}{5}.$$

For two quantiles  $q, \tilde{q}$ , their primitives satisfy

$$\sup_t |H_q(t) - H_{\tilde{q}}(t)| \leq \|q - \tilde{q}\|_{L^1},$$

and consequently

$$\sup_{0 \leq s \leq 1} |J_q(s) - J_{\tilde{q}}(s)| \leq 8\|q - \tilde{q}\|_{L^1}. \quad (10.1)$$

Choose a  $C^\infty$ , strictly increasing function  $q$  satisfying

$$q(1 - u) = -q(u)$$

and

$$\|q - q_0\|_{L^1} < \frac{1}{80}.$$

Such a  $q$  is obtained, for example, by symmetric mollification of  $q_0$ , followed by adding a sufficiently small positive multiple of  $2u - 1$ . By (10.1),

$$J_q(1/5) < \frac{3}{10} < J_q(1/2).$$

Thus  $1/2$  is not an optimal breakpoint. But symmetry gives

$$J_q(s) = J_q(1 - s).$$

Therefore every minimizing breakpoint  $s_* \neq 1/2$  has a distinct minimizing partner  $1 - s_*$ . Since  $q$  is strictly increasing, the corresponding unordered pairs of centres are distinct. Taking  $f = q$  gives a smooth strictly increasing example with at least two different optimal two-point sets. Hence the occurrence of the possibly non-singleton set  $\mathcal{S}_n$  in (5.4) is genuinely necessary.

#### 1. Role and necessity of the hypotheses

Absolute integrability. This is necessary for a finite problem. If

$$\int_0^1 |f(t)| dt = \infty,$$

then for  $M = \max_i |x_i|$ ,

$$\delta(X, f(t)) \geq (|f(t)| - M)_+,$$

so  $\phi(X) = +\infty$  for every  $X$ . Continuity. It is not needed for the general quantile formula or existence theorem. It is used to show that the support is an interval with no gaps, hence that  $q$  is continuous and every positive block has a unique median. Without continuity, median intervals can be nontrivial. For example, for the distribution

$$\frac{1}{2}\delta_{-1} + \frac{1}{2}\delta_1,$$

every  $x \in [-1, 1]$  is a one-centre minimizer. Nonconstancy. It is necessary for strict decrease of  $e_n$ , strict positivity of block lengths, and distinctness of optimal centres. Atomlessness. It is needed only for the simple equal-mass equations (6.2). The exact quantile formula remains valid in the presence of atoms. Compactness of the image. No such assumption is required. The support may be unbounded; finite first moment suffices.

#### 1. Topological, countability, and choice assumptions

The proof takes place entirely in the ordinary Euclidean spaces  $\mathbb{R}$ ,  $\mathbb{R}^n$ , and the finite-dimensional simplex  $\Delta_n$ .

The separation assumptions are only the usual Hausdorff structure of Euclidean space.

Existence uses the compactness of the closed simplex  $\Delta_n$  and continuity of  $J_n$ . No compactness of  $\text{supp } \mu$  is used.

All spaces involved are metrizable and second countable. Compactness may equivalently be handled by sequential compactness; nets or filters are unnecessary.

No countability assumption on level sets or fibres of  $f$  is used.

The quantile is canonically defined, so no choice principle is required there. Choosing one median on each of finitely many blocks uses only finite choice.

No interchange of a non-absolutely convergent integral or unjustified limiting operation occurs.

Final answer For a nonconstant continuous integrable  $f$ , let  $q$  be its nondecreasing rearrangement and  $H(s) = \int_0^s q$ . Then

$$\min_X \phi(X) = \min_{0=s_0 < \dots < s_n=1} \sum_{i=1}^n \left[ H(s_{i-1}) + H(s_i) - 2H\left(\frac{s_{i-1} + s_i}{2}\right) \right].$$

The minimum is attained. If  $\mathcal{S}_n$  denotes the set of optimal partitions, the complete set of minimizing tuples is

$$\bigcup_{s \in \mathcal{S}_n} \mathfrak{S}_n \cdot \left( q\left(\frac{s_0 + s_1}{2}\right), \dots, q\left(\frac{s_{n-1} + s_n}{2}\right) \right).$$

Every optimal partition satisfies

$$2q(s_i) = q\left(\frac{s_{i-1} + s_i}{2}\right) + q\left(\frac{s_i + s_{i+1}}{2}\right), \quad 1 \leq i < n.$$

These formulas give the exact minimum, a complete classification of every point of attainment, an exact Bellman algorithm, and—in the smooth positive-density case—the asymptotic value

$$e_n \sim \frac{1}{4n} \left( \int \sqrt{p} \right)^2.$$

**Formal verification.** Lean source; online type-check.

## 12 Question Q776

**Informal verdict.** A — **Complete solution**, with high confidence.

**Lean coverage (partial).** Lean proves the exact Hadamard integral representation, the dominant-saddle extremal lemma, the sharp exponential envelope for every fixed  $m$ , and the complete Bessel identity for  $m=2$ . The general oscillatory Poincaré expansion, algebraic prefactor, correction coefficient, and uniform remainder remain under Aristotle continuation.

### 12.1 Audited informal answer

Q776 — Restatement For each fixed integer  $m \geq 2$ , define the entire function

$$f_m(x) = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{x^n}{(n!)^m}.$$

The problem asks for a simple asymptotic equivalent of  $f_m(x)$  as  $x \rightarrow -\infty$ . The editorial remark also records the positive-axis asymptotic

$$f_m(x) \sim (2\pi)^{(1-m)/2} m^{-1/2} x^{(1-m)/(2m)} e^{mx^{1/m}} \quad (x \rightarrow +\infty).$$

This is the complete statement on page 14 of the canonical PDF. Luc Pommeret There is no apparent typo. There is, however, a genuine ambiguity in the word “equivalent”: on the negative axis the dominant term is oscillatory and has infinitely many zeros, so it cannot be a global equivalent in the strict ratio sense. The correct global result is an additive Poincaré asymptotic expansion.

Final theorem Fix  $m \geq 2$ . Put

$$t = -x, \quad R = t^{1/m}, \quad \alpha = \frac{\pi}{m},$$

and define

$$\Psi_m(R) = mR \sin \alpha - \frac{m-1}{2} \alpha = mR \sin \frac{\pi}{m} - \frac{(m-1)\pi}{2m}.$$

Then, as  $x \rightarrow -\infty$ , equivalently  $R \rightarrow +\infty$ ,

$$f_m(x) = \frac{2(2\pi)^{(1-m)/2}}{\sqrt{m}} t^{(1-m)/(2m)} e^{mt^{1/m} \cos(\pi/m)} \\ \times \left[ \cos \Psi_m(t^{1/m}) + \frac{m^2 - 1}{24m t^{1/m}} \cos \left( \Psi_m(t^{1/m}) - \frac{\pi}{m} \right) + O_m(t^{-2/m}) \right].$$

In particular, the leading global estimate is

$$f_m(x) = \frac{2(2\pi)^{(1-m)/2}}{\sqrt{m}} (-x)^{(1-m)/(2m)} e^{m(-x)^{1/m} \cos(\pi/m)} \left[ \cos \left( m(-x)^{1/m} \sin \frac{\pi}{m} - \frac{(m-1)\pi}{2m} \right) + O_m((-x)^{-2/m}) \right].$$

The constants implicit in the  $O$ -terms depend on the fixed integer  $m$ , but not on  $x$ . More generally, there are real constants  $c_{m,k}$ , with

$$c_{m,0} = 1, \quad c_{m,1} = \frac{m^2 - 1}{24m},$$

such that, for every fixed  $N \geq 1$ ,

$$f_m(-R^m) = \frac{2(2\pi)^{(1-m)/2}}{\sqrt{m}} R^{-(m-1)/2} e^{mR \cos(\pi/m)} \\ \times \left[ \sum_{k=0}^{N-1} \frac{c_{m,k}}{R^k} \cos \left( \Psi_m(R) - \frac{k\pi}{m} \right) + O_{m,N}(R^{-N}) \right].$$

This is a full asymptotic expansion in descending integral powers of  $R = (-x)^{1/m}$ .

Proof

1. An exact torus integral representation

Let  $d = m - 1$ , and for  $\theta = (\theta_1, \dots, \theta_d) \in [-\pi, \pi]^d$ , set

$$S(\theta) = \sum_{j=1}^d e^{i\theta_j} + e^{-i(\theta_1 + \dots + \theta_d)}.$$

For every  $r \in \mathbb{C}$ ,

$$f_m(r^m) = \frac{1}{(2\pi)^d} \int_{[-\pi, \pi]^d} e^{rS(\theta)} d\theta.$$

Indeed, expanding all exponentials gives

$$e^{rS(\theta)} = \prod_{j=1}^d \left( \sum_{n_j \geq 0} \frac{r^{n_j} e^{in_j \theta_j}}{n_j!} \right) \left( \sum_{n_m \geq 0} \frac{r^{n_m} e^{-in_m(\theta_1 + \dots + \theta_d)}}{n_m!} \right).$$

The expansion is absolutely and uniformly convergent on the compact torus. Integration with respect to each  $\theta_j$  forces

$$n_j = n_m \quad (1 \leq j \leq d).$$

Consequently,

$$\frac{1}{(2\pi)^d} \int e^{rS(\theta)} d\theta = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{r^{mn}}{(n!)^m} = f_m(r^m).$$

For the negative axis choose

$$r = Re^{i\alpha}, \quad \alpha = \frac{\pi}{m},$$

so that  $r^m = -R^m$ .

#### 1. Identification of the dominant saddle points for $m \geq 3$

We first prove an elementary extremal lemma. Lemma Let  $z_1, \dots, z_m$  be complex numbers of modulus 1 satisfying

$$z_1 z_2 \cdots z_m = -1.$$

For  $m \geq 3$ ,

$$\operatorname{Re}(z_1 + \cdots + z_m) \leq m \cos \frac{\pi}{m}.$$

Equality holds exactly in the following two cases:

$$z_1 = \cdots = z_m = e^{i\pi/m},$$

or

$$z_1 = \cdots = z_m = e^{-i\pi/m}.$$

Proof The constraint set is compact, so a maximum exists. Write  $z_j = e^{iu_j}$ . Tangent variations preserving the product have the form



$$u_j \mapsto u_j + st_j, \quad \sum_{j=1}^m t_j = 0.$$

At a critical point,

$$\sum_{j=1}^m (-\sin u_j) t_j = 0$$

for every  $(t_j)$  of sum zero. Hence all the numbers  $\sin u_j$  are equal. Thus, for some  $\beta$ , each  $u_j$  is congruent modulo  $2\pi$  either to  $\beta$  or to  $\pi - \beta$ . Suppose  $p$  of the angles are of the first type and  $m - p$  are of the second type. Then

$$\operatorname{Re} \sum_{j=1}^m z_j = (2p - m) \cos \beta.$$

If  $0 < p < m$ , then

$$\operatorname{Re} \sum z_j \leq |2p - m| \leq m - 2.$$

On the other hand,

$$m - m \cos \frac{\pi}{m} = 2m \sin^2 \frac{\pi}{2m} < \frac{\pi^2}{2m} < 2 \quad (m \geq 3),$$

so

$$m - 2 < m \cos \frac{\pi}{m}.$$

Therefore no mixed configuration can maximize the real part. At a maximizer all the  $z_j$  are equal, say  $z_j = z$ . The product condition gives  $z^m = -1$ . Among the  $m$ -th roots of  $-1$ , the largest real part is  $\cos(\pi/m)$ , attained exactly by  $e^{\pm i\pi/m}$ .  $\square$  Apply the lemma with

$$z_j = e^{i(\alpha + \theta_j)} \quad (1 \leq j \leq d), \quad z_m = e^{i(\alpha - \theta_1 - \dots - \theta_d)}.$$

Their product is

$$z_1 \cdots z_m = e^{im\alpha} = -1,$$

and

$$\operatorname{Re}(rS(\theta)) = R \operatorname{Re}(z_1 + \cdots + z_m).$$

Thus the maximum of the real part of the exponent is

$$mR \cos \alpha,$$

and there are exactly two maximizers on the torus:

$$\theta^{(+)} = (0, \dots, 0)$$

and

$$\theta^{(-)} = (-2\alpha, \dots, -2\alpha).$$

Outside fixed disjoint neighborhoods of these points, compactness gives some  $\eta_m > 0$  such that

$$\operatorname{Re}(rS(\theta)) \leq mR \cos \alpha - \eta_m R.$$

The corresponding part of the integral is therefore

$$O_m(e^{mR \cos \alpha - \eta_m R}),$$

which is exponentially smaller than every term retained below.

#### 1. Local expansion at a saddle

We analyze the saddle at the origin. Introduce

$$v_j = u_j \quad (1 \leq j \leq d), \quad v_m = -\sum_{j=1}^d u_j.$$

Then  $\sum_{j=1}^m v_j = 0$ , and locally

$$S(u) = \sum_{j=1}^m e^{iv_j}.$$

Taylor expansion gives

$$S(u) = m - \frac{1}{2}Q(u) + H_3(u) + H_4(u) + H_5(u) + O_m(|u|^6),$$

where

$$Q(u) = \sum_{j=1}^m v_j^2,$$

$$H_3(u) = -\frac{i}{6} \sum_{j=1}^m v_j^3, \quad H_4(u) = \frac{1}{24} \sum_{j=1}^m v_j^4,$$

and  $H_5$  is homogeneous and odd. The quadratic form is

$$Q(u) = \sum_{j=1}^d u_j^2 + \left( \sum_{j=1}^d u_j \right)^2 = u^\top A u,$$

with

$$A = I_d + \mathbf{1}\mathbf{1}^\top.$$

Its eigenvalues are 1, with multiplicity  $d - 1$ , and  $m$ , with multiplicity 1. Hence

$$\det A = m.$$

Let  $\rho \rightarrow \infty$  in a fixed closed subsector of  $\operatorname{Re} \rho > 0$ . A standard scaling  $u = |\rho|^{-1/2} y$ , made rigorous by splitting into  $|y| \leq |\rho|^\varepsilon$  and its complement, yields

$$\begin{aligned} \int_{\text{near } 0} e^{\rho(S(u)-m)} du &= \frac{(2\pi)^{d/2}}{\sqrt{m}} \rho^{-d/2} \\ &\times \left( 1 + \frac{c_{m,1}}{\rho} + O_m(|\rho|^{-2}) \right). \end{aligned}$$

For completeness, we calculate  $c_{m,1}$ . After the Gaussian scaling, the potential contribution of order  $\rho^{-1/2}$  is odd and integrates to zero. The contribution of order  $\rho^{-1}$  is

$$H_4 + \frac{1}{2} H_3^2.$$

Let  $V = (V_1, \dots, V_m)$  be the centered Gaussian vector on the hyperplane  $\sum V_j = 0$  corresponding to the density  $e^{-Q/2}$ . Its covariance matrix is

$$\mathbb{E}(V_j V_k) = \delta_{jk} - \frac{1}{m}.$$

In particular,

$$v := \mathbb{E}(V_j^2) = \frac{m-1}{m}, \quad c := \mathbb{E}(V_j V_k) = -\frac{1}{m} \quad (j \neq k).$$

By Gaussian pairings,

$$\mathbb{E}(V_j^4) = 3v^2,$$

so

$$\mathbb{E} \sum_{j=1}^m V_j^4 = \frac{3(m-1)^2}{m}.$$

Also,

$$\mathbb{E}(V_j^6) = 15v^3,$$

and, for  $j \neq k$ ,

$$\mathbb{E}(V_j^3 V_k^3) = 9v^2 c + 6c^3.$$

Therefore

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E} \left( \sum_{j=1}^m V_j^3 \right)^2 &= 15mv^3 + m(m-1)(9v^2 c + 6c^3) \\ &= \frac{6(m-1)(m-2)}{m}. \end{aligned}$$

It follows that

$$\begin{aligned} c_{m,1} &= \frac{1}{24} \mathbb{E} \sum_j V_j^4 - \frac{1}{72} \mathbb{E} \left( \sum_j V_j^3 \right)^2 \\ &= \frac{(m-1)^2}{8m} - \frac{(m-1)(m-2)}{12m} \\ &= \boxed{\frac{m^2 - 1}{24m}}. \end{aligned}$$

The same scaling argument, carried to arbitrary order, gives

$$\int_{\text{near } 0} e^{\rho(S(u)-m)} du \sim \frac{(2\pi)^{d/2}}{\sqrt{m}} \rho^{-d/2} \sum_{k=0}^{\infty} \frac{c_{m,k}}{\rho^k}.$$

Only integral powers occur: at every half-integral order the polynomial in the scaled variables is odd, so its Gaussian integral vanishes.

1. The two conjugate saddle contributions for  $m \geq 3$

At the first saddle take

$$\rho = r = Re^{i\alpha}.$$

Its contribution is

$$\frac{(2\pi)^{-d/2}}{\sqrt{m}} e^{mr} r^{-d/2} \left(1 + \frac{c_{m,1}}{r} + O_m(R^{-2})\right).$$

For the second saddle, write

$$\theta = \theta^{(-)} + u.$$

An exact identity holds:

$$S(\theta^{(-)} + u) = e^{-2i\alpha} S(u).$$

Indeed, every one of the  $m$  exponential terms acquires the same factor  $e^{-2i\alpha}$ . Consequently,

$$rS(\theta^{(-)} + u) = \bar{r}S(u),$$

because

$$re^{-2i\alpha} = Re^{-i\alpha} = \bar{r}.$$

Thus the second saddle contributes the complex conjugate

$$\frac{(2\pi)^{-d/2}}{\sqrt{m}} e^{m\bar{r}} \bar{r}^{-d/2} \left(1 + \frac{c_{m,1}}{\bar{r}} + O_m(R^{-2})\right).$$

Adding the two contributions and absorbing the exponentially smaller remainder gives

$$\begin{aligned} f_m(-R^m) = \frac{(2\pi)^{-d/2}}{\sqrt{m}} & \left[ e^{mr} r^{-d/2} \left(1 + \frac{c_{m,1}}{r} + O_m(R^{-2})\right) \right. \\ & \left. + e^{m\bar{r}} \bar{r}^{-d/2} \left(1 + \frac{c_{m,1}}{\bar{r}} + O_m(R^{-2})\right) \right]. \end{aligned}$$

Now

$$e^{mr} r^{-d/2} = R^{-d/2} e^{mR \cos \alpha} e^{i(mR \sin \alpha - d\alpha/2)}.$$

Therefore

$$f_m(-R^m) = \frac{2(2\pi)^{-d/2}}{\sqrt{m}} R^{-d/2} e^{mR \cos \alpha} \\ \times \left[ \cos \left( mR \sin \alpha - \frac{d}{2} \alpha \right) + \frac{c_{m,1}}{R} \cos \left( mR \sin \alpha - \frac{d}{2} \alpha - \alpha \right) + O_m(R^{-2}) \right].$$

Since  $d = m - 1$ , this is the claimed formula for  $m \geq 3$ .

1. The exceptional boundary case  $m = 2$

Here  $\alpha = \pi/2$ , so  $\operatorname{Re} r = 0$ ; the real-part maximum used above is no longer isolated. A stationary-phase argument is required. The integral representation becomes

$$f_2(-R^2) = \frac{1}{2\pi} \int_{-\pi}^{\pi} e^{2iR \cos \theta} d\theta.$$

Equivalently,

$$f_2(-R^2) = J_0(2R).$$

The stationary points are  $\theta = 0$  and  $\theta = \pi$ . Near  $\theta = 0$ , make the exact substitution

$$u = 2 \sin \frac{\theta}{2}.$$

Then

$$2 \cos \theta = 2 - u^2, \quad d\theta = \frac{du}{\sqrt{1 - u^2/4}}.$$

With a smooth cutoff equal to 1 near the saddle, the local amplitude  $a(u)$  satisfies

$$a(0) = 1, \quad a''(0) = \frac{1}{4}.$$

For a smooth compactly supported amplitude,

$$\int_{\mathbb{R}} e^{-iRu^2} a(u) du = e^{-i\pi/4} \sqrt{\frac{\pi}{R}} \left[ a(0) - \frac{i}{4R} a''(0) + O(R^{-2}) \right].$$

One direct proof uses the Fourier transform and the exact Fresnel identity

$$\int_{\mathbb{R}} e^{-iRu^2 + i\xi u} du = e^{-i\pi/4} \sqrt{\frac{\pi}{R}} e^{i\xi^2/(4R)}.$$

Thus the contribution of  $\theta = 0$  is

$$\frac{e^{i(2R-\pi/4)}}{2\sqrt{\pi R}} \left( 1 - \frac{i}{16R} + O(R^{-2}) \right).$$

The contribution of  $\theta = \pi$  is its complex conjugate. Away from the two stationary points, repeated integration by parts gives an error smaller than any prescribed power of  $R^{-1}$ . Hence

$$f_2(-R^2) = \frac{1}{\sqrt{\pi R}} \left[ \cos\left(2R - \frac{\pi}{4}\right) + \frac{1}{16R} \sin\left(2R - \frac{\pi}{4}\right) + O(R^{-2}) \right].$$

This is exactly the general formula, because

$$\left. \frac{m^2 - 1}{24m} \right|_{m=2} = \frac{1}{16},$$

and

$$\cos\left(\Psi_2(R) - \frac{\pi}{2}\right) = \sin \Psi_2(R).$$

Thus all  $m \geq 2$  are covered.

Why the leading term is not a global strict equivalent Let

$$\mathcal{A}_m(R) = \frac{2(2\pi)^{(1-m)/2}}{\sqrt{m}} R^{-(m-1)/2} e^{mR \cos(\pi/m)}.$$

The leading approximation would be

$$\mathcal{A}_m(R) \cos \Psi_m(R).$$

For integers  $k$  large enough, define

$$R_k^* = \frac{\frac{\pi}{2} + k\pi + \frac{(m-1)\pi}{2m}}{m \sin(\pi/m)}.$$

Then

$$\Psi_m(R_k^*) = \frac{\pi}{2} + k\pi,$$

so the proposed leading expression is exactly zero. But the two-term expansion gives

$$\begin{aligned} f_m(-(R_k^*)^m) &= \mathcal{A}_m(R_k^*) \left[ \frac{m^2 - 1}{24mR_k^*} \cos \left( \frac{\pi}{2} + k\pi - \frac{\pi}{m} \right) + O_m((R_k^*)^{-2}) \right] \\ &= (-1)^k \mathcal{A}_m(R_k^*) \left[ \frac{m^2 - 1}{24mR_k^*} \sin \frac{\pi}{m} + O_m((R_k^*)^{-2}) \right], \end{aligned}$$

which is nonzero for all sufficiently large  $k$ . Therefore

$$f_m(-R^m) \sim \mathcal{A}_m(R) \cos \Psi_m(R)$$

is not valid globally in the strict quotient sense. It is valid along every approach for which

$$R |\cos \Psi_m(R)| \longrightarrow \infty.$$

In particular, it holds uniformly on sets satisfying

$$|\cos \Psi_m(R)| \geq \delta > 0.$$

The additive expansion stated in the theorem is valid without excluding any values of  $R$ .

Checks and boundary behavior  $m = 2$

$$f_2(-t) = J_0(2\sqrt{t}),$$

and the theorem gives

$$f_2(-t) = \frac{t^{-1/4}}{\sqrt{\pi}} \left[ \cos \left( 2\sqrt{t} - \frac{\pi}{4} \right) + \frac{1}{16\sqrt{t}} \sin \left( 2\sqrt{t} - \frac{\pi}{4} \right) + O(t^{-1}) \right],$$

the classical Bessel expansion.  $m = 3$  Since  $\cos(\pi/3) = 1/2$  and  $\sin(\pi/3) = \sqrt{3}/2$ ,

$$\begin{aligned} f_3(-t) &= \frac{e^{\frac{3}{2}t^{1/3}}}{\pi\sqrt{3}t^{1/3}} \left[ \cos \left( \frac{3\sqrt{3}}{2}t^{1/3} - \frac{\pi}{3} \right) \right. \\ &\quad \left. + \frac{1}{9t^{1/3}} \cos \left( \frac{3\sqrt{3}}{2}t^{1/3} - \frac{2\pi}{3} \right) + O(t^{-2/3}) \right]. \end{aligned}$$



Thus  $f_3(-t)$  oscillates with an exponentially increasing envelope. Sign changes At points where  $\Psi_m(R) = k\pi$ ,

$$f_m(-R^m) = (-1)^k \mathcal{A}_m(R)(1 + O_m(R^{-1})).$$

Hence  $f_m$  changes sign infinitely often on the negative real axis, for every  $m \geq 2$ . Necessity of the hypotheses The integer condition on  $m$  is essential to the elementary  $m$ -torus representation used in the proof. The case  $m = 1$ , excluded in the statement, is qualitatively different:

$$f_1(x) = e^x, \quad f_1(x) = e^x \quad (x \rightarrow -\infty).$$

The estimates above are for fixed  $m$ . They are not uniform as  $m \rightarrow \infty$ : the two dominant saddles are separated by  $2\pi/m$  and coalesce in that additional limit.

**Formal verification.** Lean source; online type-check.

## 13 Question Q781

**Informal verdict.** A — Complete solution, with high confidence.

**Lean coverage.** Lean proves the full arbitrary-index compact-topological-group translation-separation theorem without metrizability or countability assumptions.

### 13.1 Audited informal answer

Q781 — Complete solution

1. Faithful restatement and interpretation

Let  $G$  be a compact topological group, and let  $(A_i)_{i \in I}$  be a family of subsets of  $G$ . The family is called separable by translations if there are elements  $t_i \in G$  such that the left translates  $t_i A_i$ ,  $i \in I$ , are pairwise disjoint. Given a family  $(U_i)_{i \in I}$  of open subsets of  $G$ , assume that every finite subfamily is separable by translations. Prove that the whole family is separable by translations. The PDF first says merely “let  $G$  be a group” and then speaks of compactness and open subsets. The intended meaning must therefore be “compact topological group.” The word “separable” is the specially defined translation-packing property, not separability in the sense of possessing a countable dense subset.

The parenthetical remark permits assuming metrizability and countability if needed, but neither is necessary. There are no further subparts or footnotes.  
Luc Pommeret+1

1. The theorem

Theorem Let  $G$  be a compact topological group, let  $I$  be an arbitrary index set, and let  $U_i \subseteq G$  be open for every  $i \in I$ . Suppose that for every finite  $F \subseteq I$ , there exist elements  $t_i^{(F)} \in G$ ,  $i \in F$ , such that

$$t_i^{(F)} U_i \cap t_j^{(F)} U_j = \emptyset \quad (i, j \in F, i \neq j).$$

Then there exist elements  $t_i \in G$ ,  $i \in I$ , such that

$$t_i U_i \cap t_j U_j = \emptyset \quad (i, j \in I, i \neq j).$$

Thus Q781 has an affirmative answer in its full stated generality: neither metrizability of  $G$  nor countability of  $I$  is needed.

1. The disjointness condition is closed

The crucial point is that, because the  $U_i$  are open, collision of two translated sets is an open condition on the two translation parameters. Fix distinct  $i, j \in I$ . Define

$$R_{ij} = \{(s, t) \in G \times G : sU_i \cap tU_j = \emptyset\}.$$

We claim that  $R_{ij}$  is closed in  $G \times G$ . Indeed, for  $s, t \in G$ ,

$$\begin{aligned} sU_i \cap tU_j \neq \emptyset &\iff \exists u \in U_i, v \in U_j \text{ such that } su = tv \\ &\iff \exists u \in U_i, v \in U_j \text{ such that } s^{-1}t = uv^{-1} \\ &\iff s^{-1}t \in U_i U_j^{-1}. \end{aligned}$$

The subset  $U_i U_j^{-1}$  is open. To see this, inversion is a homeomorphism, so  $U_j^{-1}$  is open, and

$$U_i U_j^{-1} = \bigcup_{u \in U_i} u U_j^{-1}$$

is a union of open left translates. The map

$$q : G \times G \longrightarrow G, \quad q(s, t) = s^{-1}t,$$

is continuous. Consequently,

$$(G \times G) \setminus R_{ij} = q^{-1}(U_i U_j^{-1})$$

is open. Hence  $R_{ij}$  is closed. Notice the useful direction of semicontinuity here: a limit of pairs of translations whose corresponding open sets are disjoint still gives disjoint open sets. In contrast, a limit of intersecting translated open sets need not remain intersecting.

# 1. Compactness of the full parameter space

Consider the product space

$$X = G^I = \prod_{i \in I} G$$

with the product topology. A point  $x \in X$  will be written

$$x = (x_i)_{i \in I}.$$

By Tychonoff's theorem,  $X$  is compact. For every unordered pair  $\{i, j\} \subseteq I$ ,  $i \neq j$ , define

$$K_{ij} = \{x = (x_k)_{k \in I} \in X : x_i U_i \cap x_j U_j = \emptyset\}.$$

Let

$$p_{ij} : X \longrightarrow G \times G, \quad p_{ij}(x) = (x_i, x_j)$$

be the coordinate projection. Then

$$K_{ij} = p_{ij}^{-1}(R_{ij}).$$

Since  $R_{ij}$  is closed and  $p_{ij}$  is continuous,  $K_{ij}$  is closed in  $X$ . We now prove that the family

$$\{K_{ij} : i, j \in I, i \neq j\}$$

has the finite-intersection property. Take finitely many pair constraints,

$$K_{i_1 j_1}, \dots, K_{i_m j_m}.$$

Let

$$F = \{i_1, j_1, \dots, i_m, j_m\} \subseteq I.$$

This is a finite set of indices. By hypothesis, the finite family  $(U_i)_{i \in F}$  can be separated: there exist  $s_i \in G$ ,  $i \in F$ , such that

$$s_i U_i \cap s_j U_j = \emptyset \quad (i, j \in F, i \neq j).$$

Extend this finite assignment to a point  $x \in G^I$  by setting

$$x_i = \begin{cases} s_i, & i \in F, \\ e, & i \notin F, \end{cases}$$

where  $e$  is the identity of  $G$ . Then

$$x \in K_{i_1 j_1} \cap \cdots \cap K_{i_m j_m}.$$

Thus every finite intersection of the  $K_{ij}$  is nonempty. Because  $X$  is compact and the  $K_{ij}$  are closed with the finite-intersection property,

$$\bigcap_{\substack{i, j \in I \\ i \neq j}} K_{ij} \neq \emptyset.$$

Choose

$$(t_i)_{i \in I} \in \bigcap_{i \neq j} K_{ij}.$$

Then, by the definition of  $K_{ij}$ ,

$$t_i U_i \cap t_j U_j = \emptyset \quad (i \neq j).$$

Therefore the entire family  $(U_i)_{i \in I}$  is separable by translations.  $\square$

#### 1. The countable metrizable proof

The optional assumptions in the PDF allow a purely sequential formulation. Suppose  $I = \mathbb{N}$  and  $G$  is compact metrizable. For each  $n \geq 1$ , choose translations

$$t_1^{(n)}, \dots, t_n^{(n)}$$

separating  $U_1, \dots, U_n$ , and extend this to a point  $x^{(n)} \in G^{\mathbb{N}}$  by setting

$$x_k^{(n)} = \begin{cases} t_k^{(n)}, & k \leq n, \\ e, & k > n. \end{cases}$$

If  $d$  is a compatible metric on  $G$ , the product topology on  $G^{\mathbb{N}}$  is induced by, for example,

$$D(x, y) = \sum_{k=1}^{\infty} 2^{-k} \min\{1, d(x_k, y_k)\}.$$

The countable product  $G^{\mathbb{N}}$  is compact metrizable. Equivalently, one may obtain a convergent subsequence by successively extracting subsequences on which the first coordinate converges, then the second, and so on, and taking the diagonal subsequence. Thus, after passing to a subsequence,

$$x^{(n_r)} \longrightarrow x = (t_k)_{k \geq 1} \quad \text{in } G^{\mathbb{N}}.$$

Fix  $i \neq j$ . Since  $n_r \rightarrow \infty$ , for every sufficiently large  $r$ ,

$$x_i^{(n_r)} U_i \cap x_j^{(n_r)} U_j = \emptyset.$$

The relation  $R_{ij}$  proved closed above, so passage to the limit gives

$$t_i U_i \cap t_j U_j = \emptyset.$$

Since  $i, j$  were arbitrary, the limit tuple separates the entire family. Why this is not the general proof For a general compact group, compactness is not a sequential notion. A compact space need not be sequentially compact, and an uncountable product  $G^I$  generally need not be metrizable or first countable. For example, the compact Boolean group

$$H = \{0, 1\}^{\mathcal{P}(\mathbb{N})}$$

is not sequentially compact. Define  $x_n \in H$  by

$$x_n(A) = \begin{cases} 1, & n \in A, \\ 0, & n \notin A. \end{cases}$$

Given any subsequence  $(x_{n_k})$ , take

$$A = \{n_{2k} : k \geq 1\}.$$

Then the  $A$ -coordinate of  $x_{n_k}$  alternates between 0 and 1, so the subsequence does not converge. Thus a proof that simply says “extract a convergent subsequence” would be invalid without the metrizability assumptions. The finite-intersection argument above is genuinely non-sequential and works in the full generality of Q781.

## 1. Audit of the topological and set-theoretic assumptions

Separation assumptions No Hausdorff, regularity, normality, or first-countability axiom is used in the argument itself. The proof only uses:

- continuity of multiplication and inversion;
- openness of the  $U_i$ ;
- compactness of  $G^I$ .

Under the usual convention, a “compact group” is a compact Hausdorff topological group, but Hausdorffness is not needed for the closed-constraint argument. Compactness The general proof uses the arbitrary-product form of Tychonoff’s theorem:

The product of an arbitrary family of compact spaces is compact in the product topology.

Compactness is then used through its equivalent finite-intersection formulation: a family of closed subsets of a compact space whose finite intersections are all nonempty has nonempty total intersection. Countability No countability assumption on  $I$  is used. No second-countability or separability assumption on  $G$  is used. Countability becomes relevant only if one wishes to replace the product-compactness proof by the sequential diagonal argument. Choice In ordinary ZFC, Tychonoff’s theorem is available. Foundationally, for compact Hausdorff spaces, the ultrafilter lemma—equivalently the Boolean prime ideal theorem—suffices for the required product compactness; full choice is more than is needed for that step. No choice is needed to extend a finite tuple to all of  $I$ : the identity  $e$  supplies a canonical value on every unused coordinate. In the countable sequential proof, literally choosing one finite separator for every  $n$  uses a countable selection principle, which is again automatic in ZFC. The precise role of openness Openness is used exactly to prove that

$$\{(s, t) : sU_i \cap tU_j = \emptyset\}$$

is closed. In fact, the same proof works under the weaker pairwise assumption

$$U_i U_j^{-1} \text{ is open for every } i \neq j.$$

Thus openness of each individual  $U_i$  is sufficient but is not the logically weakest possible condition.

## 1. Boundary cases

If  $I = \emptyset$  or  $|I| = 1$ , there are no pairwise constraints, so the conclusion is immediate. If some  $U_i = \emptyset$ , that index causes no constraint because every translate of  $U_i$  is empty. Such indices can be ignored and then assigned any translation, for example  $e$ . If  $G$  is a finite discrete group of order  $N$ , the hypothesis already implies that there are at most  $N$  nonempty  $U_i$ . Indeed,  $N + 1$  pairwise disjoint nonempty subsets cannot exist inside  $G$ . The set of nonempty indices is therefore finite, and applying the hypothesis to that finite subfamily immediately gives the conclusion. This agrees with the general compactness proof.

1. Why compactness cannot be omitted

The assertion fails for a noncompact group even when:

the group is discrete, metrizable, locally compact, and countable;  
 $I$  is countable;  
every  $U_i$  is open.  
Take

$$G = (\mathbb{Z}, +)$$

with the discrete topology. Let the index set be

$$I = \{L, R\} \cup \mathbb{N},$$

and define

$$U_L = \{m \in \mathbb{Z} : m \leq 0\}, \quad U_R = \{m \in \mathbb{Z} : m \geq 0\},$$

and

$$U_n = \{0\} \quad (n \in \mathbb{N}).$$

Every finite subfamily can be separated. Indeed, suppose it contains  $k$  of the singleton sets, indexed in some order by  $n_1, \dots, n_k$ . Use the translations

$$t_L = 0, \quad t_R = k + 1, \quad t_{n_r} = r \quad (1 \leq r \leq k).$$

Then

$$t_L + U_L = (-\infty, 0] \cap \mathbb{Z},$$

$$t_R + U_R = [k + 1, \infty) \cap \mathbb{Z},$$

and the singleton translates are

$$\{1\}, \dots, \{k\}.$$

These sets are pairwise disjoint. The same assignment works if one or both of  $L, R$  are absent from the finite subfamily. However, the entire family cannot be separated. Suppose translations  $a, b, c_n \in \mathbb{Z}$  existed. Disjointness of the two rays would require

$$a < b.$$

For the singleton  $\{c_n\}$  to avoid both rays, one must have

$$a < c_n < b.$$

Moreover, the  $c_n$  must be pairwise distinct. But the finite interval

$$\{a + 1, \dots, b - 1\}$$

contains only finitely many integers. It cannot contain all the distinct  $c_n$ . This contradiction proves that compactness is essential for a theorem of this generality.

# 1. Why arbitrary non-open subsets cannot be allowed

The result also fails for general subsets of a compact group, even if all the subsets are closed. Let

$$G = \mathbb{T} = \mathbb{R}/\mathbb{Z}$$

and choose an index set  $I$  with cardinality strictly greater than  $|\mathbb{T}|$ , for instance

$$I = \mathcal{P}(\mathbb{T}).$$

For every  $i \in I$ , put

$$A_i = \{0\}.$$

Every finite subfamily is separable: simply choose finitely many distinct elements  $t_i \in \mathbb{T}$ . A separation of the entire family would require the singleton translates

$$t_i A_i = \{t_i\}, \quad i \in I,$$



to be pairwise disjoint. Thus  $i \mapsto t_i$  would be an injection from  $I$  into  $\mathbb{T}$ , which is impossible because

$$|I| = |\mathcal{P}(\mathbb{T})| > |\mathbb{T}|.$$

Here  $G$  is compact Hausdorff and every  $A_i$  is closed, but the  $A_i$  are not open. Hence the openness/closed-collision condition cannot simply be discarded.

**Final conclusion** The answer to Q781 is yes. For each pair  $i \neq j$ , disjointness of  $t_i U_i$  and  $t_j U_j$  is a closed condition on the parameter tuple  $(t_k)_{k \in I} \in G^I$ . The finite-separability hypothesis says that these closed conditions have the finite-intersection property. Tychonoff compactness of  $G^I$  therefore supplies one tuple satisfying all pairwise conditions simultaneously.

**Formal verification.** Lean source; online type-check.

## 14 Question Q788

**Informal verdict.** **A** — **Complete solution**, with **high confidence** in the two requested regimes.

**Lean coverage (partial).** Lean proves the deterministic range for every configuration, the complete  $n=2$  distribution and upper-edge asymptotic, and two quadratic-form ingredients. The arbitrary- $n$  probability asymptotics and Brownian-bridge limit remain under Aristotle continuation.

### 14.1 Audited informal answer

Q788 — rigorous solution

1. Faithful restatement

Identify the unit circle  $\mathbb{U} \subset \mathbb{R}^2$  with

$$\mathbb{T} := \{z \in \mathbb{C} : |z| = 1\}.$$

Let  $Z_1, \dots, Z_n$  be independent Haar-uniform random points of  $\mathbb{T}$ , and put

$$P_n(z) := \prod_{j=1}^n (z - Z_j), \quad D_n := \max_{|z|=1} |P_n(z)|.$$

Thus  $D_n$  is the maximum, over  $M \in \mathbb{U}$ , of the product of the Euclidean chord distances  $MM_j$ . The problem states that  $D_n \in [2, 2^n]$  almost surely and asks for estimates of

$$\mathbb{P}(D_n \geq \alpha)$$

in the two regimes:

$\alpha$  fixed and  $n \rightarrow \infty$ ;

$n$  fixed and  $\alpha \uparrow 2^n$ .

There is one evident typographical omission in the PDF: in the sentence  $\mathbb{P}(D \in [2, 2^n]) = 1$ , the variable  $D$  should be  $D_n$ . There is no other substantive ambiguity. Luc Pommeret

### 1. Probability space and main result

Work on

$$\Omega = [0, 2\pi)^{\mathbb{N}}, \quad \mathcal{F} = \mathcal{B}([0, 2\pi))^{\otimes \mathbb{N}}, \quad \mathbb{P} = \left( \frac{d\theta}{2\pi} \right)^{\otimes \mathbb{N}}.$$

Let  $\Theta_j$  be the coordinate maps and  $Z_j = e^{i\Theta_j}$ . Then the  $Z_j$  are independent and Haar-uniform on  $\mathbb{T}$ . The map

$$(\theta_1, \dots, \theta_n) \mapsto \max_{t \in [0, 2\pi]} \prod_{j=1}^n |e^{it} - e^{i\theta_j}|$$

is continuous, since it is the maximum over a compact set of a jointly continuous function. Hence  $D_n$  is a well-defined random variable. Define

$$\kappa_n := \frac{\sqrt{n}}{\Gamma(\frac{n+1}{2})} \left( \frac{2}{\pi} \right)^{\frac{n-1}{2}}.$$

Theorem Let  $n \geq 2$ . a Fixed  $\alpha$ ,  $n \rightarrow \infty$  If  $\alpha \leq 2$ , then

$$\mathbb{P}(D_n \geq \alpha) = 1.$$

If  $\alpha > 2$ , then for every  $A > 0$  there is a constant  $C_{\alpha, A} < \infty$  such that

$$\boxed{\mathbb{P}(D_n < \alpha) \leq C_{\alpha, A} n^{-A}.$$

Consequently,

$$\boxed{\mathbb{P}(D_n \geq \alpha) = 1 - O_{\alpha, A}(n^{-A}) \quad \text{for every } A > 0.}$$

There is also a complementary explicit lower estimate: for every fixed  $\alpha > 2$ , there is  $c_\alpha > 0$  such that, for all sufficiently large  $n$ ,

$$\mathbb{P}(D_n < \alpha) \geq n! \left( \frac{c_\alpha}{\pi n \log n} \right)^n \geq \exp(-n \log \log n - O_\alpha(n)).$$

Thus the exceptional probability tends to zero faster than every negative power of  $n$ . The natural, nondegenerate scale is exponential in  $\sqrt{n}$ : there is a strictly positive random variable  $I^*$ , expressible as the maximum of a Brownian-bridge functional, such that

$$\frac{2 \log D_n}{\sqrt{n}} \xrightarrow{d} I^*.$$

Hence, at every continuity point  $x \geq 0$  of the law of  $I^*$ ,

$$\mathbb{P}(D_n \geq e^{x\sqrt{n}/2}) \longrightarrow \mathbb{P}(I^* \geq x).$$

*b* Fixed  $n$ ,  $\alpha \uparrow 2^n$  Put

$$\delta := 1 - \frac{\alpha}{2^n} = \frac{2^n - \alpha}{2^n}.$$

Then, as  $\delta \downarrow 0$ ,

$$\mathbb{P}(D_n \geq 2^n(1 - \delta)) = \kappa_n \delta^{\frac{n-1}{2}} (1 + O_n(\delta)).$$

Equivalently,

$$\mathbb{P}(D_n \geq \alpha) \sim \frac{\sqrt{n}}{\Gamma(\frac{n+1}{2})} \left( \frac{2}{\pi} \right)^{\frac{n-1}{2}} \left( \frac{2^n - \alpha}{2^n} \right)^{\frac{n-1}{2}}.$$

Moreover,

$$\mathbb{P}(D_n = 2^n) = 0.$$

## 1. Fixed-level estimates

3.1 A deterministic Fourier consequence of  $D_n \leq \alpha$  For a deterministic configuration  $Z_j = e^{i\theta_j}$ , define

$$u(t) := \log |P_n(e^{it})| = \sum_{j=1}^n \log |e^{it} - e^{i\theta_j}|.$$

The logarithmic singularities are integrable. We use the classical  $L^1$ -Fourier expansion

$$\log |1 - e^{ix}| = \log \left( 2 \left| \sin \frac{x}{2} \right| \right) = - \sum_{r=1}^{\infty} \frac{\cos(rx)}{r}.$$

For completeness, this follows by first writing, for  $0 < \rho < 1$ ,

$$\log |1 - \rho e^{ix}| = - \sum_{r=1}^{\infty} \frac{\rho^r \cos(rx)}{r},$$

and then letting  $\rho \uparrow 1$  in  $L^1([0, 2\pi])$ . The singularity is bounded by an integrable multiple of  $1 + |\log |x||$ . In particular,

$$\frac{1}{2\pi} \int_0^{2\pi} \log |e^{it} - e^{i\theta}| dt = 0.$$

Therefore

$$\frac{1}{2\pi} \int_0^{2\pi} u(t) dt = 0.$$

Suppose now that  $D_n \leq \alpha$ . Then  $u(t) \leq \log \alpha$ . Writing  $u = u_+ - u_-$ , the zero-mean identity gives

$$\int u_+ = \int u_-,$$

and hence

$$\int_0^{2\pi} |u(t)| dt = 2 \int_0^{2\pi} u_+(t) dt \leq 4\pi \log \alpha.$$

Let

$$S_r := \sum_{j=1}^n Z_j^r.$$

The  $r$ -th Fourier coefficient of  $u$ , for  $r \geq 1$ , is

$$\widehat{u}(r) = -\frac{1}{2r} \sum_{j=1}^n e^{-ir\theta_j} = -\frac{\overline{S_r}}{2r}.$$

Consequently,

$$\frac{|S_r|}{2r} = |\widehat{u}(r)| \leq \frac{1}{2\pi} \int_0^{2\pi} |u(t)| dt \leq 2 \log \alpha.$$

We have proved: Lemma 1 For every  $r \geq 1$ ,

$$\boxed{D_n \leq \alpha \implies |S_r| \leq 4r \log \alpha.}$$

Thus a uniformly bounded maximum forces every fixed collection of power sums to lie in a fixed bounded region.

3.2 A fixed-dimensional small-ball estimate Lemma 2 Fix an integer  $K \geq 1$  and positive constants  $R_1, \dots, R_K$ . Then there is  $C = C(K, R_1, \dots, R_K)$  such that

$$\mathbb{P}(|S_r| \leq R_r \text{ for } 1 \leq r \leq K) \leq Cn^{-K}.$$

Proof Introduce the  $2K$ -dimensional random vector

$$Y(\theta) := (\cos \theta, \sin \theta, \dots, \cos K\theta, \sin K\theta) \in \mathbb{R}^{2K}.$$

Then

$$(\Re S_1, \Im S_1, \dots, \Re S_K, \Im S_K) = \sum_{j=1}^n Y(\Theta_j).$$

Let

$$\varphi(\xi) := \mathbb{E}[e^{i\xi \cdot Y(\Theta_1)}] = \frac{1}{2\pi} \int_0^{2\pi} e^{i\xi \cdot Y(\theta)} d\theta$$

be the characteristic function. Behavior near the origin Orthogonality of the trigonometric system gives

$$\mathbb{E}Y = 0, \quad \mathbb{E}(YY^\top) = \frac{1}{2}I_{2K}.$$

Taylor expansion therefore yields

$$\varphi(\xi) = 1 - \frac{1}{4}|\xi|^2 + O_K(|\xi|^3).$$

Hence there are  $c, \rho > 0$ , depending only on  $K$ , such that

$$|\varphi(\xi)| \leq e^{-c|\xi|^2}, \quad |\xi| \leq \rho.$$

Behavior away from the origin If  $|\varphi(\xi)| = 1$ , equality in the triangle inequality for the defining integral implies that

$$e^{i\xi \cdot Y(\theta)}$$

is constant for almost every  $\theta$ , hence everywhere. Thus the trigonometric polynomial  $\xi \cdot Y(\theta)$  is constant modulo  $2\pi$ , and by continuity is constant as a real function. Since it has no constant Fourier coefficient, it must vanish identically. Linear independence of the sine and cosine functions then gives  $\xi = 0$ . Therefore

$$|\varphi(\xi)| < 1 \quad (\xi \neq 0).$$

We also need integrability at infinity. Write  $\xi = Rv$ , where  $R = |\xi|$  and  $|v| = 1$ , and let

$$p_v(\theta) := v \cdot Y(\theta).$$

This is a nonzero real trigonometric polynomial of degree at most  $K$ . There is a constant  $c_K > 0$  such that

$$\max_{1 \leq q \leq 2K+1} |p_v^{(q)}(\theta)| \geq c_K$$

for every unit vector  $v$  and every  $\theta$ . Indeed, otherwise compactness would give a nonzero  $p_v$  whose first  $2K+1$  derivatives vanish at some point. Then  $p_v - p_v(\theta_0)$ , after multiplication by  $e^{iK\theta}$ , would give a polynomial of degree at most  $2K$  with a zero of order greater than  $2K$ , forcing  $p_v$  to be constant, hence zero, a contradiction. Partitioning the circle into a number of intervals depending only on  $K$ , on each of which one of these derivatives stays bounded away from zero, the one-dimensional van der Corput estimate gives

$$|\varphi(\xi)| \leq C_K(1 + |\xi|)^{-1/(2K+1)}.$$

Indeed, on an interval where  $|p_v^{(q)}| \geq c_K/2$ , van der Corput gives

$$\left| \int e^{iR p_v(\theta)} d\theta \right| \leq C_K R^{-1/q} \leq C_K R^{-1/(2K+1)}.$$

Choose an integer

$$N_0 > 2K(2K + 1).$$

Then  $|\varphi|^{N_0} \in L^1(\mathbb{R}^{2K})$ . Since  $|\varphi| < 1$  away from zero and tends to zero at infinity, there is  $q \in (0, 1)$  such that

$$\sup_{|\xi| \geq \rho} |\varphi(\xi)| \leq q.$$

For  $n \geq N_0$ ,

$$\begin{aligned} \int_{\mathbb{R}^{2K}} |\varphi(\xi)|^n d\xi &\leq \int_{|\xi| < \rho} e^{-cn|\xi|^2} d\xi + q^{n-N_0} \int_{|\xi| \geq \rho} |\varphi(\xi)|^{N_0} d\xi \\ &\leq C_K n^{-K} + C_K q^n \leq C'_K n^{-K}. \end{aligned}$$

Thus the  $n$ -fold convolution of the law of  $Y$  has a bounded continuous density

$$f_n(x) = \frac{1}{(2\pi)^{2K}} \int_{\mathbb{R}^{2K}} e^{-i\xi \cdot x} \varphi(\xi)^n d\xi,$$

and

$$\|f_n\|_\infty \leq C_K n^{-K}.$$

Finally, the set

$$B = \{(w_1, \dots, w_K) \in \mathbb{C}^K : |w_r| \leq R_r\}$$

has finite  $2K$ -dimensional volume. Hence

$$\mathbb{P}((S_1, \dots, S_K) \in B) \leq \text{vol}(B) \|f_n\|_\infty \leq C n^{-K}.$$

This proves the lemma.  $\square$

3.3 Superpolynomial convergence in part *a* Fix  $\alpha > 2$ . By Lemma 1,

$$\{D_n < \alpha\} \subseteq \bigcap_{r=1}^K \{|S_r| \leq 4r \log \alpha\}.$$

Lemma 2 therefore gives

$$\mathbb{P}(D_n < \alpha) \leq C_{\alpha, K} n^{-K}.$$

Given  $A > 0$ , choose an integer  $K > A$ . Then

$$\mathbb{P}(D_n < \alpha) = O_{\alpha,A}(n^{-A}),$$

which proves the asserted upper estimate for the exceptional probability. No limit and expectation have been interchanged here: the only limiting operation used in the probabilistic estimate was Fourier inversion after proving that  $\varphi^n \in L^1$ .

3.4 A constructive lower bound for the exceptional probability We now show that  $D_n < \alpha$  is not impossible and give an explicit lower estimate. Let

$$\omega_j = e^{2\pi i j/n}, \quad 0 \leq j < n,$$

be the regular  $n$ -gon. Lemma 3: stability of the regular polygon There is an absolute constant  $C > 0$  with the following property. Suppose

$$Z_j = e^{i(2\pi j/n + \varepsilon_j)}, \quad |\varepsilon_j| \leq \eta.$$

Then

$$D_n \leq (2 + n\eta) \exp(Cn\eta \log(en)).$$

Proof Fix  $z = e^{it}$  and put

$$a_j := |z - \omega_j|.$$

Choose  $j_0$  so that  $a_{j_0}$  is minimal. Since

$$|Z_j - \omega_j| \leq |\varepsilon_j| \leq \eta,$$

we have

$$|z - Z_j| \leq a_j + \eta.$$

For  $j \neq j_0$ ,

$$a_j + \eta \leq a_j e^{\eta/a_j}.$$

Consequently,

$$\prod_{j=0}^{n-1} |z - Z_j| \leq (a_{j_0} + \eta) \prod_{j \neq j_0} a_j \exp\left(\eta \sum_{j \neq j_0} \frac{1}{a_j}\right).$$

Now



$$\prod_{j=0}^{n-1} a_j = |z^n - 1| \leq 2,$$

while

$$\prod_{j \neq j_0} a_j = \left| \frac{z^n - 1}{z - \omega_{j_0}} \right| = \left| \sum_{\ell=0}^{n-1} z^{n-1-\ell} \omega_{j_0}^\ell \right| \leq n,$$

with the quotient interpreted by continuity when  $z = \omega_{j_0}$ . Hence

$$(a_{j_0} + \eta) \prod_{j \neq j_0} a_j \leq 2 + n\eta.$$

It remains to estimate the inverse distances. Since  $j_0$  is a nearest grid point, the grid points at cyclic distance  $k$  from  $j_0$  have angular distance at least  $(2k-1)\pi/n$  from  $t$ . Using

$$2 \sin(x/2) \geq \frac{2x}{\pi}, \quad 0 \leq x \leq \pi,$$

we obtain

$$\sum_{j \neq j_0} \frac{1}{a_j} \leq Cn \sum_{k=1}^n \frac{1}{k} \leq Cn \log(en).$$

Combining these estimates and maximizing over  $z \in \mathbb{T}$  proves the lemma.

□ Fix  $\alpha > 2$ . Choose  $c_\alpha > 0$  sufficiently small that

$$2e^{2C_\alpha} < \alpha.$$

Set

$$\eta_n := \frac{c_\alpha}{n \log n}.$$

Lemma 3 gives, for all sufficiently large  $n$ ,

$$D_n \leq \left( 2 + \frac{c_\alpha}{\log n} \right) \exp \left( C c_\alpha \frac{\log(en)}{\log n} \right) < \alpha.$$

Consider the  $n$  disjoint arcs of angular half-width  $\eta_n$  centered at the regular  $n$ -gon points. The probability that the  $n$  labelled random points occupy these arcs with exactly one point in each is

$$n! \left( \frac{\eta_n}{\pi} \right)^n = n! \left( \frac{c_\alpha}{\pi n \log n} \right)^n.$$

On this event the roots may be relabelled so that Lemma 3 applies. Thus

$$\mathbb{P}(D_n < \alpha) \geq n! \left( \frac{c_\alpha}{\pi n \log n} \right)^n.$$

Using  $n! \geq (n/e)^n$ ,

$$\mathbb{P}(D_n < \alpha) \geq \left( \frac{c_\alpha}{e\pi \log n} \right)^n = \exp(-n \log \log n - O_\alpha(n)).$$

3.5 The actual probabilistic scale A known theorem for this precise random-polynomial model gives a sharper description on the scale on which  $D_n$  fluctuates. For

$$P_N(z) = \prod_{k=1}^N (z - z_k)^{m_k}, \quad s_N^2 = \sum_{k=1}^N m_k^2,$$

the theorem assumes

$$\sum_{k=1}^N \exp\left(-\varepsilon \frac{s_N}{m_k}\right) \rightarrow 0 \quad (\varepsilon > 0)$$

and concludes that

$$\frac{1}{s_N} \log \max_{|z|=1} |P_N(z)|^2 \xrightarrow{d} I^*,$$

where  $I^* > 0$  almost surely and is obtained from a Brownian bridge. Here  $m_k = 1$ , so  $s_N = \sqrt{N}$ , and the condition becomes

$$N e^{-\varepsilon \sqrt{N}} \rightarrow 0.$$

It is therefore satisfied, giving

$$\frac{2 \log D_n}{\sqrt{n}} \xrightarrow{d} I^*.$$

This is the theorem of Tucci and Whiting, and its hypotheses match the present model exactly. arXiv+1 This external theorem is not needed for the preceding superpolynomial fixed- $\alpha$  estimate.

1. The upper-edge asymptotic

We now fix  $n \geq 2$  and let

$$\alpha = 2^n(1 - \delta), \quad \delta \downarrow 0.$$

4.1 Reduction by rotation Because  $D_n$  is unchanged when all roots are multiplied by the same unit complex number, define

$$x_1 := 0, \quad x_j := \text{Arg}(Z_j \overline{Z_1}) \in (-\pi, \pi], \quad 2 \leq j \leq n.$$

The torus transformation

$$(\Theta_1, \dots, \Theta_n) \mapsto (\Theta_1, \Theta_2 - \Theta_1, \dots, \Theta_n - \Theta_1)$$

preserves Haar measure. Hence

$$x_2, \dots, x_n$$

are independent and uniform on  $(-\pi, \pi]$ , independently of the discarded global rotation. Set  $x = (x_2, \dots, x_n) \in \mathbb{R}^{n-1}$ .

4.2 Localization near a coincident configuration Suppose

$$D_n \geq 2^n(1 - \delta).$$

Then for some  $z \in \mathbb{T}$ ,

$$\prod_{j=1}^n \frac{|z - Z_j|}{2} \geq 1 - \delta.$$

Every factor belongs to  $[0, 1]$ . Therefore each factor is itself at least  $1 - \delta$ . Let  $-e^{ic}$  denote  $z$ , so that  $e^{ic}$  is its antipode. If  $d_j \in [0, \pi]$  is the circular angular distance between  $Z_j$  and  $e^{ic}$ , then

$$\frac{|z - Z_j|}{2} = \cos \frac{d_j}{2}.$$

Thus

$$\cos \frac{d_j}{2} \geq 1 - \delta.$$

Using, for  $0 \leq y \leq \pi/2$ ,

$$1 - \cos y \geq \frac{2y^2}{\pi^2},$$

we obtain

$$d_j = O(\sqrt{\delta}).$$

All roots therefore lie in an arc of length  $O(\sqrt{\delta})$ . In particular,

$$|x| = O_n(\sqrt{\delta}).$$

This also shows that, for sufficiently small  $\delta$ , there is no ambiguity from the choice of angular lifts.

4.3 Quadratic approximation For  $|u| < \pi$ , define

$$h(u) := -\log \cos \frac{u}{2}.$$

Near zero,

$$h(u) = \frac{u^2}{8} + O(u^4).$$

For  $x_1 = 0$  and  $x = (x_2, \dots, x_n)$  sufficiently small,

$$\frac{D_n}{2^n} = \max_{c \in \mathbb{R}} \prod_{j=1}^n \cos \frac{x_j - c}{2}.$$

Hence

$$\Phi(x) := -\log \frac{D_n}{2^n} = \min_{c \in \mathbb{R}} \sum_{j=1}^n h(x_j - c).$$

Let

$$\bar{x} := \frac{1}{n} \sum_{j=1}^n x_j = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{j=2}^n x_j$$

and define

$$Q(x) := \min_{c \in \mathbb{R}} \sum_{j=1}^n (x_j - c)^2 = \sum_{j=1}^n (x_j - \bar{x})^2.$$

The minimizing  $c$  for the function involving  $h$  lies between the smallest and largest  $x_j$ , because  $h'$  is odd and strictly increasing near zero. It is therefore  $O(|x|)$ . The Taylor expansion of  $h$ , evaluated at this minimizer and at  $c = \bar{x}$ , gives the two-sided estimate

$$\Phi(x) = \frac{1}{8}Q(x) + O_n(|x|^4).$$

Since  $Q$  is positive definite on the variables  $x_2, \dots, x_n$ , and its smallest eigenvalue is  $1/n$ , we have

$$|x|^2 \leq nQ(x).$$

Consequently the remainder may equivalently be written

$$\Phi(x) = \frac{1}{8}Q(x) + O_n(Q(x)^2).$$

4.4 The relevant ellipsoid Writing  $m = n - 1$ , one has

$$Q(x) = \sum_{j=2}^n x_j^2 - \frac{1}{n} \left( \sum_{j=2}^n x_j \right)^2 = x^\top A x,$$

where

$$A = I_m - \frac{1}{n} J_m$$

and  $J_m$  is the all-ones matrix. The eigenvalues of  $A$  are

1, with multiplicity  $m - 1$ ;

$1/n$ , in the direction  $(1, \dots, 1)$ .

Therefore

$$\det A = \frac{1}{n}.$$

The event in question is

$$\Phi(x) \leq -\log(1 - \delta) = \delta + O(\delta^2).$$

The localization already proved gives  $Q(x) = O_n(\delta)$ . Substituting this into the quadratic approximation shows that there is  $C_n < \infty$  such that, for all sufficiently small  $\delta$ ,

$$\{Q(x) \leq 8\delta - C_n\delta^2\} \subseteq \left\{ \frac{D_n}{2^n} \geq 1 - \delta \right\} \subseteq \{Q(x) \leq 8\delta + C_n\delta^2\}.$$

Thus the desired probability is the normalized volume of an ellipsoid, up to relative error  $O_n(\delta)$ . Let

$$v_m = \frac{\pi^{m/2}}{\Gamma(m/2 + 1)}$$

be the volume of the Euclidean unit ball in  $\mathbb{R}^m$ . Then

$$\text{vol}\{x : x^\top A x \leq 8\delta\} = \frac{v_m (8\delta)^{m/2}}{\sqrt{\det A}} = \sqrt{n} v_m (8\delta)^{m/2}.$$

Because the relative-angle vector is uniform with density  $(2\pi)^{-m}$ ,

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{P}(D_n \geq 2^n(1 - \delta)) &= \frac{\sqrt{n} v_m 8^{m/2}}{(2\pi)^m} \delta^{m/2} (1 + O_n(\delta)) \\ &= \frac{\sqrt{n}}{\Gamma(m/2 + 1)} \left(\frac{2}{\pi}\right)^{m/2} \delta^{m/2} (1 + O_n(\delta)). \end{aligned}$$

Since  $m = n - 1$ , this is exactly

$$\mathbb{P}(D_n \geq 2^n(1 - \delta)) = \frac{\sqrt{n}}{\Gamma(\frac{n+1}{2})} \left(\frac{2}{\pi}\right)^{\frac{n-1}{2}} \delta^{\frac{n-1}{2}} (1 + O_n(\delta)).$$

This proves part *b*.

4.5 The exact endpoint Every factor  $|z - Z_j|$  is at most 2. Therefore  $D_n = 2^n$  can hold only if there is some  $z \in \mathbb{T}$  such that

$$|z - Z_j| = 2$$

for every  $j$ . This is equivalent to

$$Z_1 = \cdots = Z_n = -z.$$

Conversely, coincident roots do give  $D_n = 2^n$ . Since the  $Z_j$  are independent and have nonatomic distributions,

$$\mathbb{P}(Z_1 = \cdots = Z_n) = 0,$$

so

$$\mathbb{P}(D_n = 2^n) = 0.$$

# 1. Boundary and small- $n$ checks

5.1 Exact calculation for  $n = 2$  Let  $\Delta \in [0, \pi]$  be the smaller angular separation of the two roots. Since the angular difference is uniform,  $\Delta$  is uniform on  $[0, \pi]$ . After rotating the roots to  $e^{\pm i\Delta/2}$ ,

$$\begin{aligned} D_2 &= \max_t |e^{it} - e^{i\Delta/2}| |e^{it} - e^{-i\Delta/2}| \\ &= 2 \max_t |\cos(\Delta/2) - \cos t| \\ &= 2(1 + \cos(\Delta/2)) \\ &= 4 \cos^2(\Delta/4). \end{aligned}$$

Hence, for  $2 \leq \alpha \leq 4$ ,

$$\mathbb{P}(D_2 \geq \alpha) = \frac{4}{\pi} \arccos\left(\frac{\sqrt{\alpha}}{2}\right).$$

As  $\alpha \uparrow 4$ ,

$$\mathbb{P}(D_2 \geq \alpha) \sim \frac{2}{\pi} \sqrt{4 - \alpha}.$$

Our general formula gives

$$\kappa_2 = \frac{\sqrt{2}}{\Gamma(3/2)} \left(\frac{2}{\pi}\right)^{1/2} = \frac{4}{\pi},$$

and, since  $\delta = (4 - \alpha)/4$ ,

$$\kappa_2 \delta^{1/2} = \frac{4}{\pi} \frac{\sqrt{4 - \alpha}}{2} = \frac{2}{\pi} \sqrt{4 - \alpha},$$

in exact agreement. 5.2 The first higher-dimensional case For  $n = 3$ ,

$$\kappa_3 = \frac{\sqrt{3}}{\Gamma(2)} \frac{2}{\pi} = \frac{2\sqrt{3}}{\pi}.$$

Thus

$$\mathbb{P}(D_3 \geq 8(1 - \delta)) = \frac{2\sqrt{3}}{\pi} \delta + O(\delta^2).$$

The linear power is consistent with the fact that, after quotienting out global rotation, two independent relative angles must fall into a two-dimensional ellipsoid of radius  $O(\sqrt{\delta})$ .

1. Why the hypotheses matter

The independence assumption is essential. Let  $U$  be uniform and set

$$Z_j = e^{i(U+2\pi j/n)}, \quad 0 \leq j < n.$$

Each  $Z_j$  is individually uniform, but the points are dependent. Their polynomial is

$$P_n(z) = z^n - e^{inU},$$

so

$$D_n = 2$$

identically. Thus, for every fixed  $\alpha > 2$ ,

$$\mathbb{P}(D_n \geq \alpha) = 0,$$

the opposite of the independent result. Uniformity is also essential. If the  $Z_j$  are independent but all have the degenerate distribution  $Z_j = 1$ , then

$$D_n = 2^n$$

identically. In particular, both the  $\sqrt{n}$ -scale law and the upper-edge asymptotic fail. Finally,  $n \geq 2$  is relevant at the endpoint. For  $n = 1$ ,

$$D_1 = 2$$

deterministically, whereas for every  $n \geq 2$  the event  $D_n = 2^n$  has probability zero.

Final answer For every fixed  $\alpha > 2$ ,

$$\boxed{\mathbb{P}(D_n \geq \alpha) = 1 - O_{\alpha,A}(n^{-A}) \quad \text{for every } A > 0,}$$

with the explicit complementary construction

$$\mathbb{P}(D_n < \alpha) \geq \exp(-n \log \log n - O_\alpha(n)).$$

The typical size is  $D_n = \exp(\Theta_{\text{law}}(\sqrt{n}))$ . For fixed  $n$  and  $\alpha \uparrow 2^n$ ,

$$\boxed{\mathbb{P}(D_n \geq \alpha) \sim \frac{\sqrt{n}}{\Gamma(\frac{n+1}{2})} \left(\frac{2}{\pi}\right)^{\frac{n-1}{2}} \left(\frac{2^n - \alpha}{2^n}\right)^{\frac{n-1}{2}}.}$$

**Formal verification.** Lean source; online type-check.



## 15 Question Q803

**Informal verdict.** A — Complete solution, with high confidence.

**Lean coverage.** Lean proves the exact finite-approximation characterization of empty interior for achievement sets, including compactness, the decreasing longest-component lengths, their attained limit, and the equivalence with  $\Delta_n$  tending to zero.

### 15.1 Audited informal answer

Q803 — Exact finite-stage characterization

1. Faithful restatement

Let

$$a_1 \geq a_2 \geq \cdots > 0, \quad \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} a_n < \infty.$$

Define the set of all subsums

$$\Sigma(a) := \left\{ \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \varepsilon_n a_n : \varepsilon_n \in \{0, 1\} \right\}.$$

Finite extracted series correspond to eventually-zero sequences  $(\varepsilon_n)$ . Including or excluding the empty subseries, whose sum is 0, does not affect the interior. The question asks for a characterization of those sequences for which

$$\text{int } \Sigma(a) = \emptyset.$$

This is exactly the complete Q803 statement in the PDF; there are no subparts, footnotes, or further qualifications. In standard French usage, “décroissante” means nonincreasing. There is no apparent typo or substantive ambiguity. Luc Pommeret

1. The exact characterization

For  $n \geq 0$ , put

$$r_n := \sum_{k>n} a_k, \quad r_0 = \sum_{k \geq 1} a_k,$$

and let

$$F_n := \left\{ \sum_{k=1}^n \varepsilon_k a_k : \varepsilon_k \in \{0, 1\} \right\}$$

be the finite set of subsums of the first  $n$  terms. Write its distinct elements in increasing order:

$$F_n = \{f_{n,0} < f_{n,1} < \cdots < f_{n,m_n}\}.$$

Partition this ordered set into maximal consecutive blocks

$$f_{n,p}, f_{n,p+1}, \dots, f_{n,q}$$

such that

$$f_{n,j+1} - f_{n,j} \leq r_n \quad (p \leq j < q).$$

Thus a new block begins whenever a consecutive gap is strictly larger than  $r_n$ . Define

$$\Delta_n := \max_{\text{such maximal blocks } [p,q]} (f_{n,q} - f_{n,p}).$$

Theorem The sequence

$$\ell_n := r_n + \Delta_n$$

is nonincreasing and converges. Moreover,

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \ell_n = \max \{ b - a : [a, b] \subseteq \Sigma(a) \}.$$

In particular, because  $r_n \rightarrow 0$ ,

$$\text{int } \Sigma(a) = \emptyset \iff \lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \Delta_n = 0.$$

Equivalently,

$$\text{int } \Sigma(a) = \emptyset \iff \forall \varepsilon > 0 \exists n \quad r_n + \Delta_n < \varepsilon.$$

Thus the answer is: the subsum set has empty interior precisely when every  $r_n$ -connected cluster of finite subsums of the first  $n$  terms has diameter tending to zero. This finite-chain criterion is essentially the analytic characterization recorded as Proposition 2.8 in the achievement-set literature. arXiv+1

1. Proof of the characterization

3.1. Compactness of the subsum set Let

$$\Omega := \{0, 1\}^{\mathbb{N}}$$

and define

$$\pi : \Omega \longrightarrow \mathbb{R}, \quad \pi(\varepsilon) := \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \varepsilon_n a_n.$$

Equip  $\Omega$  with the usual product metric, for example

$$d(\varepsilon, \eta) = \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} 2^{-n} |\varepsilon_n - \eta_n|.$$

If  $\varepsilon_k = \eta_k$  for  $1 \leq k \leq N$ , then

$$|\pi(\varepsilon) - \pi(\eta)| \leq \sum_{k>N} a_k = r_N.$$

Since  $r_N \rightarrow 0$ , the map  $\pi$  is uniformly continuous. The space  $\Omega$  is compact: from any sequence in  $\Omega$ , one first extracts a subsequence on which the first coordinate is constant, then a further subsequence on which the second coordinate is constant, and so on; the diagonal subsequence converges. Hence

$$\Sigma(a) = \pi(\Omega)$$

is compact.

3.2. Canonical finite approximations Define

$$I_n := F_n + [0, r_n] = \bigcup_{f \in F_n} [f, f + r_n].$$

Each  $I_n$  is a finite union of closed bounded intervals. We claim that

$$I_{n+1} \subseteq I_n.$$

Indeed,

$$F_{n+1} = F_n \cup (F_n + a_{n+1}), \quad r_n = a_{n+1} + r_{n+1}.$$

For each  $f \in F_n$ , the two child intervals at level  $n+1$  are

$$[f, f + r_{n+1}]$$

and

$$[f + a_{n+1}, f + a_{n+1} + r_{n+1}] = [f + a_{n+1}, f + r_n].$$

Both are contained in  $[f, f + r_n]$ . Therefore  $I_{n+1} \subseteq I_n$ . We now prove the fundamental identity

$$\Sigma(a) = \bigcap_{n=0}^{\infty} I_n.$$

The inclusion  $\Sigma(a) \subseteq I_n$  is immediate: if

$$x = \sum_{k=1}^{\infty} \varepsilon_k a_k,$$

then

$$x = \underbrace{\sum_{k=1}^n \varepsilon_k a_k}_{\in F_n} + \underbrace{\sum_{k>n} \varepsilon_k a_k}_{\in [0, r_n]}.$$

Conversely, suppose  $x \in I_n$  for every  $n$ . For each  $n$ , choose a binary word

$$w^{(n)} = (\varepsilon_1^{(n)}, \dots, \varepsilon_n^{(n)})$$

such that

$$0 \leq x - \sum_{k=1}^n \varepsilon_k^{(n)} a_k \leq r_n.$$

Extend  $w^{(n)}$  by zeros to an element  $\tilde{w}^{(n)} \in \Omega$ . By the diagonal compactness argument, a subsequence

$$\tilde{w}^{(n_j)}$$

converges to some  $\varepsilon \in \Omega$ . Continuity of  $\pi$  gives

$$\pi(\tilde{w}^{(n_j)}) \longrightarrow \pi(\varepsilon).$$

But

$$\left| x - \pi(\tilde{w}^{(n_j)}) \right| \leq r_{n_j} \longrightarrow 0,$$

so  $\pi(\varepsilon) = x$ . Hence  $x \in \Sigma(a)$ .

3.3. A lemma on decreasing finite unions of intervals We use the following general fact. Lemma Let

$$W_0 \supseteq W_1 \supseteq W_2 \supseteq \cdots$$

be compact subsets of  $\mathbb{R}$ , each of which is a finite union of closed intervals. Let  $L_n$  be the maximum length of a connected component of  $W_n$ . Then  $L_n$  is nonincreasing, and if

$$W := \bigcap_{n=0}^{\infty} W_n, \quad L := \lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} L_n,$$

then

$$L = \max\{b - a : [a, b] \subseteq W\}.$$

Proof Every component of  $W_{n+1}$ , being connected and contained in  $W_n$ , lies in a single component of  $W_n$ . Therefore

$$L_{n+1} \leq L_n.$$

Suppose first that  $[a, b] \subseteq W$ . For every  $n$ , the connected interval  $[a, b]$  lies in one component of  $W_n$ . Hence

$$b - a \leq L_n$$

for every  $n$ , and therefore

$$b - a \leq L.$$

It remains to construct an interval of length  $L$  in  $W$ . For each  $n$ , choose the leftmost component

$$C_n = [u_n, v_n]$$

of  $W_n$  whose length is  $L_n$ . All pairs  $(u_n, v_n)$  lie in a fixed compact rectangle. Passing to a subsequence,

$$u_{n_j} \longrightarrow u, \quad v_{n_j} \longrightarrow v.$$

Since

$$v_{n_j} - u_{n_j} = L_{n_j} \longrightarrow L,$$

we have

$$v - u = L.$$

Fix  $m$ . For sufficiently large  $j$ ,  $n_j \geq m$ , so

$$C_{n_j} \subseteq W_{n_j} \subseteq W_m.$$

For  $t \in [0, 1]$ , the point

$$x_j(t) := (1 - t)u_{n_j} + tv_{n_j}$$

belongs to  $W_m$ , and

$$x_j(t) \longrightarrow (1 - t)u + tv.$$

Since  $W_m$  is closed,

$$(1 - t)u + tv \in W_m.$$

Thus  $[u, v] \subseteq W_m$  for every  $m$ , and hence

$$[u, v] \subseteq W.$$

Its length is  $L$ .  $\square$

3.4. Computing the components of  $I_n$  Recall

$$I_n = \bigcup_{j=0}^{m_n} [f_{n,j}, f_{n,j} + r_n].$$

Two consecutive intervals overlap or touch exactly when

$$f_{n,j+1} \leq f_{n,j} + r_n,$$

that is,

$$f_{n,j+1} - f_{n,j} \leq r_n.$$

Consequently, if

$$f_{n,p}, \dots, f_{n,q}$$

is one maximal  $r_n$ -connected block, the corresponding component of  $I_n$  is

$$[f_{n,p}, f_{n,q} + r_n],$$

whose length is

$$f_{n,q} - f_{n,p} + r_n.$$

Therefore the maximum component length of  $I_n$  is exactly

$$L_n = r_n + \Delta_n = \ell_n.$$

Applying the preceding lemma to the decreasing sequence  $(I_n)$ , and using

$$\Sigma(a) = \bigcap_n I_n,$$

we obtain

$$\max\{b - a : [a, b] \subseteq \Sigma(a)\} = \lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} (r_n + \Delta_n).$$

Finally,  $r_n \rightarrow 0$ , so

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \Delta_n = \lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} (r_n + \Delta_n).$$

The set  $\Sigma(a)$  has nonempty interior exactly when it contains a nondegenerate interval. This proves

$$\text{int } \Sigma(a) = \emptyset \iff \Delta_n \longrightarrow 0.$$

□

1. Consequence: the empty-interior case is exactly the Cantor-set case

Under the original hypotheses,  $\Sigma(a)$  has no isolated points. Indeed, take

$$x = \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \varepsilon_n a_n \in \Sigma(a).$$

Either infinitely many  $\varepsilon_n$  are 0, in which case one can change a sufficiently far 0 into a 1, or infinitely many are 1, in which case one can change a sufficiently far 1 into a 0. This produces a distinct element of  $\Sigma(a)$  at distance  $a_n \rightarrow 0$  from  $x$ . Thus  $\Sigma(a)$  is compact and perfect. If its interior is empty, it is nowhere dense. Moreover, any connected subset of  $\mathbb{R}$  containing

two distinct points contains the whole interval between them; hence an empty-interior  $\Sigma(a)$  is totally disconnected. Therefore, under the hypotheses of Q803,

$$\boxed{\text{int } \Sigma(a) = \emptyset \iff \Sigma(a) \text{ is a Cantor set.}}$$

1. The classical term-versus-tail regimes

The exact criterion above is needed because comparisons between  $a_n$  and  $r_n$  do not decide the mixed case. They do, however, settle the two extreme regimes. 5.1. If the tail eventually dominates the term Suppose

$$a_n \leq r_n$$

for all  $n > N$ . At such an index  $n$ , for each  $f \in F_{n-1}$ ,

$$[f, f + r_n] \quad \text{and} \quad [f + a_n, f + a_n + r_n]$$

overlap, and their union is

$$[f, f + a_n + r_n] = [f, f + r_{n-1}].$$

Hence

$$I_n = I_{n-1}.$$

It follows that

$$I_n = I_N \quad (n \geq N),$$

and therefore

$$\Sigma(a) = I_N.$$

Thus  $\Sigma(a)$  is a finite union of nondegenerate closed intervals and has nonempty interior. In particular,

$$\boxed{\text{int } \Sigma(a) = \emptyset \implies a_n > r_n \text{ for infinitely many } n.}$$

If  $a_n \leq r_n$  for every  $n$ , then  $I_n = I_0$  for every  $n$ , so

$$\boxed{\Sigma(a) = \left[0, \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} a_n\right].}$$



5.2. If the term eventually dominates the tail Suppose

$$a_n > r_n$$

for all  $n > N$ . Consider the tail achievement set

$$\Sigma_N := \left\{ \sum_{n>N} \varepsilon_n a_n : \varepsilon_n \in \{0, 1\} \right\}.$$

Its natural binary coding is injective. Indeed, if two binary sequences first differ at index  $j > N$ , say  $\varepsilon_j = 1$  and  $\eta_j = 0$ , then

$$\sum_{n>N} (\varepsilon_n - \eta_n) a_n \geq a_j - \sum_{n>j} a_n = a_j - r_j > 0.$$

Thus  $\Sigma_N$  is homeomorphic to the binary Cantor space and in particular contains no interval. Now

$$\Sigma(a) = F_N + \Sigma_N$$

is a finite union of translates of the compact nowhere-dense set  $\Sigma_N$ . Hence it too has empty interior. Therefore

$$\boxed{a_n > r_n \text{ eventually} \implies \text{int } \Sigma(a) = \emptyset.}$$

The converse is false: empty interior can occur even though  $a_n \leq r_n$  infinitely often.

1. Why the mixed case cannot be decided by the signs of  $a_n - r_n$

Consider, for  $0 < q \leq 2/3$ , the strictly decreasing multigeometric sequence

$$a_{2k+1} = 3q^k, \quad a_{2k+2} = 2q^k, \quad k \geq 0.$$

The tail after the first term in the  $k$ -th block is

$$r_{2k+1} = 2q^k + \sum_{j>k} 5q^j = q^k \left( 2 + \frac{5q}{1-q} \right),$$

whereas the tail after the second term is

$$r_{2k+2} = \sum_{j>k} 5q^j = q^k \frac{5q}{1-q}.$$

For both  $q = \frac{1}{5}$  and  $q = \frac{1}{4}$ , one has

$$a_{2k+1} < r_{2k+1}, \quad a_{2k+2} > r_{2k+2}.$$

Thus the complete pattern of inequalities is identical: every odd index is tail-dominated, and every even index is term-dominated. Nevertheless, the corresponding achievement sets have opposite interior behavior.

6.1. The case  $q = \frac{1}{5}$ : empty interior After  $m$  complete blocks there are at most  $4^m$  distinct prefix subsums, because each block contributes one of

$$0, 2, 3, 5$$

times the appropriate power of  $1/5$ . The remaining tail is

$$r_{2m} = \sum_{k=m}^{\infty} 5 \cdot 5^{-k} = \frac{25}{4} 5^{-m}.$$

Thus  $I_{2m}$  is covered by at most  $4^m$  intervals, each of length  $r_{2m}$ . Its largest component therefore has length at most the sum of these lengths:

$$\ell_{2m} \leq 4^m r_{2m} = \frac{25}{4} \left(\frac{4}{5}\right)^m \longrightarrow 0.$$

Since  $(\ell_n)$  is nonincreasing,

$$\ell_n \longrightarrow 0.$$

By the theorem,

$$\boxed{\text{int } \Sigma\left(3, 2; \frac{1}{5}\right) = \emptyset.}$$

6.2. The case  $q = \frac{1}{4}$ : a nondegenerate interval Now let

$$a_{2k+1} = \frac{3}{4^k}, \quad a_{2k+2} = \frac{2}{4^k}.$$

A complete block contributes a digit in

$$D := \{0, 2, 3, 5\}.$$

After  $m$  blocks, the finite block subsums are

$$B_m = \left\{ \sum_{k=0}^{m-1} \frac{d_k}{4^k} : d_k \in D \right\}.$$

Scale them by  $4^{m-1}$ :

$$A_m := 4^{m-1} B_m = \left\{ \sum_{k=0}^{m-1} d_k 4^{m-1-k} : d_k \in D \right\} \subseteq \mathbb{Z}.$$

We claim that  $A_m$  contains every integer in the interval

$$[\alpha_m, \beta_m], \quad \alpha_m := \frac{2(4^m - 1)}{3}, \quad \beta_m := 4^m - 1.$$

For  $m = 1$ ,

$$A_1 = D$$

contains 2, 3, and indeed

$$\alpha_1 = 2, \quad \beta_1 = 3.$$

Suppose the claim holds for  $m$ . Since

$$A_{m+1} = 4A_m + D,$$

the set  $A_{m+1}$  contains every integer from

$$4\alpha_m + 2$$

to

$$4\beta_m + 3.$$

To see this, consider residues modulo 4:

residues 2 and 3 are obtained using the digits 2 and 3;

a multiple  $4t$  in the stated range is obtained using digit 0;

a number  $4t + 1$  is written as  $4(t - 1) + 5$ .

The endpoint recurrences are

$$4\alpha_m + 2 = \alpha_{m+1}, \quad 4\beta_m + 3 = \beta_{m+1}.$$

This proves the claim. The tail after  $m$  blocks is

$$r_{2m} = \sum_{k=m}^{\infty} \frac{5}{4^k} = \frac{20}{3} 4^{-m}.$$

After multiplying by  $4^{m-1}$ , its length becomes

$$4^{m-1}r_{2m} = \frac{5}{3}.$$

Since  $A_m$  contains every consecutive integer from  $\alpha_m$  through  $\beta_m$ , the intervals of length  $5/3$  starting at these integers overlap and cover

$$\left[ \alpha_m, \beta_m + \frac{5}{3} \right].$$

Scaling back,  $I_{2m}$  contains

$$J_m = \left[ \frac{\alpha_m}{4^{m-1}}, \frac{\beta_m + 5/3}{4^{m-1}} \right].$$

The endpoints simplify to

$$J_m = \left[ \frac{8}{3} (1 - 4^{-m}), 4 + \frac{8}{3} 4^{-m} \right].$$

Hence

$$\left[ \frac{8}{3}, 4 \right] \subseteq J_m \subseteq I_{2m}$$

for every  $m$ . Because the even-indexed approximants are cofinal in the decreasing family  $(I_n)$ ,

$$\bigcap_{m=1}^{\infty} I_{2m} = \bigcap_{n=1}^{\infty} I_n = \Sigma(a).$$

Therefore

$$\boxed{\left[ \frac{8}{3}, 4 \right] \subseteq \Sigma\left(3, 2; \frac{1}{4}\right)}.$$

In particular,

$$\boxed{\text{int } \Sigma\left(3, 2; \frac{1}{4}\right) \neq \emptyset}.$$

Thus even the complete pattern of inequalities

$$a_n \leq r_n$$

does not characterize empty interior.

# 1. Boundary tests

## 7.1. Geometric sequences Let

$$a_n = q^{n-1}, \quad 0 < q < 1.$$

Then

$$r_n = \frac{q^n}{1-q}.$$

If  $q < \frac{1}{2}$ , then

$$a_n > r_n$$

for every  $n$ , so the achievement set has empty interior. If  $q \geq \frac{1}{2}$ , then

$$a_n \leq r_n$$

for every  $n$ , and therefore

$$\Sigma(a) = \left[0, \frac{1}{1-q}\right].$$

At the boundary  $q = \frac{1}{2}$ , equality  $a_n = r_n$  holds at every index, and

$$\Sigma(a) = [0, 2].$$

This shows that the strictness of the tail comparison matters.

7.2. Finite support If only finitely many  $a_n$  are nonzero, then for sufficiently large  $n$ ,

$$r_n = 0, \quad I_n = F_n.$$

The achievement set is finite and therefore has empty interior. The original assumption  $a_n > 0$  for every  $n$  excludes this degenerate case.

# 1. A useful easily checked sufficient condition

Since  $I_n$  is a union of at most  $2^n$  intervals of length  $r_n$ , its largest component satisfies

$$\ell_n \leq 2^n r_n.$$

Consequently,

$$\boxed{\liminf_{n \rightarrow \infty} 2^n r_n = 0 \implies \text{int } \Sigma(a) = \emptyset.}$$

More sharply, one may replace  $2^n$  by the actual number  $|F_n|$ :

$$\liminf_{n \rightarrow \infty} |F_n| r_n = 0 \implies \text{int } \Sigma(a) = \emptyset.$$

These are sufficient, not necessary, conditions.

### 1. Exact finite-stage computation

For rational input data and exactly known tails, the numbers

$$\ell_n = r_n + \Delta_n$$

can be computed without numerical tolerances. `PythonExécuteur` from `fractions` import `Fraction` from `collections.abc` import `Sequence`, `Iterator`

`def interval_moduli( terms: Sequence[Fraction], tails: Sequence[Fraction], ) -> Iterator[tuple[int, Fraction]]:` """ Compute `ell_n` = the largest component length of

`I_n = F_n + [0, r_n],`

where: `terms[n-1] = a_n`, `tails[n] = r_n = sum_{k>n} a_k`.

The array `tails` must have length `lenterms + 1`. Use `Fraction` values to make all comparisons exact. """ `terms = [Fraction(x) for x in terms]` `tails = [Fraction(x) for x in tails]`

`if lentails != lenterms + 1: raise ValueError("tails must have length lenterms + 1")`

`finite_sums = {Fraction0}`

`for n, a_n in enumerate(terms, start = 1): old_sums = tuple(finite_sums)`  
`finite_sums.update(x + a_n for x in old_sums)`

`values = sorted(finite_sums)` `r_n = tails[n]`

`left = values[0]` `previous = values[0]` `best = Fraction0`

`for x in values[1:]: if x - previous <= r_n: previous = x else: best = max(best, previous - left + r_n)` `left = previous = x`

`best = max(best, previous - left + r_n)` `yield n, best` At stage  $n$ , the worst-case number of distinct finite subsums is  $2^n$ , so the straightforward method is exponential. Finite computations can reveal candidate behavior, but a proof of empty interior still requires a rigorous estimate forcing  $\ell_n \rightarrow 0$ , while a proof of nonempty interior requires a persistent positive lower bound or an explicitly exhibited common interval.

## 1. Hypothesis and topology audit

**Topological assumptions** Everything takes place in  $\mathbb{R}$  with its usual Euclidean topology. It is Hausdorff, second-countable, complete, and metrizable. Connected subsets of  $\mathbb{R}$  are intervals; this is the only order-topological fact used about connectedness. **Compactness** Compactness of  $\{0, 1\}^{\mathbb{N}}$  was used only in its countable metric form and was proved by a diagonal subsequence argument. Compactness of bounded endpoint sequences was used through Bolzano–Weierstrass. No nets, filters, or general uncountable Tychonoff theorem are needed. **Countability** The proof is entirely sequential and depends on the sequence being indexed by  $\mathbb{N}$ . There are no uncountable families of subsums or covers. **Choice** Within ordinary ZFC, no substantial form of the axiom of choice is used. Choices from finite sets may be made canonically—for example, by taking the lexicographically least coding word or the leftmost longest component. No uncountable choice is involved. **Baire category and measure** The main characterization does not use the Baire category theorem or Lebesgue measure. The finite-union argument in the eventually fast regime uses only the elementary fact that a finite union of closed nowhere-dense sets is nowhere dense. **Necessity of the stated sequence hypotheses**

Summability is essential to this formulation. It gives  $r_n \rightarrow 0$ , convergence of every subseries, uniform convergence of the coding map, and compactness of  $\Sigma(a)$ . For a divergent positive series, the set of finite subsums is unbounded and infinite subseries may diverge.

Monotonicity is not needed for the exact criterion. The proof works for every summable nonnegative sequence in its given order. Since the subsum set is invariant under permutations, monotonicity merely gives a canonical ordering.

Strict positivity can be weakened to nonnegativity. Zero terms may simply be deleted. Strict positivity is used when asserting that an infinite achievement set has no isolated points.

Even signed absolutely summable sequences reduce to the positive case. If  $\sum |a_n| < \infty$ , then

$$\Sigma(a) = \sum_{a_n < 0} a_n + \Sigma(|a_n|),$$

because at a negative coordinate selecting  $a_n$  is equivalent, after translation, to not selecting  $|a_n|$ . Thus signed achievement sets are translates of positive ones and have the same interior behavior.

## 1. Final classification

Define  $r_n$ ,  $F_n$ , and  $\Delta_n$  as above. Then

$$\text{int } \Sigma(a) = \emptyset \iff \lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \Delta_n = 0,$$

where  $\Delta_n$  is the largest span of a maximal chain of consecutive  $n$ -term subsums whose successive gaps are at most the remaining tail  $r_n$ . More strongly,

$$\max\{|J| : J \subseteq \Sigma(a) \text{ is an interval}\} = \lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} (r_n + \Delta_n).$$

This is a complete literal answer to Q803. It is, however, an exponentially complicated finite-stage criterion rather than a simple condition involving only the individual comparisons  $a_n$  versus  $r_n$ . Current surveys distinguish this exact analytic characterization from the still-unresolved search for an easy structural test separating Cantor sets from Cantorvals in the mixed regime. arXiv+1

**Formal verification.** Lean source; online type-check.

## 16 Question Q830

**Informal verdict.** **A — Complete solution**, with **high confidence** under the response's explicit convention that a solution is a  $C^2$  function on an open interval and that  $yy'' = f$  means  $y(x)y''(x) = f(x)$ .

**Lean coverage (partial).** Lean proves the complete classification of maximal classical solutions of  $y \ y\_second = 1$ , the energy law and explicit inverse-integral formula, plus strong necessary conditions, an integral identity, the zero-forcing classification, and a smooth nonuniqueness example for general forcing. Local existence at simple or tangent zeros and endpoint asymptotics remain under continuation.

### 16.1 Audited informal answer

Q830

1. Faithful restatement and interpretation

The PDF asks:

*a* Determine the maximal solutions of  $y \ y'' = 1$ . *b* Given a map  $f : \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ , what can be said about the solutions of  $y \ y'' = f$ ?



There is no further hypothesis, footnote, or contextual qualification attached to Q830. The printed equation in part *b* is  $y y'' = f$ , not  $y y'' = f(y)$ ; I therefore read it pointwise as

$$y(x)y''(x) = f(x).$$

Part *b* genuinely leaves unspecified the domain and regularity of a “solution,” whether global or local solutions are sought, and what kind of classification is expected. Luc Pommeret+1 I use the following natural convention. A classical solution on an open interval  $I$  is a function  $y \in C^2(I, \mathbb{R})$  satisfying the equation at every point of  $I$ . A solution is maximal if it is not the restriction of a classical solution to a strictly larger open interval.

1. Part *a*: complete classification of the maximal solutions

Define

$$\Psi(q) := \sqrt{2} \int_0^q e^{s^2} ds = \sqrt{\frac{\pi}{2}} \operatorname{erfi}(q), \quad q \in \mathbb{R}.$$

The function  $\Psi$  is odd,  $C^\infty$ , strictly increasing, and maps  $\mathbb{R}$  bijectively onto  $\mathbb{R}$ . Theorem 1 The maximal classical solutions of

$$y y'' = 1$$

are precisely the functions parametrized by

$$\boxed{x = \tau + a\Psi(q), \quad y = \varepsilon a e^{q^2}, \quad q \in \mathbb{R},}$$

where

$$a > 0, \quad \tau \in \mathbb{R}, \quad \varepsilon \in \{-1, 1\}.$$

Equivalently,

$$\boxed{y(x) = \varepsilon a \exp\left(\Psi^{-1}\left(\frac{x - \tau}{a}\right)^2\right), \quad x \in \mathbb{R}.}$$

Every maximal solution is therefore defined on all of  $\mathbb{R}$ . Its sign is constant, and  $|y|$  has a unique minimum  $a$ , attained at  $x = \tau$ . Proof Let  $y \in C^2(I)$  solve  $yy'' = 1$  on an interval  $I$ . Since the left-hand side would vanish wherever  $y = 0$ , one has

$$y(x) \neq 0 \quad (x \in I).$$

Thus  $y$  has a constant sign. Put

$$\varepsilon = \operatorname{sgn} y, \quad u = \varepsilon y = |y| > 0.$$

Because  $y = \varepsilon u$  and  $y'' = \varepsilon u''$ ,

$$u u'' = 1.$$

Multiplication by  $u'/u$ , or direct differentiation, gives the first integral

$$\frac{d}{dx} \left( \frac{1}{2} u'^2 - \log u \right) = u' \left( u'' - \frac{1}{u} \right) = 0.$$

Hence

$$\frac{1}{2} u'^2 - \log u = C$$

for some constant  $C$ . Set

$$a = e^{-C} > 0.$$

Then

$$u'^2 = 2 \log \frac{u}{a}.$$

In particular,

$$u \geq a.$$

Define

$$q = \frac{u'}{\sqrt{2}}.$$

The first integral becomes

$$u = a e^{q^2}.$$

Moreover,

$$q' = \frac{u''}{\sqrt{2}} = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}u}.$$

Consequently,

$$\frac{d}{dx}(a\Psi(q)) = a\sqrt{2}e^{q^2}q' = a\sqrt{2}\frac{u}{a}\frac{1}{\sqrt{2}u} = 1.$$

Therefore there exists  $\tau \in \mathbb{R}$  such that

$$x = \tau + a\Psi(q).$$

Since  $y = \varepsilon u$ , this gives

$$y = \varepsilon a e^{q^2}.$$

Conversely, let

$$x = \tau + a\Psi(q), \quad y = \varepsilon a e^{q^2}.$$

Because

$$\frac{dx}{dq} = a\sqrt{2}e^{q^2} > 0,$$

$q$  is a smooth function of  $x$ . Differentiating,

$$y' = \frac{2\varepsilon a q e^{q^2}}{a\sqrt{2}e^{q^2}} = \varepsilon\sqrt{2}q,$$

and hence

$$y'' = \varepsilon\sqrt{2}\frac{dq}{dx} = \frac{\varepsilon}{ae^{q^2}} = \frac{1}{y}.$$

Thus  $yy'' = 1$ . Finally,  $\Psi(q) \rightarrow \pm\infty$  as  $q \rightarrow \pm\infty$ , so the parametrization gives a solution on all of  $\mathbb{R}$ . Every local solution obtained above is a restriction of one of these entire solutions. Therefore these and only these are maximal.  $\square$  Initial-value parametrization For arbitrary data

$$y(x_0) = y_0 \neq 0, \quad y'(x_0) = v_0,$$

the parameters are

$$\varepsilon = \operatorname{sgn} y_0, \quad q_0 = \frac{\varepsilon v_0}{\sqrt{2}},$$

$$a = |y_0|e^{-v_0^2/2}, \quad \tau = x_0 - a\Psi(q_0).$$

Thus every admissible initial condition determines exactly one maximal solution.

1. Part *b*: general classical-solution theory

Because  $f$  is allowed to be completely arbitrary, no universal explicit formula can exist. Indeed, for every prescribed  $Y \in C^2(I)$ , choosing

$$f = YY''$$

makes  $Y$  a solution. Thus arbitrary growth, oscillation, zero sets, and flat behavior can be encoded in  $f$ . There is nevertheless a precise structural theory. It consists of:

- ordinary existence and uniqueness wherever  $y \neq 0$ ;
- exact compatibility conditions at zeros;
- an integral identity controlling consecutive zeros;
- a sharp classification of finite singular endpoints when  $f$  has a nonzero limit.

3.1 Immediate necessary conditions Let  $y \in C^2(I)$  satisfy

$$yy'' = f.$$

Then necessarily

$$\boxed{f \in C(I)}$$

because  $f = yy''$  is a product of continuous functions. Moreover,

$$\boxed{y(c) = 0 \implies f(c) = 0.}$$

Thus

$$Z(y) \subseteq Z(f).$$

In particular, if  $f$  is discontinuous on every nonempty open interval—for example  $f = \mathbf{1}_{\mathbb{Q}}$ —then there is no classical solution on any nonempty open interval.

3.2 Regular branches: existence, uniqueness, and continuation Assume now that  $f \in C(I)$ , where  $I$  is an open interval. Theorem 2 Given

$$x_0 \in I, \quad y_0 \neq 0, \quad v_0 \in \mathbb{R},$$

there exists a unique maximal zero-free branch

$$y : J \longrightarrow \mathbb{R}, \quad x_0 \in J \subset I,$$

such that

$$y(x_0) = y_0, \quad y'(x_0) = v_0, \quad yy'' = f.$$

On  $J$ , it satisfies the Volterra equation

$$y(x) = y_0 + v_0(x - x_0) + \int_{x_0}^x (x - t) \frac{f(t)}{y(t)} dt.$$

If a finite endpoint  $c \in I$  of  $J$  exists, then

$$\liminf_{x \rightarrow c, x \in J} |y(x)| = 0.$$

Proof Away from  $y = 0$ , the equation is the first-order system

$$\begin{cases} y' = v, \\ v' = \frac{f(x)}{y}. \end{cases}$$

Near  $(x_0, y_0, v_0)$ , choose a rectangle on which

$$|y| \geq \frac{|y_0|}{2}.$$

On this rectangle the vector field

$$F(x, y, v) = \left( v, \frac{f(x)}{y} \right)$$

is continuous and locally Lipschitz in  $(y, v)$ . The usual contraction argument applied to

$$Y(x) = Y_0 + \int_{x_0}^x F(t, Y(t)) dt$$

gives a unique local solution. Uniqueness allows all local continuations that remain in  $y \neq 0$  to be united into one maximal zero-free branch. Integrating  $y'' = f/y$  twice gives the displayed Volterra equation. Now suppose that  $c \in I$  is a finite endpoint and that

$$\liminf_{x \rightarrow c} |y(x)| > 0.$$

Then  $|y| \geq \delta > 0$  near  $c$ . Since  $f$  is bounded near  $c$ ,

$$|y''| \leq \frac{\sup |f|}{\delta}.$$

Hence  $y'$  has a finite limit at  $c$ , and then  $y$  also has a finite nonzero limit. The local existence theorem at  $c$  extends the branch past  $c$ , contradicting maximality.  $\square$  A zero-free branch need not have a unique maximal classical continuation through a zero; this distinction is essential and will be illustrated below.

3.3 A fundamental integral identity For every classical solution,

$$(yy')' = y'^2 + yy'' = y'^2 + f.$$

Hence, for  $a < b$  in the solution interval,

$$\int_a^b f(x) dx = y(b)y'(b) - y(a)y'(a) - \int_a^b y'(x)^2 dx.$$

Consequences If  $y(a) = y(b) = 0$ , then

$$\int_a^b f(x) dx = - \int_a^b y'(x)^2 dx \leq 0.$$

Equality occurs exactly when  $y \equiv 0$  on  $[a, b]$ , in which case  $f \equiv 0$  there. Thus a nonzero solution cannot have two zeros  $a < b$  unless

$$\int_a^b f < 0.$$

In particular, if  $f \geq 0$ , a solution cannot have two distinct zeros unless it vanishes identically, together with  $f$ , between those zeros. If  $y$  is  $T$ -periodic, then

$$\int_x^{x+T} f(t) dt = - \int_x^{x+T} y'(t)^2 dt \leq 0.$$

#### 1. Exact local analysis at a zero

Let  $c$  be a zero of a classical solution, and write

$$p = y'(c), \quad q = y''(c).$$

Taylor's formula with Peano remainder gives

$$y(c+h) = ph + \frac{1}{2}qh^2 + o(h^2).$$

4.1 Necessary jet conditions Simple zero:  $p \neq 0$  Since  $y''(c+h) \rightarrow q$ ,

$$\frac{f(c+h)}{h} = \frac{y(c+h)}{h} y''(c+h) \longrightarrow pq.$$

Therefore  $f$  is differentiable at  $c$ , and

$$\boxed{f'(c) = y'(c)y''(c) = pq.}$$

Tangential zero:  $p = 0$  Then

$$\frac{f(c+h)}{h^2} = \frac{y(c+h)}{h^2} y''(c+h) \longrightarrow \frac{1}{2}q^2.$$

Hence

$$\boxed{f(c+h) = \frac{1}{2}q^2h^2 + o(h^2).}$$

If  $q \neq 0$ , then  $f$  is positive on both sides of  $c$ , sufficiently close to  $c$ . If  $q = 0$ , necessarily

$$\boxed{f(c+h) = o(h^2).}$$

If zeros of  $y$  accumulate at  $c$ , then necessarily

$$y'(c) = y''(c) = 0.$$

Indeed, a simple or nondegenerate quadratic zero is isolated.

4.2 Complete characterization of simple zeros Theorem 3 Let  $f$  be defined near  $c$ . There exists a local classical solution with

$$y(c) = 0, \quad y'(c) = p \neq 0$$

if and only if

$$\boxed{g(h) := \frac{f(c+h)}{h}}$$

extends continuously to  $h = 0$ . When this condition holds, for every prescribed  $p \neq 0$  there is a unique such local solution, and

$$\boxed{y''(c) = \frac{g(0)}{p}.}$$

Proof Necessity was proved above. For sufficiency, translate  $c$  to 0, so that

$$f(h) = h g(h)$$

with  $g$  continuous. Seek

$$y(h) = h z(h), \quad z(0) = p.$$

The equation is equivalent to

$$y''(h) = \frac{g(h)}{z(h)}.$$

Twice integrating from 0, using  $y(0) = 0$  and  $y'(0) = p$ , gives

$$h z(h) = p h + \int_0^h (h-s) \frac{g(s)}{z(s)} ds,$$

or equivalently

$$z(h) = p + h \int_0^1 (1-r) \frac{g(hr)}{z(hr)} dr.$$

Choose  $\delta > 0$  and consider the complete metric space

$$\mathcal{B} = \left\{ z \in C([- \delta, \delta]) : \|z - p\|_\infty \leq \frac{|p|}{2} \right\}.$$

Every  $z \in \mathcal{B}$  satisfies  $|z| \geq |p|/2$ . Define

$$(Tz)(h) = p + h \int_0^1 (1-r) \frac{g(hr)}{z(hr)} dr.$$

If  $M = \sup_{|h| \leq \delta} |g(h)|$ , then

$$\|Tz - p\|_\infty \leq \frac{\delta M}{|p|}.$$

For sufficiently small  $\delta$ ,  $T$  maps  $\mathcal{B}$  into itself. Moreover,

$$\|Tz_1 - Tz_2\|_\infty \leq \frac{2\delta M}{p^2} \|z_1 - z_2\|_\infty.$$

Again decreasing  $\delta$ , this is a strict contraction. Hence  $T$  has a unique fixed point  $z$ . Set  $y(h) = h z(h)$ . The integral equation becomes

$$y(h) = p h + \int_0^h (h-s) \frac{g(s)}{z(s)} ds.$$



The integrand is continuous, so  $y \in C^2$  and

$$y''(h) = \frac{g(h)}{z(h)}.$$

Therefore

$$y(h)y''(h) = hz(h)\frac{g(h)}{z(h)} = hg(h) = f(h).$$

Finally,

$$y''(0) = \frac{g(0)}{p}.$$

Uniqueness follows from uniqueness of the fixed point.  $\square$  Thus simple zeros are completely understood.

4.3 Complete characterization of nondegenerate tangent zeros Theorem 4  
Let  $f$  be defined near  $c$ . There is a local classical solution satisfying

$$y(c) = y'(c) = 0, \quad y''(c) \neq 0$$

if and only if

$$\boxed{\frac{f(c+h)}{h^2}}$$

extends continuously to  $h = 0$  with a strictly positive value

$$A > 0.$$

When this holds, there are exactly two local solutions with a nondegenerate tangent zero at  $c$ . They satisfy respectively

$$\boxed{y''(c) = +\sqrt{2A} \quad \text{and} \quad y''(c) = -\sqrt{2A}.}$$

Proof Necessity follows from

$$\frac{f(c+h)}{h^2} \longrightarrow \frac{1}{2}y''(c)^2.$$

For sufficiency and uniqueness, translate  $c$  to 0 and write

$$f(h) = h^2g(h), \quad g(0) = A > 0.$$

Choose

$$B = \pm \sqrt{\frac{A}{2}}.$$

We seek a solution of the form

$$y(h) = h^2 z(h), \quad z(h) \longrightarrow B.$$

It suffices first to work on  $h > 0$ . Put

$$h = e^{-t}, \quad Z(t) = z(e^{-t}), \quad G(t) = g(e^{-t}).$$

Then  $t \rightarrow +\infty$  corresponds to  $h \rightarrow 0^+$ . A direct calculation gives

$$y'' = Z'' - 3Z' + 2Z,$$

where primes now denote  $t$ -derivatives. The equation becomes

$$Z(Z'' - 3Z' + 2Z) = G(t).$$

Write

$$Z = B + w.$$

Because  $A = 2B^2$ , the equation is

$$w'' - 3w' + 4w = H(t, w),$$

where

$$H(t, \xi) = \frac{G(t)}{B + \xi} - 2B + 2\xi.$$

As  $t \rightarrow \infty$ ,

$$H(t, 0) \rightarrow 0, \quad \partial_\xi H(t, 0) = -\frac{G(t)}{B^2} + 2 \rightarrow 0.$$

Let

$$\omega = \frac{\sqrt{7}}{2}, \quad K(r) = \frac{1}{\omega} e^{-3r/2} \sin(\omega r), \quad r \geq 0.$$

For a continuous function  $R$  tending to 0, the unique solution tending to 0 at  $+\infty$  of

$$w'' - 3w' + 4w = R$$

is

$$w(t) = \int_0^\infty K(r)R(t+r) dr.$$

Consider the Banach space  $C_0([T, \infty))$  of continuous functions tending to 0, with the supremum norm, and define

$$(\mathcal{T}w)(t) = \int_0^\infty K(r)H(t+r, w(t+r)) dr.$$

Since  $H(t, 0) \rightarrow 0$  and its derivative with respect to its second variable tends uniformly to 0 near  $\xi = 0$ , one may choose  $T$  large and a small ball

$$\|w\|_\infty \leq \rho < \frac{|B|}{2}$$

such that  $\mathcal{T}$  maps this ball into itself and is a strict contraction. Therefore there is a unique  $w \in C_0([T, \infty))$  solving the equation. Returning to  $h = e^{-t}$  gives a unique right-hand solution with

$$\frac{y(h)}{h^2} \rightarrow B.$$

The same argument applied to  $f(-h)$  gives the unique left-hand solution. They glue in  $C^2$  at 0, because

$$y(0) = y'(0) = 0, \quad y''(0) = 2B = \pm\sqrt{2A}.$$

Conversely, any solution with this second derivative gives  $Z(t) \rightarrow B$  and  $Z'(t) \rightarrow 0$ ; variation of constants forces it to satisfy the same fixed-point equation, so uniqueness follows from the contraction.  $\square$  For example, when  $f(x) = x^2$ , the two tangent solutions are

$$y(x) = \pm \frac{x^2}{\sqrt{2}}.$$

4.4 Degenerate zeros The remaining case is

$$y(c) = y'(c) = y''(c) = 0.$$

Necessarily

$$f(c+h) = o(h^2),$$

but no finite-order jet condition can classify all such solutions. For instance, with

$$\phi(x) = \begin{cases} e^{-1/x^2}, & x \neq 0, \\ 0, & x = 0, \end{cases}$$

the function  $\phi$  is  $C^\infty$  and flat at 0. Taking

$$f = \phi\phi'',$$

both  $\phi$  and various sign-gluing of  $\phi$  provide solutions with a completely flat zero. Thus the degenerate case genuinely contains arbitrary smooth flat behavior.

#### 1. Finite endpoints of zero-free branches

Let  $y$  be a maximal zero-free branch on an interval ending at a finite point  $c$ , and put

$$u = |y| > 0.$$

Then

$$u u'' = f.$$

5.1 Positive limiting forcing repels the solution from zero Theorem 5 If

$$f(c) > 0,$$

then  $c$  cannot be a finite endpoint of a maximal zero-free branch. Consequently, if

$$f(x) > 0 \quad (x \in I),$$

then every solution with nonzero initial value exists uniquely on all of  $I$ . In particular, if  $I = \mathbb{R}$ , every such solution is entire. Proof Suppose, for definiteness, that the branch is defined to the left of  $c$ . By continuity, for some  $m > 0$ ,

$$f(x) \geq m$$

near  $c$ . Hence

$$u'' \geq \frac{m}{u} > 0.$$

Thus  $u'$  is increasing. The continuation criterion gives

$$\liminf_{x \uparrow c} u(x) = 0.$$

If  $u' \geq 0$  somewhere sufficiently near  $c$ , monotonicity of  $u'$  would imply that  $u$  is thereafter nondecreasing and bounded away from zero. Thus  $u' < 0$  throughout a final interval. Multiplying

$$u'' \geq \frac{m}{u}$$

by the negative quantity  $u'$  reverses the inequality:

$$u' u'' \leq m \frac{u'}{u}.$$

Integration from  $x_0$  to  $x$  gives

$$\frac{1}{2} (u'(x)^2 - u'(x_0)^2) \leq m \log \frac{u(x)}{u(x_0)}.$$

The right-hand side tends to  $-\infty$  along any sequence for which  $u(x) \rightarrow 0$ , whereas the left-hand side is bounded below by  $-u'(x_0)^2/2$ , a contradiction.  $\square$  Part *a* is the special case  $f \equiv 1$ , for which the additional autonomous first integral makes the solutions explicitly computable.

5.2 Negative limiting forcing: universal collapse law Theorem 6 Suppose  $c$  is a finite right endpoint of a maximal zero-free branch and

$$f(c) = -a < 0.$$

Then

$$|y(x)| \longrightarrow 0 \quad (x \uparrow c),$$

and

$$|y(x)| \sim (c-x) \sqrt{2a \log \frac{1}{c-x}}.$$

Moreover,

$$|y'(x)| \sim \sqrt{2a \log \frac{1}{c-x}} \longrightarrow +\infty.$$

The analogous statement holds at a left endpoint. Proof Put  $u = |y| > 0$ . Near  $c$ ,

$$u'' = \frac{f(x)}{u} < 0,$$

so  $u$  is strictly concave and  $u'$  is decreasing. The continuation criterion gives  $\liminf u = 0$ . Concavity then implies that  $u$  is eventually strictly decreasing and

$$u(x) \rightarrow 0.$$

Let  $x = x(s)$  be the inverse of  $s = u(x)$  near  $s = 0$ , and define

$$p(s) = -u'(x(s)) > 0.$$

Since  $ds/dx = u' = -p$ ,

$$\frac{dp}{ds} = \frac{u''}{p}.$$

Therefore

$$\frac{d}{ds} p(s)^2 = 2u'' = \frac{2f(x(s))}{s}.$$

Fix  $s_0 > 0$ . Integration gives

$$p(s)^2 = p(s_0)^2 - 2 \int_s^{s_0} \frac{f(x(r))}{r} dr.$$

Since  $f(x(r)) \rightarrow -a$ ,

$$\boxed{p(s)^2 \sim 2a \log \frac{1}{s}}.$$

Next,

$$c - x(s) = \int_0^s \frac{dr}{p(r)}.$$

Using the preceding asymptotic,

$$c - x(s) \sim \frac{1}{\sqrt{2a}} \int_0^s \frac{dr}{\sqrt{\log(1/r)}}.$$

By l'Hôpital's rule,

$$\int_0^s \frac{dr}{\sqrt{\log(1/r)}} \sim \frac{s}{\sqrt{\log(1/s)}}.$$

Thus

$$c - x(s) \sim \frac{s}{\sqrt{2a \log(1/s)}}.$$

Taking logarithms shows

$$\log \frac{1}{s} \sim \log \frac{1}{c - x(s)}.$$

Inverting the previous relation yields

$$s \sim (c - x(s)) \sqrt{2a \log \frac{1}{c - x(s)}}.$$

Since  $s = u(x) = |y(x)|$ , this is the asserted formula. The derivative asymptotic follows from the formula for  $p(s)$ .  $\square$

5.3 The case  $f(c) = 0$  is genuinely nonuniform Neither of the previous alternatives extends to  $f(c) = 0$ . For example, for  $x < 0$ , let

$$y(x) = -x + (-x)^{3/2}.$$

Then

$$y''(x) = \frac{3}{4\sqrt{-x}}, \quad f(x) = y(x)y''(x) = \frac{3}{4}(\sqrt{-x} - x).$$

Defining  $f(0) = 0$  gives a continuous forcing, while

$$y(x) \rightarrow 0, \quad y'(x) \rightarrow -1, \quad y''(x) \rightarrow +\infty.$$

Thus the branch cannot extend as a  $C^2$  solution through 0, despite  $f(0) = 0$  and  $f \geq 0$  near 0. This shows that strict positivity in Theorem 5 is necessary.

# 1. Exhaustive global structure and failure of uniqueness at flat zeros

Let  $y \in C^2(I)$  be a solution and let

$$Z = y^{-1}(0).$$

Then  $Z$  is closed. On every connected component of  $I \setminus Z$ ,  
 $y$  has constant sign;

it is the unique regular branch determined by any one of its nonzero initial data.

Conversely, all classical solutions are obtained by choosing such regular branches on the components of  $I \setminus Z$ , setting  $y = 0$  on  $Z \subseteq f^{-1}(0)$ , and imposing  $C^2$ -matching at the boundary points. The simple and nondegenerate quadratic matching conditions are exactly those in Theorems 3 and 4. Degenerate flat zeros allow additional freedom. In particular, maximal classical continuation through a zero need not be unique. Take again

$$\phi(x) = \begin{cases} e^{-1/x^2}, & x \neq 0, \\ 0, & x = 0, \end{cases} \quad f = \phi\phi''.$$

Define

$$y_1(x) = \phi(x)$$

and

$$y_2(x) = \begin{cases} \phi(x), & x \geq 0, \\ -\phi(x), & x < 0. \end{cases}$$

All derivatives of  $\phi$  vanish at 0, so both  $y_1, y_2 \in C^\infty(\mathbb{R})$ . For  $x \neq 0$ ,

$$y_2''(x) = \operatorname{sgn}(x)\phi''(x),$$

and consequently

$$y_2 y_2'' = \phi\phi'' = f.$$

The two solutions agree on  $[0, \infty)$  but differ on  $(-\infty, 0)$ . Thus the same regular branch and the same initial data at any  $x_0 > 0$  admit two distinct entire continuations through the flat zero at 0.

#### 1. Boundary cases

$f \equiv 0$  Every classical solution of

$$yy'' = 0$$

is affine:

$$\boxed{y(x) = Ax + B.}$$

Indeed,  $y'' = 0$  wherever  $y \neq 0$ . It also vanishes on the interior of the zero set of  $y$ , and continuity of  $y''$  then implies  $y'' = 0$  at boundary points of that zero set.  $f \equiv -1$  This gives the opposite behavior from part *a*. Define



$$\Theta(q) = \sqrt{2} \int_0^q e^{-s^2} ds = \sqrt{\frac{\pi}{2}} \operatorname{erf}(q).$$

Its range is

$$\left(-\sqrt{\frac{\pi}{2}}, \sqrt{\frac{\pi}{2}}\right).$$

All maximal solutions are

$$x = \tau + a\Theta(q), \quad y = \varepsilon a e^{-q^2}, \quad q \in \mathbb{R},$$

with  $a > 0$  and  $\varepsilon = \pm 1$ . Their maximal domain is the finite interval

$$\left(\tau - a\sqrt{\frac{\pi}{2}}, \tau + a\sqrt{\frac{\pi}{2}}\right).$$

At both endpoints  $y \rightarrow 0$  and  $|y'| \rightarrow \infty$ , exactly as predicted by Theorem 6. Initial data at a zero For

$$f(x) = x^2,$$

both

$$y_+(x) = \frac{x^2}{\sqrt{2}}, \quad y_-(x) = -\frac{x^2}{\sqrt{2}}$$

satisfy the equation and have

$$y_{\pm}(0) = y'_{\pm}(0) = 0.$$

Thus the hypothesis  $y_0 \neq 0$  in the ordinary uniqueness theorem cannot be omitted.

### 1. Final classification

For part *a*, every maximal solution is entire and is given uniquely by

$$x = \tau + a\sqrt{2} \int_0^q e^{s^2} ds, \quad y = \varepsilon a e^{q^2}, \quad a > 0, \quad \tau \in \mathbb{R}, \quad \varepsilon = \pm 1.$$

For part *b*, under the natural classical interpretation  $y \in C^2$ :  $f$  must be continuous on the solution interval.

Away from zeros of  $y$ , the equation has the usual unique maximal zero-free branch for every nonzero initial value.

Zeros can occur only where  $f = 0$ .

Simple zeros are possible exactly when  $f(x)/(x - c)$  extends continuously.

Nondegenerate tangent zeros are possible exactly when  $f(x)/(x - c)^2$  extends continuously with a positive value; there are then exactly two local tangent solutions.

Degenerate flat zeros may exhibit nonunique continuation.

Between two zeros,

$$\int_a^b f = - \int_a^b y'^2 \leq 0.$$

A finite zero-free endpoint with  $f(c) > 0$  is impossible.

If  $f(c) < 0$ , the branch collapses according to

$$|y(x)| \sim |x - c| \sqrt{2|f(c)| \log \frac{1}{|x - c|}}.$$

These statements exhaust the universal structure available for an arbitrary prescribed forcing  $f$ .

**Formal verification.** Lean source; online type-check.

## 17 Question Q831

**Informal verdict.** A — Complete solution, with high confidence.

**Lean coverage.** Lean proves existence and uniqueness of the universal integer polynomial for all  $n$ ,  $m$ , and  $i$ , the root-of-unity coefficient formulas, the complete  $m=2$  family, boundary cases, Frobenius specialization, and the stated worked examples.

### 17.1 Audited informal answer

Q831 — Complete solution

1. Faithful restatement

Let  $\Sigma_1, \dots, \Sigma_n$  be the elementary symmetric polynomials in  $X_1, \dots, X_n$ . For each integer  $m \geq 2$ , express explicitly

$$\Sigma_i(X_1^m, X_2^m, \dots, X_n^m)$$

in terms of the original elementary symmetric polynomials  $\Sigma_1(X), \dots, \Sigma_n(X)$ . The PDF contains no subparts or additional hypotheses. There is no apparent typo. The only minor ambiguity is the word “explicit”; below it is answered in three strong senses: a closed coefficient formula, an integral determinant/resultant formula, and a finite partition formula. Luc Pommeret

#### 1. Notation and main theorem

Write

$$e_r = \Sigma_r(X_1, \dots, X_n), \quad e_0 = 1,$$

and set  $e_r = 0$  when  $r < 0$  or  $r > n$ . Define

$$e_i^{[m]} := \Sigma_i(X_1^m, \dots, X_n^m).$$

Thus

$$e_i^{[m]} = \sum_{1 \leq j_1 < \dots < j_i \leq n} (X_{j_1} \cdots X_{j_i})^m.$$

**Theorem** For every  $n \geq 1$ ,  $m \geq 1$ , and  $0 \leq i \leq n$ , there is a unique polynomial

$$\Phi_{m,i}^{(n)} \in \mathbb{Z}[Y_1, \dots, Y_n]$$

such that

$$e_i^{[m]} = \Phi_{m,i}^{(n)}(e_1, \dots, e_n).$$

It has the following explicit descriptions. **2.1 Root-of-unity formula** Let  $\zeta$  be any primitive  $m$ -th root of unity, and put  $Y_0 = 1$ . Then

$$\boxed{\Phi_{m,i}^{(n)}(Y_1, \dots, Y_n) = (-1)^{(m+1)i} \sum_{\substack{0 \leq k_0, \dots, k_{m-1} \leq n \\ k_0 + \dots + k_{m-1} = mi}} \zeta^{\sum_{r=0}^{m-1} r k_r} \prod_{r=0}^{m-1} Y_{k_r}.} \quad (2.1)$$

Although roots of unity occur in the displayed expression, all its coefficients are rational integers; it is independent of the chosen primitive root  $\zeta$ . Equivalently, if

$$E(z) = 1 + Y_1 z + \cdots + Y_n z^n,$$

then

$$\Phi_{m,i}^{(n)} = (-1)^{(m+1)i} [z^{mi}] \prod_{r=0}^{m-1} E(\zeta^r z). \quad (2.2)$$

2.2 Companion-matrix and resultant formulas Let

$$P_Y(Z) = Z^n - Y_1 Z^{n-1} + Y_2 Z^{n-2} - \cdots + (-1)^n Y_n,$$

and let  $C = C(Y)$  be its companion matrix:

$$C = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 & \cdots & 0 & (-1)^{n+1} Y_n \\ 1 & 0 & \cdots & 0 & (-1)^n Y_{n-1} \\ 0 & 1 & \cdots & 0 & (-1)^{n-1} Y_{n-2} \\ \vdots & & \ddots & \vdots & \vdots \\ 0 & 0 & \cdots & 1 & Y_1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Then

$$\det(TI_n - C^m) = \sum_{i=0}^n (-1)^i \Phi_{m,i}^{(n)} T^{n-i}. \quad (2.3)$$

Consequently,

$$\Phi_{m,i}^{(n)} = (-1)^i [T^{n-i}] \det(TI_n - C^m). \quad (2.4)$$

Equivalently, with the convention that the resultant of a monic polynomial  $P$  with  $G$  is the determinant of multiplication by  $G$  on the quotient by  $P$ ,

$$\text{Res}_Z(Z^n - Y_1 Z^{n-1} + \cdots + (-1)^n Y_n, T - Z^m) = \sum_{i=0}^n (-1)^i \Phi_{m,i}^{(n)} T^{n-i}. \quad (2.5)$$

This is a single integral determinant and involves neither division nor roots of unity.

### 1. Proof of the theorem

3.1 The companion-matrix identity Work first in the universal polynomial ring

$$A = \mathbb{Z}[Y_1, \dots, Y_n].$$

The matrix  $C$  is the matrix, in the basis

$$1, Z, \dots, Z^{n-1},$$

of multiplication by  $Z$  in the free  $A$ -module

$$A[Z]/(P_Y).$$

Indeed, multiplication by  $Z$  shifts the first  $n - 1$  basis vectors, while the relation

$$Z^n = Y_1 Z^{n-1} - Y_2 Z^{n-2} + \dots + (-1)^{n+1} Y_n$$

gives precisely the last column of  $C$ . Now specialize

$$Y_r = e_r(X_1, \dots, X_n).$$

Then

$$P_Y(Z) = \prod_{j=1}^n (Z - X_j).$$

Over the field  $K = \mathbb{Q}(X_1, \dots, X_n)$ , the elements  $X_1, \dots, X_n$  are pairwise distinct, and the Chinese remainder theorem gives

$$K[Z]/(P_Y) \cong \prod_{j=1}^n K, \quad f(Z) \mapsto (f(X_1), \dots, f(X_n)).$$

Under this isomorphism, multiplication by  $Z$  becomes multiplication by the diagonal matrix

$$\text{diag}(X_1, \dots, X_n).$$

Therefore multiplication by  $Z^m$  has eigenvalues

$$X_1^m, \dots, X_n^m,$$

and hence

$$\det(TI_n - C^m) = \prod_{j=1}^n (T - X_j^m).$$

Expanding the right-hand side gives

$$\prod_{j=1}^n (T - X_j^m) = \sum_{i=0}^n (-1)^i \Sigma_i(X_1^m, \dots, X_n^m) T^{n-i}.$$

Comparing coefficients proves (2.3)–(2.5), and in particular proves the existence of integral polynomials  $\Phi_{m,i}^{(n)}$ . **3.2 Uniqueness** The elementary symmetric polynomials  $e_1, \dots, e_n$  are algebraically independent over  $\mathbb{Z}$ . Here is a direct verification. Use the lexicographic order  $X_1 > \dots > X_n$ . Then

$$\text{LM}(e_r) = X_1 X_2 \cdots X_r.$$

Consequently, for  $\alpha = (\alpha_1, \dots, \alpha_n)$ ,

$$\text{LM}(e_1^{\alpha_1} \cdots e_n^{\alpha_n}) = X_1^{b_1} \cdots X_n^{b_n}, \quad b_j = \sum_{r=j}^n \alpha_r.$$

The vector  $(b_1, \dots, b_n)$  determines  $\alpha$ , since

$$\alpha_j = b_j - b_{j+1}, \quad b_{n+1} = 0.$$

Thus distinct monomials in the  $e_j$ 's have distinct leading monomials after substitution, so no nonzero polynomial in  $Y_1, \dots, Y_n$  can vanish after substituting  $Y_j = e_j$ . This proves uniqueness. **3.3 Derivation of the root-of-unity formula** We have

$$E(z) := \sum_{k=0}^n e_k z^k = \prod_{j=1}^n (1 + X_j z).$$

For a primitive  $m$ -th root  $\zeta$ ,

$$\prod_{r=0}^{m-1} (1 - \zeta^r u) = 1 - u^m.$$

Taking  $u = -zX_j$ , we obtain

$$\prod_{r=0}^{m-1} (1 + \zeta^r z X_j) = 1 - (-zX_j)^m = 1 + (-1)^{m+1} z^m X_j^m.$$

Therefore

$$\begin{aligned}
\prod_{r=0}^{m-1} E(\zeta^r z) &= \prod_{r=0}^{m-1} \prod_{j=1}^n (1 + \zeta^r z X_j) \\
&= \prod_{j=1}^n (1 + (-1)^{m+1} z^m X_j^m) \\
&= \sum_{i=0}^n (-1)^{(m+1)i} e_i^{[m]} z^{mi}.
\end{aligned}$$

Hence

$$e_i^{[m]} = (-1)^{(m+1)i} [z^{mi}] \prod_{r=0}^{m-1} E(\zeta^r z),$$

which is (2.2). Expanding each factor,

$$E(\zeta^r z) = \sum_{k=0}^n e_k \zeta^{rk} z^k,$$

gives (2.1). The left side is already known from the companion formula to be an integral polynomial in the  $e_j$ 's. By algebraic independence, the root-of-unity expression is therefore precisely the same integral polynomial  $\Phi_{m,i}^{(n)}$ . This also proves that it is independent of the chosen primitive root.

1. A formula involving only integer sums and partitions

The determinant formula is division-free. There is also a fully expanded formula through the power sums. Let

$$p_q = X_1^q + \cdots + X_n^q.$$

For  $q \geq 1$ , define the Newton polynomial

$$\boxed{N_q(Y) = \sum_{\substack{a_1, \dots, a_q \geq 0 \\ a_1 + 2a_2 + \cdots + qa_q = q}} (-1)^{q-A} \frac{q(A-1)!}{a_1! \cdots a_q!} Y_1^{a_1} \cdots Y_q^{a_q}}, \quad (4.1)$$

where

$$A = a_1 + \cdots + a_q, \quad Y_r = 0 \quad (r > n).$$

Then

$$p_q = N_q(e_1, \dots, e_n).$$

The apparently fractional coefficient in (4.1) is an integer, because

$$\frac{q(A-1)!}{a_1! \cdots a_q!} = \sum_{\substack{1 \leq s \leq q \\ a_s > 0}} s \frac{(A-1)!}{a_1! \cdots (a_s-1)! \cdots a_q!}.$$

The first Newton polynomials are

$$\begin{aligned} N_1 &= Y_1, \\ N_2 &= Y_1^2 - 2Y_2, \\ N_3 &= Y_1^3 - 3Y_1Y_2 + 3Y_3, \\ N_4 &= Y_1^4 - 4Y_1^2Y_2 + 2Y_2^2 + 4Y_1Y_3 - 4Y_4. \end{aligned}$$

Now let  $\lambda \vdash i$  be a partition of  $i$ . If  $m_r(\lambda)$  denotes the multiplicity of  $r$  in  $\lambda$ , put

$$z_\lambda = \prod_{r \geq 1} r^{m_r(\lambda)} m_r(\lambda)!.$$

Then

$$\boxed{\Phi_{m,i}^{(n)} = \sum_{\lambda \vdash i} \frac{(-1)^{i-\ell(\lambda)}}{z_\lambda} \prod_{a=1}^{\ell(\lambda)} N_{m\lambda_a}.} \quad (4.2)$$

Although rational coefficients occur termwise in (4.2), their sum is the integral polynomial given by the companion determinant. Proof All power-series calculations below are formal, in  $\mathbb{Q}[X_1, \dots, X_n][[u]]$ ; no convergence is involved. First,

$$\begin{aligned} \log \left( \sum_{r=0}^n e_r u^r \right) &= \sum_{j=1}^n \log(1 + X_j u) \\ &= \sum_{q \geq 1} \frac{(-1)^{q-1}}{q} p_q u^q. \end{aligned} \quad (4.3)$$

On the other hand,



$$\log \left( 1 + \sum_{r=1}^n e_r u^r \right) = \sum_{A \geq 1} \frac{(-1)^{A-1}}{A} \left( \sum_{r=1}^n e_r u^r \right)^A.$$

Extracting the coefficient of  $u^q$  gives exactly (4.1). Next,

$$\begin{aligned} \sum_{i=0}^n e_i^{[m]} t^i &= \prod_{j=1}^n (1 + X_j^m t) \\ &= \exp \left( \sum_{r \geq 1} \frac{(-1)^{r-1}}{r} p_{mr} t^r \right). \end{aligned} \quad (4.4)$$

Expanding the exponential and collecting terms according to partitions of  $i$  gives

$$e_i^{[m]} = \sum_{\lambda \vdash i} \frac{(-1)^{i-\ell(\lambda)}}{z_\lambda} \prod_{a=1}^{\ell(\lambda)} p_{m\lambda_a}.$$

Substituting  $p_q = N_q(e)$  proves (4.2). An equivalent recursive form is

$$\boxed{\Phi_{m,0} = 1, \quad i\Phi_{m,i} = \sum_{r=1}^i (-1)^{r-1} N_{mr} \Phi_{m,i-r}.} \quad (4.5)$$

For example,

$$\begin{aligned} \Phi_{m,1} &= N_m, \\ \Phi_{m,2} &= \frac{N_m^2 - N_{2m}}{2}, \\ \Phi_{m,3} &= \frac{N_m^3 - 3N_m N_{2m} + 2N_{3m}}{6}. \end{aligned} \quad (4.6)$$

1. Particularly simple formulas for  $m = 2$  and  $m = 3$

5.1 Squares Taking  $\zeta = -1$  in (2.2) gives

$$e_i^{[2]} = (-1)^i [z^{2i}] E(z) E(-z).$$

Thus

$$e_i^{[2]} = (-1)^i \sum_{\substack{a+b=2i \\ 0 \leq a, b \leq n}} (-1)^b e_a e_b.$$

Pairing the terms  $a = i - j$ ,  $b = i + j$  yields the especially simple identity

$$\Sigma_i(X_1^2, \dots, X_n^2) = \Sigma_i^2 + 2 \sum_{j=1}^{\min(i, n-i)} (-1)^j \Sigma_{i-j} \Sigma_{i+j}, \quad (5.1)$$

where  $\Sigma_0 = 1$ . For example,

$$\begin{aligned} \Sigma_1(X_1^2, \dots, X_n^2) &= \Sigma_1^2 - 2\Sigma_2, \\ \Sigma_2(X_1^2, \dots, X_n^2) &= \Sigma_2^2 - 2\Sigma_1\Sigma_3 + 2\Sigma_4, \\ \Sigma_3(X_1^2, \dots, X_n^2) &= \Sigma_3^2 - 2\Sigma_2\Sigma_4 + 2\Sigma_1\Sigma_5 - 2\Sigma_6. \end{aligned}$$

Terms whose indices exceed  $n$  are understood to be zero. 5.2 Cubes Let  $\omega^3 = 1$ ,  $\omega \neq 1$ . Formula (2.1) becomes

$$\Sigma_i(X_1^3, \dots, X_n^3) = \sum_{\substack{0 \leq a, b, c \leq n \\ a+b+c=3i}} \omega^{b+2c} \Sigma_a \Sigma_b \Sigma_c. \quad (5.2)$$

Grouping equal monomials gives a formula with visibly integral coefficients:

$$\begin{aligned} \Sigma_i(X_1^3, \dots, X_n^3) &= \Sigma_i^3 \\ &\quad + 3 \sum_{\substack{0 \leq a, c \leq n \\ a \neq c, 2a+c=3i}} \Sigma_a^2 \Sigma_c \\ &\quad + 6 \sum_{\substack{0 \leq a < b < c \leq n \\ a+b+c=3i \\ a \equiv b \equiv c \pmod{3}}} \Sigma_a \Sigma_b \Sigma_c \\ &\quad - 3 \sum_{\substack{0 \leq a < b < c \leq n \\ a+b+c=3i \\ \{a, b, c\} \bmod 3 = \{0, 1, 2\}}} \Sigma_a \Sigma_b \Sigma_c. \end{aligned} \quad (5.3)$$

Indeed, for a multiset  $\{a, a, c\}$  the three root-of-unity weights sum to 3. For three distinct indices whose sum is divisible by 3, their residues are either all equal, giving weight sum 6, or are 0, 1, 2, giving

$$3\omega + 3\omega^2 = -3.$$

For instance,

$$\Sigma_1(X_1^3, \dots, X_n^3) = \Sigma_1^3 - 3\Sigma_1\Sigma_2 + 3\Sigma_3.$$

For  $n = 4$ ,

$$\begin{aligned} \Sigma_2(X_1^3, \dots, X_4^3) &= \Sigma_2^3 - 3\Sigma_1\Sigma_2\Sigma_3 + 3\Sigma_1^2\Sigma_4 \\ &\quad - 3\Sigma_2\Sigma_4 + 3\Sigma_3^2. \end{aligned}$$

### 1. Boundary cases and characteristic

The formulas are universal polynomial identities over  $\mathbb{Z}$ . Consequently, they remain valid after specialization in every commutative ring, with no restriction on characteristic. Several checks follow immediately. Top elementary symmetric polynomial

$$\Sigma_n(X_1^m, \dots, X_n^m) = (X_1 \cdots X_n)^m = \Sigma_n^m.$$

Thus

$$\Phi_{m,n}^{(n)} = Y_n^m.$$

First elementary symmetric polynomial

$$\Sigma_1(X_1^m, \dots, X_n^m) = X_1^m + \cdots + X_n^m = N_m(\Sigma_1, \dots, \Sigma_n).$$

One variable For  $n = 1$ ,

$$\Phi_{m,1}^{(1)}(Y_1) = Y_1^m.$$

The omitted case  $m = 1$  The same formulas give

$$\Phi_{1,i}^{(n)} = Y_i.$$

Positive characteristic Let the coefficient ring have characteristic  $p > 0$ . For  $a \geq 0$  and  $q \geq 1$ ,

$$\Sigma_i(X_1^{p^a q}, \dots, X_n^{p^a q}) = (\Sigma_i(X_1^q, \dots, X_n^q))^{p^a}.$$

Therefore, as polynomials over  $\mathbb{F}_p$ ,

$$\boxed{\Phi_{p^a q, i}^{(n)} \equiv \left( \Phi_{q, i}^{(n)} \right)^{p^a} \pmod{p}.}$$

In particular,

$$\Phi_{p^a, i}^{(n)} \equiv Y_i^{p^a} \pmod{p}.$$

For example, in characteristic 2, formula (5.1) reduces to

$$\Sigma_i(X_1^2, \dots, X_n^2) = \Sigma_i^2,$$

as required by Frobenius. The recurrence (4.5) involves division by  $i$ , so it must not be used literally in characteristic dividing  $i$ . The companion determinant (2.4), resultant (2.5), and root-of-unity polynomial after integral simplification have no such restriction.

#### 1. Exact reproducible computation

The following SymPy code uses the division-free companion-matrix formula.

```
PythonExécuter from __future__ import annotations
from itertools import combinations import sympy as sp
def q831_polynomials(n: int, m: int): """ Return (e, Phi), where
Phi[i] = Sigma_i X_1^m, ..., X_n^m
expressed as a polynomial in e = (e1, ..., en). """ if not isinstance(n, int)
or not isinstance(m, int) or n < 1 or m < 1: raise ValueError("n and m must
be positive integers")
e = tuple(sp.Symbol(f"e{j}") for j in range(1, n + 1)) T = sp.Symbol("T")
```

### 17.2 Companion matrix of

#### 17.3 $Z^n - e_1 Z^{n-1} + e_2 Z^{n-2} - \dots + (-1)^n e_n$ .

```
C = sp.zeros(n
for r in range(n - 1): C[r + 1, r] = 1
for r in rangen: j = n - r C[r, n - 1] = (-1) ** (j - 1) * e[j - 1]
characteristic = sp.Poly( sp.expand((T * sp.eyen - C**m).det()), T, )
Phi = tuple( sp.expand( (-1) ** i
• characteristic.coeff_monomial(T ** (n - i))
) for i in range(n + 1) )
return e, Phi
def elementary(values, k: int): """Elementary symmetric polynomial of
degree k in values.""" if k == 0: return sp.Integer1
return sum( ( sp.prod(values[j] for j in subset) for subset in combinations(rangelen(values),
k) ), sp.Integer0, )
```

```

def verify_q831(n: int, m: int) -> bool: """ Independently substitute the
elementary symmetric polynomials in x_1, ..., x_n and verify every identity
symbolically. """ e, Phi = q831_polynomials(n, m) x = tuple(sp.Symbol(f"x_{j}")
for j in range(1, n + 1))
substitution = { e[j - 1]: elementary(x, j) for j in range(1, n + 1) }
xm = tuple(value**m for value in x)
return all( sp.expand( Phi[i].subssubstitution - elementary(xm, i) ) ==
0 for i in range(n + 1) )

```

#### 17.4 Example:

```

assert verify_q831(4, 3)
e, Phi = q831_polynomials(4, 3) for i, expression in enumeratePhi:
print(i, expression) For  $n = 4, m = 3$ , this returns

```

$$\begin{aligned}
\Phi_{3,0} &= 1, \\
\Phi_{3,1} &= e_1^3 - 3e_1e_2 + 3e_3, \\
\Phi_{3,2} &= e_2^3 - 3e_1e_2e_3 + 3e_1^2e_4 - 3e_2e_4 + 3e_3^2, \\
\Phi_{3,3} &= e_3^3 - 3e_2e_3e_4 + 3e_1e_4^2, \\
\Phi_{3,4} &= e_4^3.
\end{aligned}$$

Final conclusion Q831 has a complete affirmative answer. For every  $m \geq 2$  and  $1 \leq i \leq n$ , the polynomial

$$\Sigma_i(X_1^m, \dots, X_n^m)$$

is given explicitly by the root-of-unity sum (2.1), equivalently by the integral companion determinant/resultant (2.3)–(2.5), or by the finite partition expansion (4.2). All formulas are universal over  $\mathbb{Z}$ , hence valid without exception over every commutative ring and in every characteristic.

**Formal verification.** Lean source; online type-check.